

THE SHAPE LOVE TAKES

BOOK ONE

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First edition

Edited by Jesse Lemery

PROLOGUE

The Color

The house was quiet after midnight. The refrigerator hummed downstairs. Claire's white-noise machine breathed through the wall, an artificial ocean steady enough to disappear if Brooke stopped listening for it. Outside her bedroom window, a streetlight laid a pale bar across the carpet.

Brooke liked the house at this hour. Small sounds held still long enough to place. Four windows occupied her monitor.

Her editing timeline filled the bottom half of the screen. Above it sat a dispatch recording, a hospital video, and a recovery clip she had opened twenty minutes ago and still had not played.

None of the footage was hers. Normally that alone would have made her close it. People moved when they should have held the frame. They lurched toward whatever frightened them and lost the useful details at the edges. They talked over pauses that might have mattered. Brooke spent more time watching backgrounds than subjects, looking for the seam where a clip became true.

She had learned to distrust dramatic footage while editing weddings. The important moment was rarely the kiss or the speech. It was the groom checking the exit while his father talked, or a bridesmaid removing her smile the instant the photographer turned away. Brooke's clients asked her to cut those moments. They called them unflattering. She called them the part that had happened.

Tonight she had built a spreadsheet before opening the editor. Source account. Upload time. Claimed location. Earliest repost. Weather and hospital signage. Whether the clip began before the

action or conveniently at its most shocking second. Three videos had failed her checks and gone into a folder labeled UNSOURCED, separate from the ones she trusted. False things could still teach people what they wanted to believe.

For two nights, she had been finding seams everywhere.

The illness did not have a name. News stations called it a gastrointestinal outbreak. Posts called it the stomach flu, the purge, or whatever was going around. One commenter beneath a hospital video had written two words that Brooke had saved without knowing why: *the color*. She played the dispatch recording again.

Thirty-one seconds of radio traffic from two towns over. Someone who monitored emergency frequencies had uploaded it over a motionless blue screen.

A dispatcher's trained voice read an address. Behind it, a caller spoke too quickly.

She can't keep anything down. She can't keep the medicine down. It comes right back up.

The dispatcher asked what medicine she meant. The caller went silent long enough for Brooke to glance at the waveform.

The red one, the woman said. *They gave us the red one.*

Brooke had listened forty times. *The red one* still raised the hair on her arms. *She can't keep anything down* did not. Fear was like that. It picked.

She dragged the audio onto her timeline. Keeping things had become automatic after a hard drive died when she was twelve and took four months of footage with it. She could no longer remember some of what she had lost without also remembering the videos of it, which felt like proof that memory could be edited without permission.

Footage was incomplete. It showed only what entered the frame. At least it stayed incomplete in the same way every time she played it.

The hospital video had been shot from the second level of a parking structure. Chain-link divided the picture into soft diamonds. Below it, ambulances crowded an emergency entrance three deep, rear doors hanging open. The building's name was too distant to read.

A man in blue scrubs came through the sliding doors and stopped in the ambulance bay with both hands on his knees. After a moment, he straightened. He stood alone in the cold for eleven seconds before going back inside.

Brooke counted without deciding to. Timing was where people gave themselves away.

The doors opened again. White light spread across the pavement, and the pavement shone red.

Not the darkening rust of blood. This stayed bright beneath the ambulance lights, running from the entrance and collecting in the low places. It looked like the inside of a throat.

A hospital worker hurried through it and slipped. She struck the pavement, caught an ambulance bumper, and came up with one hand printed red to the wrist. She looked at her palm. Then she wiped it down the side of her scrubs and went back through the doors.

Brooke rewound the fall once. The woman did not hesitate the second time either.

A comment beneath another clip claimed hospitals had received cases of red liquid in sealed cups. The writer said patients vomited it almost as soon as they swallowed. The writer claimed to be a nurse. Brooke had no way to know whether that part was true.

The account was six years old and mostly contained houseplants, a graduation, and a gray cat asleep in increasingly impossible positions. That did not prove the writer was a nurse. It made the account harder to dismiss than one created that afternoon.

Brooke copied the comment into her source notes, then wrote beside it: *Identity not verified. Same visual reported at three locations.* She disliked the sentence because it sounded official. Official language made uncertainty seem organized.

The liquid on the pavement could have been the treatment. Similar red stains appeared in videos from three hospitals. That was a pattern, not an answer.

Brooke muted the hospital video. She sometimes edited wedding footage for gas money, and voices were often the least reliable part of a room. People said they were happy while their shoulders drew tight. They said they were fine while watching an exit.

Bodies did not know how to lie the way voices did. Without sound, she found the timing.

She pulled in two more hospital clips, one from another state and one filmed by a phone propped against a vending machine. She aligned their timestamps as closely as the posts allowed.

In the first clip, six patients along a wall stopped moving. In the second, a woman lowered a paper cup without drinking. In the third, two nurses looked toward opposite ends of a corridor. Then the patients folded forward.

Not one and then another. The movement passed through each room in a narrow wave. Shoulders tightened. Heads turned. Bodies doubled over as if something had been said that only they could hear. Her mouth had gone dry. She replayed it muted, then at half speed.

The refrigerator cycled off downstairs, leaving Claire's white noise and the faint click of Cooper's collar near the foot of the stairs. Sarah, Brooke's mother, had gone to bed hours ago after reminding her twice that it was a school night. Claire, her thirteen-year-old sister, was asleep behind the manufactured ocean.

The house sounded ordinary. Brooke let it, then opened a news tab.

The anchor spoke with the careful calm used for storms that might turn away. The lower third read *REGIONAL ILLNESS UNDER INVESTIGATION*. An official described the situation as serious but responsive to treatment. Behind him, through a window in a hospital door, someone dragged a red mop bucket across the hall.

The report was not necessarily false. The footage was not complete. Brooke could not make them occupy the same room.

She placed fifteen seconds of the broadcast above the hospital video. On one track, the official said treatment capacity remained stable. On the other, an ambulance reversed because two more blocked the bay. Brooke aligned *remained stable* with the worker slipping in the red liquid, watched once, and deleted the edit.

It was persuasive in a way she did not trust. She could make the official look like a liar without proving he had seen the ambulance bay or knew what the camera showed. Editing did not only preserve truth. It could manufacture a cleaner one.

Brooke restored the original lengths and added a note instead. Context before conclusion. She obeyed the rule more reliably with strangers than with her family.

The unplayed recovery clip waited in the fourth window. She clicked it.

A girl lay propped in a hospital bed, filmed from the doorway by an unsteady phone. She looked fifteen or sixteen. An IV ran into a hand the color of paper. Her lips were gray, and the skin beneath her eyes had sunk into bruised half-moons. Then she drank from a plastic cup. She swallowed, waited, and drank again.

The girl turned toward the phone and smiled. A woman behind the camera began crying with relief.

There she is, the woman said. *There's my girl.*

The smile looked real. Tired, but real. The girl's eyes filled when she heard her mother's voice.

Brooke understood why the comments called it a miracle.

The mother stepped partly out of the doorway to answer someone in the hall. The girl's gaze followed her. Her smile held for one second, then vanished. She pushed herself upright too quickly, pulling the IV line taut.

Mom?

The phone swung back. The woman returned to the bedside, laughing softly as she told the girl not to scare her.

The girl caught her wrist with both hands, and her face relaxed at once.

It could have been fear. After hours of vomiting and bright hospital rooms, anyone might panic when the one familiar person stepped away. The mother bent to kiss the girl's forehead. The girl's fingers remained closed around her wrist.

When a nurse asked the mother to move so she could check the IV, the girl said, very quietly, *She can stay.*

Not a question. Not anger. The same exhausted voice she had used for *Mom?*

The clip ended with the mother still beside the bed. The smile was not late or false. That would have been easier. The relief belonged to the girl completely. So did the fear when the doorway emptied.

Brooke opened the automated transcript. It had rendered *She can stay as chicken steak*. She corrected the words, added the time code, and listened with her eyes closed. The girl's voice did not contain menace. It contained the exhausted certainty of somebody asking for the only thing that still made sense.

That was why Brooke did not title the marker *behavior change*. She called it *doorway*.

Her channel dashboard remained open behind the editor. Twelve subscribers. A video about making cheap rain look convincing had seventy-three views, mostly because a teacher had shared it. Her most popular upload was Claire and Cooper destroying a paper backdrop during a camera test. Six hundred and eleven people had watched that one, and at least half the comments were about the dog.

Brooke could have assembled the outbreak clips into something frightening before morning. She knew where to put the red pavement, where to drop the sound, how long to hold on the girl's fingers before cutting to black. The fact that she could do it was the reason she did not.

She created a new sequence called SOURCES and placed each clip in full, with its original audio and the account information preserved at the start. If she ever posted anything, viewers would be able to see what she had seen and disagree with her honestly.

She also opened a blank document and typed the sentence she used whenever an idea threatened to become a conclusion too soon: *What would prove me wrong?*

If the red liquid appeared only in reposts of one hospital, the pattern failed. If ordinary fear disappeared with rest, the doorway marker meant nothing. Altered timestamps, copied captions, or separate moments cut together could explain the rest. Brooke wanted to know before she built a story around it.

She listed each possibility beneath the question. The list made the clips less frightening because it gave fear jobs to do.

Brooke dragged the clip to the end of her timeline. She labeled the project *the color*, added the date, and saved it to her main archive. Then she copied it to the backup drive beneath her desk.

Dispatcher. Red pavement. Bodies folding together. A girl's hands locked around her mother's wrist.

Brooke checked the files, checked them again, and closed the laptop.

Darkness returned to the room. The streetlight remained across the carpet. Claire's artificial ocean rolled through the wall.

Cooper was no longer resting. Brooke could not see him from her bed, but the front hall had gone too still. His tags did not move. His nails did not shift against the hardwood.

A vibration traveled up through the floor, so low she mistook it for the refrigerator starting again. Then Cooper growled. He ignored delivery drivers, passing cars, joggers, children on bicycles. Brooke had heard him bark at a squirrel once and sneeze at the vacuum cleaner. This sound belonged to neither irritation nor surprise.

She went to her bedroom door. Cooper stood at the bottom of the stairs with his head low and ears forward, his weight aimed toward the front of the house. The fur along his shoulders had lifted. He did not look back at her.

Outside, a shoe scraped along the sidewalk. One step. A pause. Another step, slower than the first.

No engine passed. No headlights moved across the wall. Something continued beyond the front windows and down the street, never entering the bar of light Brooke could see from the landing.

Cooper tracked it behind the closed door. Brooke waited for him to settle, but he did not.

CHAPTER 1

Ordinary Evidence

Claire was wearing Brooke's blue hoodie when she came into the kitchen, which meant the day had begun with theft.

It was not an ambiguous hoodie. Brooke had bought it with money from editing three hours of dance-recital footage for a woman who believed every child deserved equal screen time. There was a pale bleach mark inside the right cuff from a failed attempt to clean red nail polish off her desk.

Claire wore it unzipped over her school shirt, sleeves pulled over her hands.

Brooke raised her phone and framed the evidence. "State your name for the record."

Claire stopped beside the kitchen island. "You know my name."

"State your name and explain why you're dressed like a burglar who shops exclusively in my room."

"I was cold."

"Your closet contains fabric. I've seen it."

"Nothing warm."

Brooke zoomed in on the cuff. "Exhibit A. Permanent identifying damage."

Claire looked straight into the lens and zipped the hoodie to her chin. "I found it in the hall. Legally abandoned."

"It was on the laundry basket."

"In the hall."

"On my laundry basket."

"You should get a better lawyer."

From the stove, Sarah said, "You should both get plates."

She had made pancakes on a weekday, which usually meant one of two things: somebody had received good news, or Sarah had woken too early and decided the rest of the house should benefit from it. Her hair was clipped up badly, with one section falling against her neck. She still wore the gray sweatpants she slept in and an old college T-shirt with a hole near the hem.

Brooke turned the phone toward her. "Which one is it?"

Sarah glanced over her shoulder. "Which one is what?"

"Celebration or insomnia."

"Your father called at five-thirty."

"Insomnia," Claire said.

"He forgot I didn't need to be awake just because he did." Sarah slid a pancake onto the stack. "Then I was up."

Brooke lowered the phone a few inches. "Is everything okay?"

"Everything is fine. The job ran long."

The answer came easily enough, but Sarah pressed the spatula flat against the pan after she said it, as if the pancake required more authority than she had already applied.

Mark had been in western Pennsylvania since Monday, rewiring part of an old hotel that its owners wanted to call historic whenever the age helped them and outdated whenever it did not. He was supposed to come home Thursday. Yesterday, the return had moved to Friday night. Now, apparently, the job had run long again.

"Did he say when?" Brooke asked.

"Saturday morning, probably."

"Probably sounds official."

Sarah gave her a look. "He'll call tonight. You can interrogate him then."

Claire reached past the pancake stack. Without turning, Sarah tapped the back of Claire's hand with the spatula.

"Plate."

"That was violence."

"Tell your lawyer."

Brooke caught Claire's offended expression before it broke into a grin. She kept recording as Claire dragged a plate from the cabinet and loaded it with three pancakes, each one placed carefully enough to support her claim that she was not taking three, only building something.

Mark usually handled Saturday pancakes and treated each one as a structural problem. He made Claire's shaped like animals that became less identifiable as she grew older and more critical. Sarah made circles and expected gratitude. This morning she had used Mark's heavy cast-iron pan, the one she complained was designed for people with stronger wrists and worse judgment.

"Dad says you heat it too fast," Claire said.

"Your father isn't here to defend that opinion."

"I can call him."

"At six forty in the morning? Please do."

Claire considered the threat seriously enough to make Sarah laugh. Brooke kept the laugh in frame. Sarah's laughter had a small inhale in the middle when it surprised her. Brooke had never noticed it without headphones.

Cooper lay at the foot of the stairs where the kitchen opened toward the front hall. He had returned to his usual shape sometime before dawn, loose-limbed and mostly in the way. One ear lifted when Claire opened the silverware drawer. It dropped again when no cheese appeared.

Brooke had checked the front walk after his growling stopped. There had been nobody beneath the streetlight, no dropped package, no animal in the hedge. By the time she went upstairs, Cooper had circled twice on his bed and collapsed with the force of something unfairly burdened by comfort.

In daylight, the sound from the night had become less specific. Dogs growled. People walked past houses. A thing did not become evidence because it happened near another thing.

She moved the camera back to Claire. "Take it off before school."

"No."

"You're going to stretch it."

"We are almost the same size."

"That is an insult to both of us."

Claire poured syrup over the pancake tower. "Film this."

"I am filming it."

"No, get close. It's going to do the thing."

The top pancake shifted. Syrup found the edge, gathered itself, and spilled down all three layers in one glossy line. Brooke stepped closer without meaning to. Claire leaned out of the light.

“Back,” Brooke said.

“I’m not in it.”

“Your shadow is.”

Claire moved back. Brooke tapped the screen to hold focus on the syrup.

“This is why nobody eats with you,” Claire said.

“I’m standing in a room with two people.”

“You’re standing near people. That’s different.”

Brooke stopped recording. Claire had already begun cutting into the stack and did not appear to know she had said anything worth keeping. Sarah set a plate on the island in front of Brooke, two pancakes with crisp edges and a small amount of syrup because she remembered Brooke hated when they turned soft.

“Sit,” Sarah said.

“I have to get dressed.”

“You have ten minutes.”

“Nine,” Claire said around a bite.

“You stole my clothes, not my ability to read time.”

Brooke took the plate with her upstairs. Her room looked better through a lens. In person, cables showed beneath the editing desk no matter how many times she tied them together. Memory-card cases leaned against the monitor. Two camera batteries charged beside a chipped mug full of pens and one screwdriver she kept forgetting to return to the garage.

Brooke set her plate beside the keyboard and checked the files she had saved overnight. They were still there.

The folder called *the color* sat between a client project and footage from last summer. She did not open it. School started in twenty-seven minutes, and there were limits to how much hospital pavement a person should see before first period.

She connected her phone instead and transferred the kitchen video.

The transfer software created a thumbnail of Claire with the hoodie zipped over her mouth. Brooke dragged the clip into a family project she had been building without telling anyone. It had no clear purpose. Pancakes, Cooper sleeping through a thunderstorm, Mark replacing a porch light while Claire supplied incorrect electrical advice, Sarah singing half a line of a song and

stopping when she noticed the camera. Ordinary footage accumulated faster than Brooke could justify it.

She told herself it was practice. Continuity. Color correction under bad kitchen lights. The truth was less technical. Families changed in ways nobody marked. A voice lowered. A favorite mug disappeared. Somebody stopped sitting in the same chair. By the time anyone noticed, the old version existed only in claims nobody remembered making.

Brooke set an in point before Claire entered the kitchen and an out point after Sarah laughed. She did not trim the empty second at the beginning. The empty room established what changed when Claire arrived.

The clip began with Claire entering in the stolen hoodie. Brooke scrubbed past her own mock-serious interrogation, past Sarah at the stove, and stopped on a frame she had not intended to catch. Sarah stood in profile behind Claire, looking down at her phone. Whatever message was on the screen had tightened her mouth.

One frame later, she had looked up and smiled at them.

Brooke backed up. Sarah's mouth tight. Claire saying *legally abandoned*. Sarah looking up. The smile. It was not fake. That was the lazy word people used when a camera caught the transition into an expression. Sarah had been worried and then had decided not to bring the worry into breakfast. Both things were true. The cut between them was only visible because Brooke could move backward.

She saved the clip under FAMILY instead of deleting it.

From the hall, Claire shouted, "Mom says we're leaving!"

"Then leave."

"She says you also live here!"

Brooke looked at her untouched pancakes, picked up the plate, and took one bite standing over the desk. They were already cold.

Downstairs, Sarah waited by the front door with her purse over one shoulder and travel mug in hand. Her first work call started after the school run. Claire had added Brooke's black knit hat to the hoodie.

"Absolutely not," Brooke said.

Claire pulled the hat lower. "I can't hear you."

"That's because it's covering the listening part of your brain."

Sarah opened the door. "Car. Now. Both of you."

Cooper lifted his head from the bottom stair. For a moment he looked past Sarah toward the street, body still beneath the warm square of sunlight from the glass.

Brooke watched him. His tail struck the floor once. Then he sneezed and lowered his head again. Nothing.

Outside, Ashcroft looked offensively normal. A sprinkler clicked across the Dunns' lawn despite the cold. A school bus sighed at the corner. Two houses down, Mr. Kessler dragged a recycling bin toward his garage in plaid pajama pants, pausing to raise one hand at Sarah.

Sarah waved back. Brooke checked the sidewalk in both directions. She did not know what she expected to find. A red trail would have been ridiculous. A stranger standing beneath the streetlight in daylight would have been worse.

There was only a damp patch of concrete where somebody's sprinkler had reached too far.

Claire bumped Brooke's shoulder on the way to the car. "You coming?"

"Give me my hat."

By lunch, the overnight outbreak had acquired three new expert interviews and a rumor that Ashcroft High would close on Monday. Beneath the cafeteria's flickering blue menu board, Nora Patel said the red medicine was an experimental antiviral. A boy behind her said his cousin's roommate worked at Saint Vincent's and the emergency room was empty. Before Nora could answer, he added that the National Guard had taken over the hospital.

Nora had been in Brooke's media class the previous year and still asked for help when an export failed. She slid her phone across the table now, showing a vertical video of uniformed people unloading boxes.

"That's not Saint Vincent's," Brooke said.

"How can you tell?"

"The ambulance logo. And the building has brick around the doors. Saint Vincent's is glass."

Nora enlarged the frame until the image broke into squares. "So where is it?"

"I don't know."

The boy behind her leaned closer. "Then it could be Saint Vincent's."

“That isn’t how locations work.”

Nora took back the phone. “Can you check it? Like reverse search it or whatever?”

Brooke almost said yes. The request produced a familiar spark, the pleasure of being useful because she noticed what other people missed. Then she imagined spending lunch proving one video false only to have another replace it by final bell.

“Send it to me,” she said.

She saved the clip beneath UNSOURCED before eating anything.

The principal disproved the closure rumor over the intercom before final bell. Nobody sounded convinced.

Brooke did not mention the clips. Everybody else had already decided what they meant.

Brooke kept her phone facedown and thought about the girl gripping her mother’s wrist.

Sarah texted at three-sixteen that she was stuck on a work call and the girls should walk home together.

Claire appeared beside Brooke’s locker at three-twenty wearing the hoodie, the hat, and an expression of personal sacrifice.

“Mom says I’m not allowed to walk alone.”

“Mom says lots of things when she isn’t here to enforce them.”

“She said you’d say that.”

Brooke shut her locker. “Did she also predict the part where I leave you to be raised by crossing guards?”

“She said if you ditched me, I should call her.”

“You two have built an efficient police state.”

Claire smiled and started toward the exit, apparently certain Brooke would follow. She did.

The quickest route home cut behind the athletic fields, through a narrow path between two developments, then along Hawthorne Road. Claire narrated most of it without requiring an audience. Her science teacher had worn two different shoes. Someone named Lila had cried in the bathroom and refused to explain why. The cafeteria pizza had achieved a texture Claire believed violated federal law.

At the edge of the athletic field, Claire stopped to retie a shoe that was not untied. Brooke waited while the soccer team ran drills under lights that had come on too early in the gray afternoon.

“Are you going to film school somewhere far away?” Claire asked.

Brooke lowered the phone. “That was random.”

“Mom said the workshop would look good on applications.”

“New Haven isn’t far away.”

“I meant later. College.”

Brooke looked toward the path home. “If somebody lets me in.”

Claire pulled the lace tighter. “You could make movies here.”

“About what? Mr. Kessler’s recycling bin?”

“You film pancakes.”

It was meant as an insult, but Brooke heard the question beneath it. Claire was thirteen. A year was a country. Two years was disappearance.

“You’d get my room,” Brooke said.

“I don’t want your room. The light is bad.”

“The light is excellent.”

Claire stood. “Then I want it.”

The conversation moved on because that was how most important conversations ended in their family. Somebody made the last true thing into a joke.

Brooke filmed ten seconds of her walking backward along the path.

“Tell me about the shoes again.”

Claire looked at the phone. “Why?”

“I missed the beginning.”

“You weren’t listening.”

“I was listening badly. Do it again.”

Claire did, adding an impression of the teacher that was probably inaccurate and definitely cruel. She stepped into a patch of sun through the trees at exactly the right point in the story. Brooke let the shot run.

At home, Claire reached the front step first. She tried the handle.

“Locked,” she said.

“Astute.”

Brooke kept filming while Claire shielded the keypad with one hand and entered the code with the other.

“Don’t film the code.”

“Your hand is in the way.”

“It can see around hands.”

“That’s not how cameras work.”

“That’s exactly what a camera would want me to think.”

The lock clicked. Claire pushed inside and called Cooper’s name in the voice she used as if returning from war. His nails skittered across the hardwood. He met her in the foyer with a full-body wag, pressing his head into the stolen hoodie while she dropped to hug him.

Brooke stayed on the step and held the frame.

The shot included Claire and Cooper, the narrow living-room wall crowded with family photographs, and the small keypad at the edge of the open door. Its buttons flashed blue behind Claire’s hand as she entered the code. One picture showed all four Bennetts at the beach when Claire was six and Brooke was ten. Claire had buried Brooke’s legs to the knees and decorated the sand with shells. In the photograph, Brooke was laughing hard enough to show the gap where she had lost a tooth.

She barely remembered the missing tooth. She remembered the grit inside her swimsuit for the drive home, Claire asleep against her arm, and Mark carrying both their plastic buckets because neither girl would agree to leave one behind.

The video held what memory had dropped: Mark behind the camera asking who had stolen his legs, Sarah’s shadow across the sand, Claire patting the mound around Brooke’s knees and announcing that she lived there now.

“Are you coming in?” Claire asked.

Brooke lowered the phone. Claire remained on the floor with both arms around Cooper. His chin rested on her shoulder. The hoodie bunched across her back, one sleeve already marked with a dark smear from his nose.

“You got dog on it,” Brooke said.

“He lives here. You don’t.”

Claire squeezed Cooper once more, then stood. “I’m making popcorn.”

“It’s four o’clock.”

“That’s when popcorn happens.”

“Dinner happens at six.”

“Separate event.”

She headed toward the kitchen, Cooper following close enough to nose the backs of her knees.

Brooke looked at the phone in her hand. The frame had been good. Claire in the doorway, Cooper crossing into the light, the beach photograph behind them. Ordinary pieces arranged cleanly enough to look intentional.

From the kitchen came the cabinet door, Claire's voice asking Cooper whether he preferred butter or extra butter, and Sarah's work-call voice drifting faintly through the ceiling from her bedroom office.

Brooke could go in. She could take back the hoodie, eat popcorn, and listen to Claire explain the moral failure of plain butter. None of it required preserving first.

Instead she sat on the front step and replayed the clip.

Claire's palm had hidden her fingers. At the edge of the frame, thin blue halos marked where each one landed. Most of it. Brooke was already listening to Claire complain about the popcorn when the flashes passed.

Claire called from the kitchen that the popcorn smelled weird. Cooper barked once at the microwave. Brooke went inside, and that evening the doorway clip joined six other ordinary pieces in the short video she uploaded under her own name.

CHAPTER 2

Permission

The cancellation arrived at 6:42 Thursday morning and thanked Brooke for a decision she had not made. She read it twice before getting out of bed.

ASHCROFT YOUTH FILM COLLABORATIVE Registration Withdrawal Confirmed

Hi Brooke,

This message confirms that your registration for Saturday's Student Film Intensive has been withdrawn at your parent or guardian's request. Your seat has been released to the waiting list. We hope you can join us for a future program.

The rest was a refund policy and a signature from someone named Celia who wished her all the best.

Brooke pressed the phone to her blanket as if covering the screen could restore her place.

The workshop was not a summer camp or a school club pretending phones made everyone a director. It was six hours at the Harlan Media Center in New Haven with working filmmakers and equipment Ashcroft High did not own. Twenty-four students had been accepted. Brooke had spent four nights cutting her two-minute application film.

The film followed a crossing guard named Mr. Alvarez through one winter morning. No music. No interview. Just boots in gray snow, children arriving in bursts, and Mr. Alvarez learning which drivers would stop only after he stepped into the road. Brooke had filmed from across the street for three days until he stopped

performing kindness for the camera and returned to the smaller gestures that interested her: warming a child's dropped mitten beneath his coat, checking an empty intersection twice, waving to a bus driver who never waved back.

The acceptance email praised her "observational patience." Brooke had read that phrase enough times to distrust it and still wanted it printed on something permanent.

Sarah had watched the finished application at the kitchen island. She had cried at the wrong part, denied crying, then paid the registration fee before Brooke could talk herself out of going. Now Brooke opened the message details.

The withdrawal request had come from Sarah's email at 9:18 the previous night, while Brooke was upstairs editing and Sarah was reminding Claire to take her shower.

Brooke took a screenshot, then another with the sender information expanded. Evidence did not improve with quantity, but anger did.

Across the hall, Claire's alarm began playing the first eight seconds of a pop song before she silenced it. Pipes knocked inside the wall. Downstairs, a cabinet opened and shut. The house had started without Brooke.

She got dressed, tucked the phone into her pocket, and carried the workshop email downstairs.

Sarah stood at the counter packing lunches. No pancakes today. Two slices of bread lay open beside a jar of peanut butter, and the television murmured from the living room about increased emergency-department traffic across the state. Sarah had turned the volume low enough that the anchors sounded apologetic.

Claire sat at the island in Brooke's hoodie again, picking raisins out of a bowl of cereal and lining them along a napkin. Cooper waited beneath her stool, prepared to resolve the dispute.

"Those are the only part with nutritional value," Sarah said.

"They're wet," Claire said.

"They were dry when I bought them. You did this."

Brooke placed her phone on the counter in front of Sarah.

Sarah looked at the screen. Her hands stopped above the sandwich. That was enough for Brooke. "You canceled it," she said. Claire ate one of the raisins.

Sarah folded the bread together and pressed her palm over it. "I was going to talk to you this morning."

"You talked to them first."

"Brooke."

"Did you think I wouldn't get an email?"

"Of course I knew you'd get an email. I thought I would have a chance to explain before you saw it."

"You sent it nine hours ago." Sarah's eyes flicked toward Claire. Claire lowered her spoon. "I can go away."

"Eat your breakfast," Sarah said.

"I can do both."

She lifted the bowl and slid off the stool. Cooper followed her toward the living room, watching the milk tip dangerously close to the rim.

Brooke waited until Claire disappeared around the corner.

"Explain."

Sarah put the knife in the sink. She rinsed it though nothing remained on the blade.

"Your dad isn't coming home tomorrow."

"I know."

"The hotel added another floor to the inspection. He doesn't know when they'll release his crew."

"What does that have to do with Saturday?"

"It means he's not here. The program paused its carpool list because people are getting sick. I am not putting you on a train by yourself, they won't let Claire stay through the sessions, and Mrs. Dunn isn't comfortable having her all day now."

"Why wouldn't she be?"

Sarah looked toward the television. The anchor had been replaced by footage of cars waiting outside a hospital entrance. A bright banner beneath them read *STATE MONITORING STOMACH ILLNESS*.

"People are getting sick," Sarah said.

"People are always getting sick."

"Not like this."

The certainty in her voice surprised Brooke. "Yesterday you said everything was fine."

"Yesterday I said your father was fine." It was an answer built to survive inspection.

Sarah reached for the remote and muted the television. “The reports got worse overnight. New Haven has cases. Hartford has cases. Saint Vincent’s put out a notice asking people not to come in unless they can’t keep fluids down. We don’t know what this is yet.”

“The workshop isn’t at a hospital.”

“I understand that.”

“Do you? Because you seem confused about what I registered for.”

Sarah leaned both hands against the counter. “I am not sending you into a city for an optional workshop while your father is away and hospitals are filling up.”

“Sending me? I’m not eight.”

“You’re seventeen.”

“Exactly.”

“That is not the argument you think it is.”

Brooke picked up the phone. The email was still open between them, bright and bloodless. “You could have asked me.”

“And you would have said no.”

“Then at least I would have been part of the decision.”

Sarah’s face softened, which made Brooke angrier than if she had shouted. “This isn’t a decision I can hand you when I don’t think it’s safe.”

“I had a plan.”

“A train is not a plan.”

“The seven-twelve to Union Station, the shuttle from the west entrance, check-in at nine-thirty. I sent you all of it.”

“And if the shuttle stops running? If they cancel the return train? If you get sick?”

“I call you.”

“From an hour away while I have Claire here and your father is several states away.”

“You keep saying where everybody else is like that makes me less capable.”

Sarah’s fingers tightened against the counter. “I am saying I cannot be in three places. That is not an opinion about your capability.”

Brooke heard the exhaustion in it and refused to let it change the argument. Sarah was always tired when she made decisions for

everyone. If exhaustion excused the decisions, it would excuse them forever.

"You handed it to yourself."

"I'm your mother. Sometimes that is my job."

From the living room came the soft scrape of Claire's spoon and a commercial promising that families could save twenty percent by switching mobile plans together.

Brooke lowered her voice. "You don't do this to her."

Sarah glanced toward the doorway. "Do what?"

"Decide who she is allowed to be before she gets a chance."

"Claire is thirteen. I decide most of what she's allowed to do."

"That's not what I mean."

"Then tell me what you mean."

Brooke knew. The answer had lived in the house for years without anyone agreeing to name it. Sarah checked Brooke's location when she went out. She asked for the address, the parents' names, the time Brooke would leave, the time she would return, and a text when she arrived. Claire could cross two backyards to a friend's house with one shouted sentence over her shoulder. Age and distance explained some of it. They did not change how it felt.

"You trust her," Brooke said.

"This has nothing to do with Claire."

"It always has something to do with Claire."

Sarah went very still. "You think I treat her differently."

It was not a question. Brooke heard how long Sarah had been waiting for the accusation.

"I think you look at her and know she belongs here."

Sarah's expression changed, not into anger at first. Hurt came before it, clean enough that Brooke almost stopped.

"I have never looked at you as anything but my daughter."

"That's not the same thing."

"It is exactly the same thing."

"Not to you."

Sarah stepped back from the counter. "Do not tell me what you are to me."

The sentence struck harder because Sarah did not raise her voice.

Brooke could have apologized. She could have said that wanting to know why one woman had left did not erase the woman

who stayed. She had tried to explain that before, but the words always made Sarah listen for a contest Brooke had not started.

Instead she looked at the cancellation email and saw her empty seat offered to somebody on a waiting list.

"You don't get to keep me forever just because she didn't."

The refrigerator motor turned on. In the living room, the cereal bowl met the coffee table with a small ceramic knock.

Sarah's mouth opened. Nothing came out. For one terrible second, Brooke felt the satisfaction of having found the exact place to hurt.

Sarah picked up the two lunch bags. She folded the tops once, then again, making the creases hard beneath her thumbs.

"We need to leave in six minutes," she said.

"Mom, I didn't mean it like that."

Sarah put Claire's lunch beside Brooke's. "How did you mean it?"

Brooke had no version that would make the sentence harmless. "I meant you can't make every choice for me."

"Then that is what you should have said."

Claire appeared in the doorway holding her empty bowl. Her gaze moved from Sarah to Brooke and stayed there.

"Are we still going to school?"

"Yes," Sarah said.

Sarah took her keys from the hook. "Shoes. Both of you."

On the drive, Claire sat in the back with Cooper's hair stuck to the sleeve of Brooke's hoodie. She talked about a history quiz, stopped after two sentences, and turned to the window.

Sarah drove with both hands on the wheel. The radio reported twenty-seven confirmed hospitalizations statewide, then corrected itself to thirty-one before the traffic update. Officials urged people with symptoms to stay home, drink clear fluids, and contact a medical provider if they became severely dehydrated.

At a red light, Sarah reached for the volume and turned it down. Brooke watched her hand return to the wheel. The camera in her bag stayed there.

At school, the workshop email remained unread in Brooke's notifications even though she had opened it four times. She kept swiping it away. It returned whenever she checked the time.

At lunch, Nora Patel asked whether Brooke was still going Saturday. Brooke said the program had canceled. The lie came out flat and easy.

"Because of the outbreak?" Nora asked.

"Probably."

Brooke hated Sarah for making the lie necessary. She hated herself for choosing it.

After final bell, Brooke waited beside Claire's locker beneath a speaker that clicked with half-finished dismissal announcements. Claire arrived with her backpack open and two pencils caught in her hair.

"Mom's outside," she said.

"I can see that."

Through the front doors, Sarah's car waited at the curb. Sarah looked down at her phone, then toward the entrance. Even through the glass, Brooke could tell she was counting the seconds.

"Are you mad at me?" Claire asked.

"Why would I be mad at you?"

Claire shrugged. "You made it about me."

Brooke looked at the hoodie. "I made it about Mom."

"You said my name a lot for something about Mom."

"Give me my hoodie."

Claire crossed her arms. "It's cold."

Brooke almost told her she had other clothes. The argument from yesterday sat ready, familiar and safe.

"Keep it," she said.

Claire studied her as if this might be a trap. Then she zipped the hoodie higher and started toward the doors.

Sarah did not mention the workshop in the car. At home she carried groceries into the kitchen and began wiping down containers before putting them away, something she had never done before. When Claire asked why, Sarah said there were a lot of germs going around. Brooke went upstairs.

An hour later, Sarah knocked once and entered with the refunded workshop fee displayed on a bank notification as if it were a document requiring Brooke's approval.

"The money is back," she said.

Brooke kept her eyes on the monitor. "Congratulations."

Sarah placed the phone on the desk. "I emailed Celia. If they reschedule, she will contact you before reopening registration."

"That fixes it."

"No. It is the thing I can fix."

Brooke turned then. Sarah had changed out of her work blouse but still wore the black pants, wrinkled behind the knees. She looked older than she had at breakfast, though nothing visible had happened except a grocery trip and a full day of calls.

"Why are you more afraid for me than for Claire?" Brooke asked.

Sarah sat on the edge of the bed without being invited. "I am afraid for both of you in different ways."

"Because she's yours."

Sarah flinched. "You are mine."

"That's what you always say when I ask something else."

"Because the something else is built on a lie."

Brooke wanted Sarah to say she checked Brooke's location because adoption had taught her people could vanish. She wanted the ugly explanation because then the difference would be real and not something Brooke created from every locked door and repeated question.

Sarah rubbed both hands over her face. "When Claire is reckless, I know the exact kind of reckless she is. I watched it develop one bad idea at a time. You think before you do things. Then you make a plan and tell me after the part where I could object. That scares me more, Brooke. It has nothing to do with who gave birth to you."

The answer was reasonable. Brooke hated it for not resolving anything.

Sarah stood. At the door she said, "I am sorry I did not talk to you first. I am not sorry I kept you home. Both can be true."

After she left, Brooke recorded the empty doorway for eleven seconds before realizing the camera was on.

The cancellation email looked different on her monitor. Larger, not more meaningful. She saved a copy in a folder with the workshop application, her acceptance, and the two-minute film that had earned the seat. Then she opened her messages with Mark. His last text had arrived at 5:37 that morning.

Another day in the glamorous old hotel. Call tonight. Proud of you, kid. Brooke typed beneath it.

Mom canceled the workshop without asking me. She says it's because you're gone and people are sick, but that's not all of it. She thinks if she watches me closely enough nothing can happen. I said something awful. She stopped. The cursor waited after the period.

If she sent it, Mark would call Sarah and referee from a hotel in western Pennsylvania. Brooke did not want his balanced answer again.

Brooke selected the message and copied it into a blank note instead.

She did not delete it. Deleting and deciding not to send were different things.

Downstairs, a cupboard closed. Water ran. Sarah called to Claire that dinner would be ready in twenty minutes. Her voice sounded ordinary again, which meant she had chosen ordinary and expected the rest of them to follow.

Brooke filed the cancellation beside the acceptance letter and her application film. When she finished, the room had darkened around the monitor. A local-news alert appeared across the corner of the display.

SAINT VINCENT'S EXPANDS INTAKE AREA AMID SURGE

Brooke opened it. The article said the hospital remained fully operational, most patients were expected to recover, and temporary outdoor screening would reduce pressure on the emergency department. Below it, workers unfolded white privacy screens beside the ambulance entrance.

Brooke saved the alert in a separate folder bearing the same date as the cancellation. The two documents remained open on her monitor.

CHAPTER 3

Sisters

By Friday morning, Sarah had become professionally polite.

She asked Brooke whether she wanted toast. She reminded Claire about her library book. She said Mark expected to call before dinner, though the hotel inspection was still running late. Every sentence performed its assigned task and ended before it could become anything else.

Brooke answered in the same language. No, thank you. Yes, she had her charger. She would be home after school. The words passed between them without touching the workshop, the cancellation, or the sentence Brooke had spent most of the night hearing in her own voice.

Claire watched from the kitchen table with the absorbed expression she usually reserved for people fighting in public.

“What?” Brooke asked.

“Nothing.”

“Your face is doing something.”

“It’s eating toast.”

Sarah set her mug in the sink. “Can we have one morning without an investigation?”

Brooke looked at her. Sarah was already rinsing the cup, shoulders angled away. “Apparently decisions are easier when nobody asks questions.”

The water stopped. Claire put down her toast.

Sarah dried her hands with careful attention to each finger. “Car in five minutes.”

That was all. She took her work bag into the hall, and Claire waited until the front door opened before whispering, “Good job. Very normal.”

“Eat your face.”

“That doesn’t mean anything.”

“It means stop using it at me.”

Claire finished the toast in two bites and followed Sarah outside. She was still wearing Brooke’s blue hoodie.

At school, the outbreak had become ordinary enough to schedule around. The nurse’s office sent an email asking families to report gastrointestinal symptoms before sending students in. Two teachers kept bottles of disinfectant beside their classroom doors. The principal repeated that Ashcroft High remained open, then asked everyone to respect classmates who might be anxious about inaccurate social-media reports.

It was not quite the school it had been on Monday. Two desks in first period stayed empty all morning, and one in chemistry, and a scatter of others across the day that the teachers worked around without comment. Absence was ordinary during a stomach bug. The unusual part was the care everyone took not to count, the way the roll was read now with certain names skipped so smoothly that skipping them had clearly been decided somewhere above the teachers.

Brooke heard three people repeat *inaccurate social-media reports* before lunch. None of them knew which reports were inaccurate.

She saved the nurse’s email and a screenshot of the district notice. During study hall, she opened the folder called *the color* and built a sequence from the clips she had collected: the red pavement, the synchronized movement in hospital corridors, the recovering girl tightening both hands around her mother’s wrist, and the white intake screens outside Saint Vincent’s.

Mr. Larkin had given Brooke a key to the audiovisual room after she repaired two microphone cables the district had planned to replace. The room smelled of dust warmed by old equipment. A row of cameras sat in a locked cabinet, each one older than Brooke but better balanced than her phone. She used the school’s sound blanket, clipped it behind the desk, and listened to the room through headphones.

The first narration sounded excited. Brooke deleted it. The second sounded frightened, which was closer to honest but made every image seem guilty before it appeared. On the third attempt she left space between statements. Uncertainty required room. If she filled every pause, viewers would hear confidence she did not have.

Brooke recorded narration in the empty audiovisual room, keeping her voice low because the walls were thinner than they looked.

"This started showing up three nights ago. I don't know if the red liquid is medicine or something else, and I don't know whether it matters. Hospitals in at least four states are using it. The people in these clips seem to recover quickly, but the reports don't agree about how sick they were first. I'm saving the sources in the description. If anything gets corrected, I'll update it."

She stopped there. No warning. No theory. She titled the upload *Something's going around* and posted it under Brooke Bennett.

Before publishing, she checked the source links twice and blurred a patient's face the original account had left visible. She removed six frames of the red spill because they made the thumbnail more compelling than the information justified. The final thumbnail showed the white paper cup against a hospital wall. It was less dramatic. Brooke trusted it more.

By final bell, one comment said *dramatic much*. Another asked whether the red liquid was fruit punch. Brooke did not reply.

Nora found her outside the audiovisual room and asked why Brooke had not used music.

"Because it isn't a trailer," Brooke said.

"Everything online is a trailer for something."

"That's depressing."

Nora refreshed the page. "You have twenty-one views."

"I had twelve subscribers this morning."

"Congratulations on terrifying nine strangers."

The joke was not cruel. Nora said it with the same mild respect she used when Brooke fixed corrupted project files. Brooke almost asked whether she wanted to help with the next upload. The impulse passed before it became speech. Collaboration meant explaining why each cut mattered. It meant letting somebody else

see the uncertainty before Brooke had shaped it into something defensible.

“There isn’t a next upload,” she said.

Nora looked at the source folder still open on the computer behind her. “Sure.”

Sarah texted that her last meeting would run late and told Brooke to make sure Claire came straight home. The message included a heart at the end, the same one Sarah used after reminders about dentist appointments and laundry. Brooke stared at it long enough for the screen to dim, then sent back *okay*.

Claire was not at her locker. Brooke found her outside the art room wearing Brooke’s green flannel over the blue hoodie. She had rolled the flannel sleeves to her elbows, creating a layered arrangement that looked less like an outfit than evidence of a prolonged burglary.

“Take off my shirt.”

Claire looked down. “This is a jacket.”

“It has buttons.”

“Lots of jackets have buttons.”

“It came from my closet.”

“That’s not a legal definition.”

The lawyer joke belonged to yesterday, when Sarah had made pancakes and nobody had yet learned where to place their eyes. Hearing Claire use it now felt like somebody trying to restart a song after the power failed.

Brooke held out her hand. “Give it back.”

“I spilled water on my shirt in ceramics.”

“Then wear the hoodie you also stole.”

“The zipper feels weird when it’s all the way up.”

“That sounds devastating.”

Claire’s smile faded. “You’re still mad at Mom.”

“This isn’t about Mom.”

“Everything is about Mom today.”

Students moved around them toward the stairwell. A teacher wheeled a cart of clay pieces past, each one wrapped in cloudy plastic. Brooke lowered her voice. “You don’t know what you’re talking about.”

“I know she cried in the laundry room last night.”

Brooke's hand dropped. Claire picked at a loose thread on the flannel cuff. "She thought I was upstairs."

"Did she tell you that?"

"People don't have to tell you things for them to happen."

It sounded like Brooke, which made it worse.

"You were listening outside the door?"

"I was getting my gym clothes. It's also my laundry room."

"You don't own rooms because your stuff is in them."

Claire looked pointedly at the flannel. "That seems like a new rule for you."

Brooke reached for the sleeve. Claire pulled her arm back, not frightened, only irritated. "Stop."

"It's mine."

"I said stop."

The hallway had thinned around them. Somewhere near the front office, a phone rang twice and cut off.

Claire said, "You made her cry because she didn't let you go to one thing."

"She canceled it behind my back."

"Because people are sick."

"You sound exactly like her."

"Maybe because she's right."

Brooke laughed once. "Of course you think that."

"What does that mean?"

"It means you don't care what she does as long as she does everything for you."

Claire's face reddened. "She does everything for both of us. You just act like it doesn't count."

"You don't know what counts."

"I know she's your mom even when you're being horrible to her."

There were many things Brooke could have said. She could have said Claire was thirteen. She could have said Sarah had no right to withdraw the application. She could have taken back the flannel and walked away.

Instead she chose the sentence that would end the argument.

"At least you never have to wonder why your real mother didn't want you."

Claire went still. Brooke knew the line had landed before she understood where she had aimed it. Claire's mouth opened slightly. Her eyes moved over Brooke's face as if searching for evidence that the sentence belonged to somebody else.

The hallway noise continued around them. A locker slammed. Somebody laughed near the stairs. The ordinary sounds made the cruelty feel private, sealed between the two of them even though Brooke had said it where anyone could have heard.

"Mom is your real mother," Claire said.

"I know."

"Then why would you say that?"

Brooke looked toward the stairwell. "Forget it."

"No."

"I said forget it."

"That's not an apology."

"I didn't say it was."

Claire's chin trembled once. She pressed her lips together until it stopped, then began unbuttoning the flannel. The anger had gone out of the movement. She held the shirt toward Brooke without looking at her.

Brooke took it. The fabric was warm from Claire's arms.

For a second Brooke remembered a different warmth: beach sand packed around both legs, Claire kneeling in front of her with wet hair stuck to her cheeks. Claire had been six and furious that the tide kept undoing her work. Each time water reached them, she rebuilt the mound and told Brooke not to move.

You live here now, Claire had announced.

Brooke could have said she was sorry. The words were available. She felt their shape and rejected them because apologizing in the hall would make the cruelty real in a way pretending not to care did not.

She tied the flannel around her waist. "Mom said we have to go straight home."

Claire wiped one eye with the sleeve of the stolen hoodie. "Then go."

"She said both of us."

"You follow rules now?"

Brooke almost smiled because the answer sounded like Claire again. Claire did not smile back.

They walked home several feet apart. Claire did not narrate the route. She did not complain about school or ask Brooke to film anything. At Hawthorne Road, an ambulance passed toward Saint Vincent's without using its siren. Both sisters watched it disappear around the bend.

At the path behind the fields, Claire stopped at the bench where they sometimes waited out rain. She took Brooke's hat from her backpack and set it on the damp wood.

"That's yours too," she said.

Brooke picked it up. "You can keep the hoodie until we get home."

"I don't want it."

"You're wearing it."

Claire unzipped it and held it out. Underneath, her school shirt had dried in a pale ring from the ceramics spill.

"Claire, it's cold."

"Then you wear it."

Brooke took the hoodie because refusing would have required an apology or another cruel sentence, and she did not trust herself with either. Claire walked ahead in the thin shirt. Brooke carried both stolen things and understood that getting them back was not the same as winning.

At home, Sarah was still on a call. Brooke went upstairs and refreshed the outbreak upload. Thirty-eight views. Four dislikes. A new comment read, *My brother had this. He was fine the next day.*

Brooke clicked the account, but it contained no videos and no name she recognized. She typed *What hospital?* and deleted it before posting. The comment could be true. It could be a lie. It could be somebody bored during study hall.

The neighborhood page she followed had a post she read twice. Someone was asking for prayers for Hector Alvarez, the crossing guard at the Field Street elementary school, taken to Saint Vincent's on Wednesday and not yet home.

Brooke knew the name from her application film. He was the reason the workshop had wanted her. She had two minutes of his unperformed kindness that nobody else on the page would ever see, and she sat with the phone in the dark and did not comment.

There was no way to write *I have footage of him being kind* that was not also, underneath, about her.

Her phone rang at 7:26. Mark's face appeared frozen at an angle that showed mostly ceiling. When the connection corrected, he sat on the edge of a hotel bed in his work shirt, a white smear of plaster across one shoulder.

"There she is," he said. "Future famous director."

The words hurt more than Brooke expected. "The workshop got canceled."

He frowned. "The program canceled it?"

From downstairs, Sarah called his name. Brooke heard Claire say something too quietly to make out.

"Mom did," Brooke said.

Mark closed his eyes for half a second. "Okay."

"That's your response?"

"That's me trying not to have three conversations through one phone."

Sarah came into Brooke's room holding her own phone. Claire stayed in the hall. Mark asked what happened, though Brooke suspected Sarah had already told him. Sarah explained the hospital notices and the additional work delay. Brooke explained the waiting list and the acceptance film. Each version was true. Together they sounded like two separate families discussing the same Saturday.

Mark rubbed his forehead. "I think your mom made the safest call she could with what we know. I also think she should've talked to you first."

Nobody won. Brooke had expected him to choose a side and resented him for finding a place between them.

"When are you coming home?" Claire asked from the doorway.

Mark's eyes shifted toward her voice. "Tomorrow night. That's the plan."

"You said that yesterday."

"Yesterday I was younger and more optimistic."

Claire leaned against the frame without laughing. She had changed into her own sweatshirt.

The call continued until the connection began failing. By the end, the family almost sounded normal.

When the screen went dark, Claire left first. Brooke waited for Sarah to mention the workshop or the laundry room. Sarah only said, “Good night,” and followed her.

Brooke opened the video from the beach. She stopped on a frame where Claire’s hands were buried in the sand around Brooke’s knees. The picture shook with Mark’s laughter behind the camera.

The full clip lasted four minutes. Sarah was offscreen warning them that the tide was coming in. Claire kept adding sand to the wall as water darkened it from below. Six-year-old Claire wore Brooke’s striped towel like a cape because her own had blown down the beach. Brooke, ten and sunburned across the nose, complained that the sand scratched her legs.

“You have to stay,” Claire told her in the video. “The castle needs a person.”

“Why can’t you be the person?”

“I’m the builder.”

The first wave broke through and both girls screamed, then laughed so hard the camera shook. Mark said something about engineering standards. Claire threw a handful of wet sand toward him and hit Sarah instead.

Brooke watched until the video ended with the lens pointed at sky.

She considered sending Claire the clip. Instead she saved a second copy to the family folder.

Then she opened their message thread and typed *I’m sorry*. She stared at the two words until they looked like a caption placed over the wrong scene. She deleted them, told herself she would say it in person, and heard Claire’s bedroom door close across the hall.

CHAPTER 4

The Dog Knows

At nine Saturday morning, Brooke's phone reminded her to leave for a workshop she was no longer attending.

She dismissed the alert and stayed in bed. Downstairs, the vacuum cleaner struck the same baseboard three times while Sarah cleaned a house that was not dirty. Claire's door remained closed across the hall.

The Harlan Media Center opened registration at ten. At ten-fifteen, students would meet their production groups. At eleven, they would rotate through lighting and sound. Brooke knew because the schedule was still attached to the confirmation email, preserved alongside the cancellation she had recorded the night before.

At ten, she opened the workshop's social page. Someone had posted a photograph of name badges arranged on a table. The nearest badge belonged to a girl named Elise. Behind it, twenty-three others waited in clean white rows.

At eleven-twenty, the page posted a lighting exercise. Students stood around a woman seated against a gray backdrop while an instructor demonstrated how moving one lamp changed the apparent shape of her face. Brooke enlarged the image until she could identify the fixtures. Two LED panels, one tube light, a black flag clipped to a stand. Equipment she had read about and never touched.

She imagined where she would have stood. Not closest to the instructor. Close enough to see the controls, far enough that

nobody expected her to volunteer first. By lunch the imagined day had become detailed enough to feel remembered.

Brooke closed the page before she could count them.

Her outbreak upload had reached eighty-six views. The fruit-punch comment had collected more likes than the video. Two new viewers said their schools had sent notices about the illness. One wrote that her father had recovered overnight and was already back at work.

Brooke saved screenshots, then hated herself for feeling relieved by the small purpose they gave her.

A soft scrape came from the hall. Cooper stood outside Claire's bedroom with his nose near the gap beneath the door. He did not scratch to be let in. His tail hung low, and the fur between his shoulders moved when he breathed.

"What are you doing?"

One ear turned toward Brooke. The rest of him remained aimed at the door.

Claire called from inside, "If that's Brooke, I'm dead."

"It's the police. We found several stolen garments."

Silence followed. Yesterday, Claire would have answered before Brooke finished the sentence.

Brooke crouched beside Cooper. "Come on."

He backed away at once, so quickly his nails clicked against the hardwood. He stopped beside Brooke's knee and looked at the door.

"Cooper?" Claire called. His ears flattened. Brooke knocked. "Open up."

"I'm sleeping."

"You're talking."

"Sleep talking. It's serious."

"Mom wants your laundry," Brooke said instead.

"No, she doesn't."

"She might eventually."

"Go away."

Brooke stood. Cooper followed her into her room without being asked. When she tried to send him back into the hall, he settled beneath her desk and placed his chin over both front paws.

At noon, Sarah made grilled cheese and tomato soup. Claire came down wearing loose pajama pants and her own gray

sweatshirt. She said she was tired. Sarah touched the back of her hand to Claire's forehead and announced there was no fever.

"I'm not sick," Claire said.

"I didn't say you were."

"You did the mom thermometer."

Sarah set a bowl in front of her. "Eat something."

Claire tore the sandwich in half but did not lift it. Cooper lay beside Brooke's chair, farther from Claire than usual. When Claire held a corner of crust beneath the table, he turned his head away.

"Traitor," Claire said.

Normally Cooper accepted bread as if famine had been narrowly avoided. Brooke watched him press closer to her ankle.

"Maybe he already ate," Sarah said.

"He has never already eaten," Brooke replied.

Claire dropped the crust onto her plate. "He knows you're mad at me."

"Dogs don't understand grudges."

"Then why does he like you?"

The answer was close enough to normal that Sarah smiled. Brooke did too before she could prevent it. Claire looked between them and gave a small, satisfied nod.

For several minutes they ate without mentioning the workshop or yesterday's fight. Rain began against the kitchen windows, light enough to sound like fingers brushing the glass. The television showed footage of a temporary intake tent outside a hospital in Hartford. A reporter stood beneath an umbrella and said officials were investigating whether the gastrointestinal illness was foodborne, viral, or the result of an environmental exposure.

Sarah's phone buzzed beside her bowl. She read a message, set the phone facedown, and took one bite without chewing.

"Dad?" Brooke asked.

"Work."

"His work or yours?"

"Mine. Two people called out."

Sarah coordinated schedules for a regional property-management company. On ordinary weekends, somebody always lost a key or reported water where water did not belong. Today the calls had been about employees refusing to enter apartments where tenants were vomiting, cleaners asking whether

ordinary gloves were enough, and a building manager who wanted permission to close a shared laundry room.

One message Sarah did not read aloud. A tenant in the Merrow Street building, an old man who had complained about those radiators every winter Brooke had been alive, had been found that morning when a wellness check went in. Sarah wrote the unit number on her pad, drew a line under it, and did not say his name at the table. She stood to refill a glass of water nobody had asked for and rested her hand on the back of Claire's chair on the way past, then Brooke's, the way a person counts stairs in the dark.

"Are they sick?" Claire asked.

"Some of them have family who are."

"Then why are you working?"

Sarah looked at the muted television. "Because buildings do not stop needing things when people are scared."

It was the kind of sentence Brooke would remember later and wish she had recorded cleanly.

"Every option," Brooke said.

Sarah reached for the remote. "They don't know yet."

"That's what I said."

"No. You said it like not knowing is evidence they're hiding something."

"I didn't say anybody was hiding anything."

Claire pushed her bowl away. "Can you both not?"

Sarah muted the television. "How much did you eat?"

"Enough."

The sandwich halves remained intact. Claire had taken three spoonfuls of soup, leaving pale swirls where the cheese had touched the surface.

"Your stomach hurt?" Sarah asked.

"No."

"Nauseous?"

"I'm tired."

Sarah performed the hand thermometer again. This time Claire ducked away.

"Stop."

"You're warm."

"Your hands are cold."

Brooke looked down at Cooper. He had raised his head.

Claire carried her bowl to the sink and left it on the counter. Cooper watched her cross the kitchen. When she passed behind Brooke, his body tightened against her chair.

Brooke felt the movement through the wood.

“Cooper,” she said quietly.

Claire stopped. “What?”

“Nothing.”

Cooper stood and moved to the other side of Brooke’s legs.

Sarah noticed. Her eyes narrowed briefly, then moved to the untouched sandwich. “Go lie down. I’ll bring you water.”

“I’m not sick.”

“I know. Go rest anyway.”

Claire left without arguing. Halfway to the stairs, she pressed one hand flat against her abdomen.

Brooke saw it. Sarah saw Brooke see it.

“It’s probably nothing,” Sarah said. Brooke did not answer.

Upstairs, Claire put on one of Brooke’s old camera tests without asking. Brooke heard Cooper barking through the wall, then her own voice telling somebody to hold the reflector still. The clip restarted twice. On the third pass, Brooke went across the hall.

Claire lay on top of the covers with Brooke’s laptop balanced against her knees. “You said I could borrow this.”

“You didn’t ask.”

The image on the screen had paused on Claire in the backyard, squinting into reflected sunlight while Cooper tried to drag the collapsible screen away by one handle. Brooke sat at the foot of the bed. “Why are you watching that?”

“I wanted to see if you were always bossy. You used to let me help.”

Brooke reached for the laptop. “You’re getting fingerprints on it.”

Claire closed the screen before Brooke took it. “I’m sorry about the workshop.”

“You said Mom was right.”

“I can be sorry and think she’s right.”

The answer was irritatingly reasonable. Brooke looked toward the doorway, where Cooper stood with his front feet in the hall and his head extended into the room. Claire patted the mattress.

“Come here, Coop.” He shifted his weight backward.

Claire frowned. "Do I smell?"

"More than usual."

She threw a pillow. It fell short of Brooke and landed near the door. Cooper startled away. When Brooke retrieved it, she felt his body trembling against her leg.

"He's being weird," Claire said.

"He was weird before you were born."

Brooke guided him into the hall and shut Claire's door partway, leaving the gap she always demanded. The camera test began again behind it. Cooper followed Brooke to her room, still glancing back.

By three, Claire had developed a fever of 101.4. Sarah took her temperature twice with the digital thermometer and once with an older one from the bathroom cabinet because she distrusted the first number. Claire complained that the beeping hurt her head. The curtains in her room were closed, though the rain had already darkened the afternoon.

Sarah called the pediatrician's regular line even though the office had closed at noon. The recording had been replaced since yesterday. It now directed patients with vomiting and fever to a state information page before offering the option to leave a message.

"We are not there yet," Sarah said after hanging up.

"There where?" Brooke asked.

"Emergency-room there. She has a fever. She needs rest and fluids."

Sarah wrote the temperature and time on the back of an envelope from the electric company. Brooke photographed it, then opened a note on her phone and copied the number.

"We don't need two records," Sarah said.

"Yours can get thrown away."

"And your phone can die."

Neither stopped recording it their way.

Brooke stood in the doorway with her phone in her hand. She had begun recording when Sarah read the second temperature aloud. The camera held the clock, the thermometer, and Claire curled beneath her blanket.

"Turn that off," Claire said.

"I'm keeping track."

"Use paper."

"Paper doesn't have a clock."

"Clocks have clocks."

Sarah looked over her shoulder. "Brooke."

Brooke stopped recording but did not put the phone away.

Claire shifted onto her back. Sweat had darkened her hairline.

"Can you get Mom?"

"She's right there."

Claire looked toward Sarah as though surprised to find her beside the bed. Confusion crossed her face and vanished. "I know. I meant water."

Sarah picked up the glass from the nightstand. "Small sips."

Claire drank, winced, and pressed her lips together. Sarah took the glass before it spilled.

In the hall, Cooper paced from Brooke's room to the top stair and back. He would not cross Claire's doorway.

Brooke filmed twelve seconds of him privately, including the time on her screen. When Cooper noticed the phone, he looked past it toward Claire's room.

At five, Mark texted that the crew had found damage behind a wall and he would call when he knew whether they could leave. Sarah typed a response with both thumbs, erased it, and called him. The call went to voicemail.

"His phone dies in that building," she said. Brooke had not asked.

Claire slept for an hour. When she woke, the fever had reached 102.6. She refused soup, crackers, applesauce, and the lemon ice pops she normally ate until her tongue hurt.

Brooke sat on the floor outside the room while Sarah changed Claire's damp pillowcase. Cooper lay against Brooke's thigh, awake but pretending not to be. Through the doorway, Claire answered questions with her eyes closed. Name. Day. Whether her neck hurt. Whether the light made her head worse.

"Saturday," Claire murmured.

"Good," Sarah said.

"Brooke's thing."

Brooke looked up.

Claire opened her eyes briefly. "You should've gone."

"This is a terrible apology strategy."

"Not apologizing."

"Then you're doing great."

Claire's mouth moved toward a smile and failed. The failure frightened Brooke more than the fever number.

"The lemon ones taste wrong," she said.

"They're the same box," Sarah told her.

"They're bad."

Sarah opened a new one and tasted it herself. "It tastes normal."

Claire turned her face into the pillow.

At seven-thirteen, she came out of her room without socks and stood at the top of the stairs. Brooke was below her, carrying clean towels from the dryer. Cooper rested on the landing between them. He woke before Claire spoke.

His head rose. His body went rigid. A sound gathered low in his chest, not yet the growl from the night of the hospital footage but close enough that Brooke stopped moving.

Claire gripped the banister. "My stomach hurts."

Cooper backed down one step. Brooke dropped the towels. She reached Claire as her knees folded, catching her beneath the arms before her head struck the railing. The phone in Brooke's pocket pressed against Claire's hip. For once, Brooke did not think about taking it out.

Claire's skin burned through the sweatshirt. She made a small sound and clutched Brooke's hand with both of hers.

"Don't go," she whispered.

"I'm not going anywhere."

Sarah ran from the kitchen. Cooper remained two steps below, trembling as he watched them.

Claire bent forward sharply. Brooke barely turned her in time. Vomit struck the scattered towels and spread across the landing. For one second, nobody moved. Then Sarah began giving instructions, and the house stopped being ordinary.

CHAPTER 5

Empty

Sarah moved Claire to the upstairs bathroom because it had tile, a lock that could be left open, and a tub close enough to catch what the toilet did not.

Brooke gathered the ruined towels by their corners and carried them to the laundry room. The smell followed her down the stairs. She loaded everything into the washer, added too much detergent, and stood with her hand on the lid while the machine filled. Above her, Claire vomited again. The sound traveled through the pipes and walls without losing anything.

Brooke opened the state health department page on her phone. A yellow banner covered the top.

GASTROINTESTINAL ILLNESS: HOME CARE AND WARNING SIGNS

Encourage frequent small sips of clear liquid. Do not force food. Contact a medical provider for persistent vomiting, signs of severe dehydration, confusion, difficulty waking, blood in vomit or stool, or fever above 103°F.

Beneath the list, a new notice warned that emergency departments were experiencing unusually high volume. Patients with mild symptoms should call before arriving.

Nothing about Claire felt mild. Brooke took screenshots anyway, because pages could change and because having the list in her hand felt almost like having instructions.

When she returned upstairs, Sarah knelt beside Claire on the bathroom floor. Claire leaned against the tub in a T-shirt and

underwear, her sweatshirt abandoned near the door. Sweat shone along her arms. A plastic basin sat in her lap.

"I want my bed," Claire said.

"As soon as your stomach settles," Sarah told her.

"It settled."

Her body contradicted her before the sentence ended. Sarah caught the basin and held Claire's hair away from her face. Brooke stopped in the doorway, useless with a glass of water in one hand and her phone in the other.

There was almost nothing left to come up. Claire retched until her shoulders shook, bringing up thin strings of yellow liquid that gathered in the bottom of the basin. When it stopped, she sagged against Sarah.

"Rinse your mouth," Sarah said. Claire shook her head.

"Just a little."

"It tastes wrong."

"It's water."

"I don't want it."

Brooke crouched and held out the glass. "One sip. Then you can yell at us again."

Claire looked at her through wet strands of hair. "I'm not yelling."

"You're doing a weak version. It's embarrassing."

The corner of Claire's mouth moved. She accepted the glass, wet her lips, and shoved it back so suddenly water spilled across Brooke's wrist.

"No."

"Okay."

"Get the lemon ice pop taste out."

"You already threw it up."

Claire stared at her. "I can still taste it."

Sarah glanced at Brooke. Neither said what they were thinking: the ice pop had come up hours ago, before the fever climbed, before the towels on the landing.

Brooke checked the warning-sign list. Persistent vomiting. Confusion. Difficulty keeping fluids down.

"We should go in," she said.

Sarah wiped Claire's face with a damp washcloth. "We should call first."

“She’s dehydrated.”

“She’s been vomiting for less than an hour.”

“She can’t drink.”

“And the emergency room is asking people not to come unless they have to.”

“The page says confusion.”

“She is exhausted.”

Claire closed her eyes. “I’m here.”

Sarah placed a hand against her cheek. “I know, honey.”

Brooke did not say that Claire had forgotten Sarah was beside her earlier. Sarah had seen it.

Sarah called the pediatrician’s after-hours line. A recording advised anyone experiencing severe dehydration or altered mental status to call 911 or proceed to the nearest emergency department. For all other concerns, they could leave a message for the on-call provider. Sarah left Claire’s name, temperature, symptoms, and callback number with the calm precision of someone placing an order. Then they waited.

Brooke searched beneath the state notice while Sarah replaced the damp cloth on Claire’s neck. One comment said Saint Vincent’s had stopped letting relatives beyond triage. Another showed three people sitting together beneath the emergency-room sign. Contradiction had become the only detail every report shared.

She called Saint Vincent’s main number. A recording thanked callers for their patience, warned of extended emergency waits, and repeated that the hospital remained open. The menu offered no choice for asking whether a thirteen-year-old would be separated from her family. Brooke pressed zero until the system disconnected her.

On the second call, she chose patient information. A woman answered after seven minutes and said she could not discuss emergency intake procedures because they were changing by the hour.

“Can two family members stay with a child?” Brooke asked.

“The clinical team will decide based on space and safety.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means bring one adult if possible.”

Brooke looked through the bathroom doorway at Sarah supporting Claire’s weight. “What happens to the other person?”

The woman paused. "They wait."

Brooke thanked her because the woman sounded as tired as Sarah.

A video posted twenty minutes earlier showed shoes, chair legs, and a white paper cup tipped on its side in a crowded waiting room. A vivid red line ran from the cup toward the filmer's sneaker. Someone out of frame retched.

Brooke watched six seconds, muted it, and locked her screen. Claire was sick in front of her. The footage did not make Claire safer or tell Sarah what to do. For the first time since the clips began, saving more felt like refusing to look at what was already in the room.

At eight, Claire's fever was 102.8. At eight-twenty, she vomited after one teaspoon of electrolyte drink. At eight-forty, diarrhea forced Sarah to close the bathroom door, leaving Brooke in the hall with fresh clothes and the sound of Claire crying that she was sorry.

The illness erased privacy by degrees. First Sarah asked Brooke to bring clean underwear. Then Claire needed help standing. Then the bath mat went into a trash bag and Sarah stopped closing the door all the way because she needed Brooke near enough to hear instructions. Claire protested each loss until exhaustion made protest more expensive than embarrassment.

Brooke learned how to knot a trash bag without touching the wet plastic, how to run the shower just long enough to warm the room without filling it with steam, and how to look at Claire's face instead of the mess around her. None of it felt like helping until Sarah asked for something else.

"You have nothing to be sorry for," Sarah said through the door.

"It's gross."

"Bodies are gross. Your sister was gross for most of 2009."

Brooke sat against the opposite wall. "I was three."

"Exactly. No standards."

Claire gave a small laugh that broke in the middle. Brooke pressed the heels of her hands into her eyes.

Cooper lay at the far end of the hall. He had tried twice to come closer when Claire cried, but each time he reached the bathroom

threshold, he stopped and retreated. Now he watched the closed door with his chin on the floor.

Brooke lifted her phone and recorded the time, the thermometer on the carpet, the unopened electrolyte bottle, and Cooper's position in the hall. She did not point the camera toward the bathroom. The clips were no longer material for an upload. They were a record for a doctor who might ask when something happened, and for Brooke if morning arrived and everyone began saying it had not been this bad.

Sarah opened the door enough to take the clothes. Her college shirt was damp at the collar, and strands of hair had worked free from the clip at the back of her head. "Put a trash bag in the bathroom bin. Then bring another blanket. I need ten minutes where you're helping me instead of fighting me."

Brooke went for the blanket. At nine-oh-three, Mark called. Sarah put him on speaker from the bathroom counter. His voice broke around the edges, flattened by poor service and the fan Sarah had turned on.

"How high?" he asked.

"One-oh-two point eight," Sarah said. "Maybe higher now. She can't keep fluids down."

"Did you try ice chips?"

"Yes."

"The blue electrolyte stuff she likes?"

"It came back up."

Claire opened her eyes. "I don't like blue." Mark paused. "Since when?"

"It tastes dirty."

"It's sealed," Sarah said.

"Not the bottle. The blue." The fan filled the silence.

Mark said, "I'm leaving as soon as they clear us. If she gets worse, don't wait for me."

"The pediatrician hasn't called back," Sarah replied.

"Call again."

"I did."

"Then take her in."

Brooke looked at Sarah. Sarah turned away from the phone as if Mark could see her expression through the speaker.

"The hospitals are overwhelmed," she said.

“They’re still hospitals.”

Claire lurched toward the toilet. The phone slid against the counter while Sarah caught her. Mark’s voice repeated Claire’s name from somewhere beneath the noise.

The call disconnected before anyone said goodbye.

Sarah picked up the phone and called back immediately. Voicemail. She tried again while Claire rinsed her mouth. Voicemail again.

“He said he was leaving,” Brooke said.

“He said as soon as they clear them.”

“Same thing.”

“No, it isn’t.”

Sarah set the phone faceup on the counter, volume at maximum. For the next hour, every vibration made all three of them look toward it. Most were building alerts from Sarah’s work or news notifications Brooke had forgotten to silence.

At nine-twenty, the pediatrician returned the message. The on-call nurse sounded tired and spoke quickly. She asked whether Claire had urinated in the last six hours, whether her mouth was dry, whether she could stand without dizziness, whether she knew where she was. Sarah answered until the last question. “Claire,” she said, “tell me where you are.”

Claire rested her forehead against the cool side of the tub. “Home.”

“Where at home?”

“The room.”

“Which room?”

Claire frowned at the toilet, the sink, the bath mat beneath her knees. “The white one.” Their bathroom was pale blue.

The nurse told Sarah to take her to the emergency department.

The house became a list: insurance card, phones, clean clothes, plastic bags, medication history, basin. Sarah moved through it without stopping while Brooke obeyed.

Brooke added Claire’s temperature note, the state-health screenshots, and the short video of Cooper outside the room. Sarah saw the video thumbnail when Brooke checked the folder.

“Do not show them her throwing up.”

“I didn’t film that.”

Sarah looked at her long enough to make the answer feel like a test. "Good."

Brooke wanted credit for the boundary and hated herself for wanting it.

"Shoes she can put on in the car. Bring the gray blanket. Put Cooper in the kitchen."

At his name, Cooper rose but would not approach Claire. Sarah had helped her into sweatpants and one of Mark's old T-shirts. Claire stood between them in the hallway, swaying slightly.

"Cooper," she whispered. He looked at her.

She held out one trembling hand. "Come here."

His tail lowered. He backed toward the stairs.

Claire began to cry. Not loudly. Tears moved down her face while she kept her hand extended, as though she could not understand why he had refused something so simple.

Brooke stepped between them. "He's scared because everybody's running around."

"Of me?"

"Of Mom. Obviously."

Sarah was in the bedroom finding socks and did not hear. Claire's hand dropped.

Brooke put the phone in her pocket and wrapped the gray blanket around her sister. Claire leaned into her immediately, forehead against Brooke's shoulder.

"You're hot," Brooke said.

"You're mean."

The words were faint but familiar. Brooke tightened the blanket around her. "Yeah."

The apology rose and stopped behind Brooke's teeth. Sarah called from the bedroom that they needed to move.

Claire's body jerked. Brooke caught the basin just before she vomited again.

This time the liquid was almost clear.

By ten, Claire had nothing left. Her stomach continued trying anyway.

Sarah drove. Brooke sat in the back beside Claire with the basin between their feet. Rain glazed the roads and turned every traffic light into a long colored smear across the windows. Claire lay with

her head in Brooke's lap, shivering beneath the blanket despite the heat pouring from the vents.

They passed the high school at ten-oh-seven. The parking lot lights were on though the building was empty. A digital sign near the road still announced Monday's basketball game and reminded families that attendance mattered. Beneath it, somebody had taped a sheet of paper over the community-event board. In the headlights Brooke read only two words: *STAY HOME*.

At the next intersection, a pharmacy drive-through line wrapped around the building. People waited beneath umbrellas at the walk-up window. Sarah slowed, considered the turn, and continued toward the hospital.

"We could get nausea medicine," Brooke said.

"Not without knowing what she can take."

"Everybody online says they're giving something red."

Sarah's eyes met hers in the mirror. "Online is not her doctor."

Claire shifted in Brooke's lap. "No red."

Neither of them asked what she meant.

Brooke kept one hand on Claire's shoulder and used the other to refresh the Saint Vincent's emergency page. The estimated wait time had disappeared. A notice said temporary triage procedures were in effect. Families should bring identification, medication lists, and patience.

At the turn for the hospital, traffic stopped.

Red taillights stretched ahead of them in two unmoving lines. An ambulance edged along the shoulder, lights flashing without a siren. Cars shifted just enough to let it pass, then closed behind it.

Sarah gripped the steering wheel. "We're going to get there."

Brooke could not tell whether she was speaking to Claire or herself.

Claire opened her eyes. "Don't let them take me by myself."

"They won't," Sarah said.

It was the first promise of the night that none of them had the power to keep.

CHAPTER 6

Red

Saint Vincent's had turned its visitor parking lot into a waiting room.

Reflective cones divided the entrance lanes. Staff in yellow gowns moved between stopped cars, asking questions through cracked windows and tying paper bands around wrists. Beyond them, white screens enclosed the ambulance bay Brooke had seen in the news photograph. Rain had darkened their lower edges.

Sarah lowered her window when a nurse reached them. "Thirteen years old. Fever, vomiting, diarrhea, confusion. She can't keep water down."

The nurse aimed a flashlight through the back window. Claire flinched and buried her face against Brooke's stomach.

"When did she last urinate?"

Sarah looked at Brooke. Neither knew.

The answer moved them out of the car line and into a wheelchair.

Inside, the emergency department remained recognizably a hospital. A registration clerk asked for insurance. A triage nurse checked Claire's pulse, blood pressure, temperature, and oxygen level while another worker wiped the equipment between patients. Claire received an emesis bag, a mask she immediately pulled beneath her nose, and a printed label warning of contact precautions.

The triage nurse asked Claire to rate her pain from zero to ten. Claire said four. Sarah said eight at the same time.

"Her pain or your worry?" the nurse asked without looking up.

Sarah almost smiled. “Both.”

The nurse pressed a fingernail until the color left it and counted the seconds until it returned. She asked Claire to stick out her tongue, then noted dry mucous membranes and delayed capillary refill in the chart. When Claire stood for the scale, her knees softened. The nurse caught her elbow and changed something on the screen.

Brooke watched the order of questions. The staff were not guessing. Each answer moved Claire through a system that had worked before tonight and was now being asked to hold too many people at once.

Patients filled the waiting-room chairs and the corridor beyond them. Plastic basins sat beneath seats. A custodian changed gloves beside a yellow spill sign while a second stain spread near the vending machines. Gurneys lined one wall, each separated by a curtain that stopped several feet short of privacy.

A nurse told Sarah that one family member could remain past triage.

“I’m staying,” Sarah said.

Claire caught Brooke’s sleeve. “No. Both.”

“I need you to wait here,” Sarah told Brooke. “Keep your phone on.”

Claire tightened her grip. “She comes.”

The nurse crouched until they were nearly eye level. “We have to limit how many people go back. Your mom will stay with you.”

“Brooke too.”

Her voice had no force left, but she did not release the sleeve. Sarah peeled Claire’s fingers away one at a time.

“I’ll be right here,” Brooke said.

Claire stared at her as the wheelchair moved through the double doors. The look remained fixed until the doors met between them.

Brooke sat beneath a television with captions turned on. A local anchor reported that most patients were improving rapidly with supportive treatment. Behind him, National Guard members unloaded cardboard cases at a state distribution center.

Registration gave her a paper visitor slip that did not permit entry and directed her to a vending area already emptied of water. She bought ginger ale because it was the only clear drink left, then

did not open it. Around her, people conducted private emergencies at public volume.

A father argued that his wife could not understand English well enough to go back alone. An older man slept upright with both hands around a plastic basin. Two teenage boys shared one charging cable while reading updates from somebody behind the treatment doors. Every few minutes, a staff member called a name and several families stood before realizing it was not theirs.

Brooke opened her camera but did not record faces. She filmed the television caption saying *MOST PATIENTS RECOVER* above a row of shoes stained red near the vending machines. Then she lowered the phone and wrote the time in her notes.

She checked the neighborhood page once, the way she checked everything, and found the answer to the question she had not let herself ask. The post about Hector Alvarez had been updated. His family thanked everyone for their prayers. He had died Friday night, in this building, while Brooke was three miles away refreshing a page and counting the views on a video about her sister.

The comments were already doing the work grief did now. He was at peace. He was with God. He had touched so many children. Nobody wrote that he had checked an empty intersection twice because a habit of care did not switch off just because the street was clear. Only Brooke had that, on a drive at the bottom of a folder, and for the first time the footage did not feel like evidence of anything. It felt like the last place a dead man was still bending to warm a child's hands.

Down the hall, behind the doors, her sister was alive and full of saline and the red medicine everyone kept bringing back up. Claire was alive. Mr. Alvarez was not. The two facts sat in Brooke's chest without resolving into anything she could use, and she understood, in that plastic chair, that she would have traded every frame she had ever shot to keep one ordinary man from becoming a file.

At 12:18 a.m., Sarah texted that Claire had an IV and bloodwork pending. At 12:41, she wrote that the fever was 103.1. At 1:06, a nurse brought Brooke through because Claire had become too agitated for Sarah to calm alone.

The nurse made Brooke sanitize her hands, put on a yellow gown, and repeat that she would stay inside the marked treatment

area. Brooke tied the gown badly. The nurse retied it without comment while walking.

They passed rooms whose doors had been propped open for visibility. In one, a woman argued that she had already recovered and wanted to leave with her husband. In another, three family members stood pressed together around an empty bed while a transport worker waited with a wheelchair. A physician at a computer dictated that a patient was alert, oriented, ambulatory, and refusing separation from family. The language sounded clinical enough to make the last phrase seem ordinary.

Near the pediatric bay, cases of the red formulation had been stacked against a wall beneath a paper sign reading *ORAL REHYDRATION SUPPORT*. Several boxes were wet along the bottom. A supply worker moved the dry cases onto a cart and left the stained cardboard where it was.

The treatment space had once held six beds. It now held ten. Claire lay beneath a thin blanket with an IV taped to her hand. Her lips had split at the center. Sarah sat beside her, one palm resting on Claire's ankle as if contact could keep her in place.

An IV pump alarmed behind one curtain until a nurse silenced it with the heel of her hand while adjusting another patient's oxygen. A laminated sign taped to the medication station listed contact precautions, fluid-replacement thresholds, and neurological checks every hour. Somebody had added *DOCUMENT ORAL INTAKE* in red marker.

Claire's first bag of saline was already half empty. A second smaller bag hung beside it, and the nurse explained that it contained potassium because vomiting and diarrhea had lowered Claire's level enough to affect muscle and heart function.

"Is her heart okay?" Sarah asked.

"Her rhythm is okay. We're correcting it before it becomes a problem."

The nurse attached leads to Claire's chest anyway. Claire complained that the adhesive pulled. Sarah called that a good complaint because it sounded like her.

"They gave her nausea medicine," Sarah said. "The normal kind."

The distinction made Brooke look toward the end of the bay.

A cart stood beside the medication station, loaded with sealed white cups. Through their translucent sides, the liquid appeared almost luminous red. A nurse peeled back lids and distributed them with printed instruction sheets.

“What is that?” Brooke asked.

Sarah shook her head. “Something they’re using for vomiting.”

The doctor arrived before Brooke could ask more. Dr. Shah looked younger than Sarah and more tired than anyone Brooke had ever seen standing upright. He said Claire’s labs showed significant dehydration and electrolyte imbalance. They were moving her to pediatric observation for IV fluids, neurological checks, and the oral treatment being used under emergency guidance.

He washed his hands while speaking, twenty seconds by the wall clock, then repeated the neurological questions the nurse had asked. Claire knew her name and the hospital but called Saturday Friday. Dr. Shah did not correct her immediately. He asked whether school had been open that day, whether anyone else at home was ill, whether Claire had eaten anything unusual, traveled, taken antibiotics, or been near untreated water.

Sarah answered until Brooke interrupted to mention Cooper’s behavior. Dr. Shah looked at her for one second, neither dismissive nor interested enough to record it.

“Animals can react to fever, smell, stress, and changes in household behavior,” he said.

It was a useful answer that explained nothing Brooke wanted explained.

“What is it called?” Brooke asked.

Dr. Shah pointed to the emergency-formulary code printed on the instruction sheet. It looked more like inventory than a name. “We don’t have evidence that it treats the cause. The goal is to help patients tolerate fluids.”

“Is it working?”

He looked toward the crowded bay. “Some people are improving.”

That was not the same answer.

Sarah read the emergency-use sheet from top to bottom. It listed the formulation code, ingredients Brooke recognized from electrolyte drinks, a flavoring agent, and several words she did not.

Under *Known limitations*, it said the product had not been established to shorten the underlying illness.

"Then why give it?" Brooke asked.

Dr. Shah had already moved to the next bed. The nurse answered while checking Claire's IV. "Because getting fluid into people by mouth means we can save IV supplies for patients who need them most."

"But they're throwing it up."

The nurse looked toward the medication cart. "Some are."
She did not sound convinced by the distinction.

Brooke started recording after he left. She held her phone low, framing only the medication cart and the clock above it. One patient drank. Then another. Across the bay, a child began crying that it tasted like pennies.

Claire accepted her cup because Sarah asked her to. The liquid stained her lower lip red.

The nurse scanned the cup. The cart rejected the barcode twice before accepting a short emergency-formulary code on the paper label. No product name appeared on the screen Brooke could see, only *ORAL REHYDRATION SUPPORT* and a yellow notice that reconciliation was pending.

"Small sip," the nurse said.

Claire swallowed once. Her whole body tightened.

Three beds away, a man folded forward. The sound of liquid hitting the floor came a second before two other patients began retching. Claire shoved the cup away and turned toward the basin.

The red came back brighter than it had gone in.

It splashed the basin, Sarah's gown, the white sheet, and the floor beneath the bed. Another patient vomited across the curtain. Shoes squeaked as staff moved between them. A nurse slipped, caught the medication cart, and sent sealed cups rolling in red water.

For several seconds the room seemed to move together. Bodies contracted. Curtains shook. Staff called for bags, suction, clean gowns, more towels. The custodian from the waiting room appeared with a fresh mop head, stopped at the bay entrance, and looked as if somebody had asked him to empty the ocean.

One nurse began counting aloud, not patients but seconds between episodes. Another called the medication station and asked

whether the batch number matched the previous shipment. The answer was lost beneath retching and alarms.

A respiratory therapist moved a child onto his side and cleared his mouth with suction. An aide guided a confused woman back onto her bed before she stepped barefoot into the spill. Nobody ran. Running would have made the room less usable. They moved quickly inside narrow lanes that existed only because each worker trusted the others to keep theirs.

Brooke had expected panic to look disorganized. This was worse. It had protocols.

Brooke kept recording until Sarah saw the phone.

“Put it away.”

“They said it was supposed to help.”

“Put it away and help me.”

Brooke did. She held Claire’s hair while Sarah changed the sheet beneath her. The nurse replaced the IV tubing that had pulled loose. Red footprints traveled outward from the bed and remained after the visible spill was gone.

At three, Claire slept.

Brooke sat in the plastic chair with Claire’s damp socks sealed in a belongings bag beneath her feet. Sarah had changed into a clean disposable gown, but red remained in the seam of one thumbnail. She scraped at it until the skin around the nail reddened too.

“Stop,” Brooke said.

Sarah tucked the hand beneath her opposite arm. “I can still smell it.”

“It’s in the room.”

“I know.”

They spoke softly because Claire was sleeping and because neither wanted to restart the workshop argument in a place where other families could hear. Sarah leaned her head against the wall.

“I’m sorry,” Brooke said.

Sarah opened her eyes. “For what?”

There were too many possible answers. The sentence about being kept. The camera. The fact that part of Brooke had noticed the red medicine as footage while Claire was vomiting it.

“Yesterday,” she said.

Sarah looked at Claire. “Not here.”

It was not forgiveness. It was a promise that the argument still belonged to a future in which they went home.

At three-thirty, the lights dimmed by a degree that would have been comforting in any room without ten beds. The nurses continued neurological checks every hour. Claire woke when they asked her name, answered, and immediately searched for Sarah's hand. Across the bay, the woman who had held her husband's sleeve earlier was awake again. Her husband slept folded over a chair, his forehead against the mattress. She watched him without blinking until an aide crossed between them.

The aide blocked her view for less than two seconds. The woman pushed herself upright, pulse monitor alarming, and relaxed only after the aide moved on.

Brooke wrote *fear of separation after recovery?* in her notes, then added a question mark large enough to make the phrase look embarrassed.

At four-ten, Claire kept down an ounce of water. Sarah cried quietly and laughed at herself for crying. Brooke filmed only the measurement marks on the cup and Sarah's hand holding it. Claire's face remained outside the frame.

Her fever fell to 101.7. She kept down two ice chips, then four. By then, she answered her name, the hospital, and the day correctly. Around them, other patients improved with the same improbable speed.

A woman across the aisle sat upright after hours beneath a blanket. When an orderly arrived to take her for imaging, she hooked two fingers through her husband's sleeve. He kissed her knuckles and promised he would wait. She kept hold of the fabric until the orderly gently separated them.

Before dawn, Mark called. Brooke went into the corridor so the ringing would not wake Claire.

His video showed darkness and part of a dashboard. "How is she?"

"Better. Maybe. They gave her the red medicine. She threw it up. Everybody did."

The image froze. His voice continued in broken pieces.

"Leaving now... road closure... hear me?"

"Where are you?"

"Still near... Brooke, tell your mom..."

The call failed.

She called back twice. Both attempts went to voicemail.

At dawn, the walls near Claire's bed had been wiped but not cleaned. Pale red streaks remained in the grout. A nurse stepped through them while carrying discharge papers for a patient who had been unable to stand three hours earlier.

A hospitalist from pediatric observation reviewed Claire's chart and explained that they would continue IV fluids, repeat electrolytes, monitor urine output, and advance her diet only after she tolerated clear liquids. Sarah asked whether Claire remained contagious. The doctor said they should assume she was until the health department gave different guidance.

"How long after the vomiting stops?" Sarah asked.

"We don't know yet."

"Should her sister stay away from her?"

The hospitalist looked at Brooke, then at the crowded bay where separation had become mostly theoretical. "At home, use separate towels, clean high-touch surfaces, and limit close contact where you can."

Claire woke during the answer. Her hand moved across the sheet until she found Brooke's wrist.

"You're here," she said.

"Yeah."

Her grip was weak, ordinary, and familiar. Brooke let her keep it.

Claire would remain in pediatric observation through Sunday.

CHAPTER 7

Better

Monday morning, Claire walked out of Saint Vincent's under her own power.

Sarah carried the discharge folder, two plastic bags, and the gray blanket. Brooke carried everything else because nobody trusted Claire with anything that could spill. The morning sun made them all squint after the hospital's flat white light.

"I feel disgusting," Claire said.

Her voice sounded like hers again.

The discharge nurse had called the improvement typical. Continue fluids. Offer bland foods. Return for confusion, persistent vomiting, or inability to drink. Follow up with the pediatrician. The printed page described a gastrointestinal illness. Under medications, the red treatment appeared only as the same emergency-formulary code, a handwritten time, and *pending reconciliation*. There was no product name or batch number for Sarah to ask about.

At home, the kitchen smelled faintly of coffee left in the pot and the lavender cleaner Sarah used on the counters. Cooper waited behind the gate. His tail moved when Sarah entered, faster when he saw Brooke, then stopped when Claire stepped through.

Claire dropped to her knees. "I survived."

Cooper remained near the refrigerator.

"Come here."

He looked toward Brooke.

Sarah unlatched the gate. "Give him a minute. You smell like the hospital."

Claire accepted the explanation. Brooke watched Cooper retreat when she stood.

By noon, Claire's fever was gone. She showered, changed into Brooke's blue hoodie without asking, and ate half a bowl of rice. Sarah slept on the living-room sofa with one hand still curled around her phone.

The house had the stale, abandoned feeling of a place they had left in a hurry. A glass of water still stood on the stairs where Sarah had set it before deciding Claire needed the hospital. Brooke found one of Claire's socks beneath the kitchen table and the other beside the downstairs bathroom. Cooper followed her while she opened curtains and emptied cups, keeping close until Claire came into the room. Then he chose a doorway and watched.

Brooke tried to photograph the normal things. Claire's sneakers kicked beneath the radiator. Sarah asleep with her mouth slightly open. The discharge folder on the counter beneath a grocery coupon. She told herself the images were for the part afterward, when this became the weekend Claire had a terrible stomach virus and everybody complained about the hospital for years.

Claire caught her pointing the camera toward the sofa.

"Mom will murder you if you post her sleeping."

"I'm not posting it."

"Then why take it?"

Brooke lowered the camera. Before the hospital, Claire would have leaned across the screen and demanded approval rights over every picture in which even one strand of her hair appeared. Now she only waited.

"Because this is what today looks like," Brooke said.

"It looks boring."

"That's the dream."

Claire smiled. It was quick, crooked, and familiar enough that Brooke felt foolish for every second she had spent watching Cooper.

Brooke sat at the kitchen table reviewing the hospital clips with the sound off. The red treatment cart. The cups. Claire's stained mouth. The room contracting almost together. She cropped out the other patients and the staff name badges, then chose a close frame of the emergency-formulary code. She cut away before Claire

vomited, restored the section, and hated herself a little for deciding that removing it changed what happened.

When Claire entered, Brooke minimized the window.

"Were you filming me?"

"The hospital."

"I was at the hospital."

"You were barely in it."

Claire opened the refrigerator. "Do we have mushrooms?"

Brooke looked up. "What?"

"Mushrooms."

"We have never had mushrooms because you describe them as wet ears."

"I did not say wet ears."

"You said boiled ears. Sorry."

Claire searched the vegetable drawer and found a carton Sarah had bought for an omelet. She ate one slice raw.

Brooke waited for the face Claire always made when a mushroom touched her food. It did not come.

"That's good," Claire said.

"No, it isn't."

"You don't like them either."

"That isn't the point."

Sarah woke at their voices and came into the kitchen. When Brooke explained, she smiled with exhausted relief. "Her appetite is back. That's good."

"She hates mushrooms."

"People's tastes change."

"Since yesterday?"

Sarah's smile disappeared. "She spent the weekend in pediatric observation. Can we let one thing be good?"

Claire stood between them chewing a second slice.

Brooke said yes because Sarah needed it and because Claire was upright, hydrated, and rolling her eyes again. She helped make eggs with mushrooms while Cooper watched from the hall.

Sarah called Mark while the eggs cooked. The call failed twice before connecting with his face broken into squares by the hotel Wi-Fi. He was still in western Pennsylvania, where a job-site closure had stranded his crew behind a county travel advisory. He asked Claire to hold the phone closer, then farther away, then

laughed when she complained that he was directing her like one of Brooke's videos.

"Look at you," he said. "Back among the living."

Sarah closed her eyes at the phrase.

"Too soon?" Mark asked.

"A lot too soon."

Claire told him about the red medicine and left out nearly everything else. She made the hospital sound gross rather than frightening. Mark promised to drive home as soon as the site released the company trucks. Sarah asked whether he had eaten. Claire moved beside Brooke during the answer and leaned against her until their shoulders touched.

On the small screen, Mark noticed. "Taking care of your sister?"

"She's taking care of me," Claire said.

Brooke made herself smile. The connection froze on Mark smiling back.

When the picture moved again, his attention had shifted toward someone outside the frame. A voice called his name. Mark said he had to go and that he loved them. Claire answered first and loudest. After the call ended, Sarah remained at the stove with the dark phone in her hand.

"He'll be home soon," she said.

Nobody had asked.

That afternoon, Brooke assembled her second upload. She titled it *My sister got sick*. She included Claire's fever timeline, the hospital notices, the red cups, and the recovery instructions. She did not include the bathroom, Claire crying about Cooper, or the cruel line from two days before. Those belonged to Claire, not the outbreak.

She recorded one final sentence.

"She's home now. Her fever is gone. The hospital says most people recover quickly, and that seems true. I still don't know what the red treatment is supposed to do."

The upload began collecting comments before dinner. The first criticism that stayed with her asked whether Claire had agreed to have the worst night of her life posted online. Brooke began typing that the video might help somebody, then stopped. Claire had not agreed. Brooke closed the page.

She reopened the project instead and watched the cut as if someone else had made it. The hospital employees were unidentifiable. The children in the waiting room appeared only as shoes, blankets, and hands. Claire's face showed for eleven seconds. Brooke had chosen the seconds in which she looked sick enough to prove the story and well enough that posting her did not feel cruel.

That choice bothered Brooke more than the comment.

Before she closed the laptop she opened a different file, one she had not touched since the workshop email. Two minutes of a crossing guard in gray snow. She watched it with the sound off, the way she watched everything she was afraid of. Mr. Alvarez warmed the mitten. He checked the empty intersection twice. He waved at the bus driver who never waved back, and the film ended, and he was still dead.

While the last frame held, Brooke understood why she filmed people. The hard drive that died when she was twelve had taken four months she never got back, and some part of her had promised it would not happen again. Then it happened to Mr. Alvarez and perhaps to her father at the far end of a failing call. The camera did nothing to stop it. It only made the loss legible afterward. She had pointed the lens at Claire and called it evidence, but suspicion was not the whole truth. She had her sister back, and keeping the frames felt like the only saving left to her.

She carried the laptop to Claire and paused before the first hospital shot. "Watch this."

Claire groaned. "Do I have to?"

"No. That's the point. You can tell me to take it down."

Claire watched without speaking. At the image of the red cup she rubbed her tongue against her teeth. When the video ended, she asked how many people had seen it.

"A hundred and nine."

"That's barely people."

"Claire."

"Leave it up." She reached for the progress bar and replayed the shot of Sarah arguing with the intake clerk. "Mom looks scary there."

"Mom was scary there."

"You didn't show me throwing up."

“I promised.”

Claire nodded, apparently satisfied, and leaned her head against Brooke’s upper arm. “You can make another one if something else happens.”

Brooke looked down at her. “What else would happen?”

Claire’s eyes stayed on the frozen hospital frame. “Nothing.”

Saint Vincent’s called before dinner. Sarah put the phone on speaker and carried it through the kitchen while checking Claire’s temperature for the third time. Dr. Shah asked about fluids, urine, dizziness, abdominal pain, and whether Claire could keep down food. Claire answered each question with impatient precision.

“Any confusion?” Dr. Shah asked.

“No,” Sarah said.

Claire said, “Mom asked me the president and my birthday six times.”

“Only four.”

“It felt like six.”

Dr. Shah laughed softly. “That sounds promising. Any unusual behavior?”

Brooke looked at the mushrooms.

Sarah followed her gaze. “She’s tired. A little clingy.”

“Normal after a frightening hospitalization,” Dr. Shah said. “Let her nervous system settle. Keep the next few days quiet and predictable.”

Claire took Brooke’s hand beneath the counter. Her fingers were cool and loose. Brooke let them stay.

“What about the medicine they gave her?” Brooke asked.

The pause was brief but real. “Which medication?”

“The red liquid. The emergency formula.”

“That was part of the hospital protocol. Saint Vincent’s can answer questions about the specific formulation.”

“The discharge sheet doesn’t name it.”

“Then call the number on the packet tomorrow. My concern tonight is hydration and return of symptoms.”

Sarah thanked him before Brooke could ask again. When the call ended, she said, “You heard him. Quiet and predictable.”

“She also didn’t answer.”

“He treated Claire, but he does not run the hospital pharmacy.”

Claire squeezed Brooke’s hand. “I’m okay.”

The sentence was exactly what Brooke wanted. It was also what every adult needed Claire to say. Brooke turned her palm upward and squeezed back.

For the rest of the afternoon, recovery performed itself convincingly. Claire complained about the bland-food list. She beat Sarah at a card game and accused her of cheating. She sent Mark a photograph of the mushroom eggs with the caption *I have survived and become sophisticated*. When Sarah made her walk once around the ground floor to check for dizziness, Claire added a runway turn in the foyer.

Brooke filmed none of it.

She wanted to remember without creating evidence. She wanted one hour that did not have to become useful later.

Claire sat cross-legged on the living-room rug watching a cooking competition. A plate beside her held mushrooms and plain crackers.

"Can I sit here?" Brooke asked.

Claire looked surprised. "It's a free country."

Brooke sat on the sofa. Cooper climbed beside her and pressed his full weight against her thigh.

Claire patted the rug. "You too."

He lowered his head onto Brooke's knee.

Sarah returned with three blankets and covered them as if recovery could be secured by warmth. Claire complained that hers was too heavy. Sarah called that a normal complaint and kissed the top of her head.

When the credits began, Claire reached back and rested her hand over Brooke's ankle. She left it there after she fell asleep.

CHAPTER 8

Sit With Me

Claire began following Brooke on Tuesday morning.

At first it was easy to explain. She had been sick. The hospital had separated them. Brooke had promised not to go anywhere and then spent hours behind a set of double doors she could not control.

Claire waited outside the bathroom while Brooke brushed her teeth. She sat on Brooke's bed while Brooke dressed. Downstairs, she moved from chair to counter whenever Brooke crossed the kitchen.

"You're hovering," Brooke said.

"I'm eating."

Claire held a forkful of eggs. Sarah had made them again because Claire asked.

"You can eat from a chair."

"I like it here."

Here meant close enough that their sleeves touched.

Sarah watched them over her coffee. "She had a frightening weekend."

"So did I. I'm not standing on anybody."

Claire smiled. "You can if you want."

Brooke moved to the other side of the island. Claire followed with her plate.

Cooper rose from beneath the table and left the kitchen.

Sarah kept both girls home from school. Claire's pediatrician wanted twenty-four symptom-free hours, and Sarah said Brooke

needed sleep. Instead Brooke spent the morning editing while Claire occupied the spare chair beside her desk.

Brooke tried to restore the old distance by giving Claire work. She copied the hospital clips into a new folder and showed her how to add plain labels without opening any of the files.

"Date, time, place," Brooke said. "No opinions."

"You mean no fun."

"You used to beg to help."

"I used to be ten."

For fifteen minutes Claire complained in recognizable ways. She misspelled Saint Vincent's, blamed the keyboard, and renamed one clip *RED BARF HALLWAY* before Brooke made her change it. Brooke relaxed enough to concentrate. This was what Claire had meant about logging. They had spent whole rainy afternoons this way, Brooke shaping a story while Claire did a minor job and acted as if she had been exploited by a major studio.

Then Brooke noticed that Claire had stopped working. Her hands rested in her lap. She was watching Brooke's face reflected in the dark edge of the monitor.

"What?"

"Nothing."

"You haven't labeled anything in five minutes."

"I like watching you."

Brooke turned back to the screen. "That is a deeply creepy sentence."

Claire laughed because Brooke had made it a joke. A moment later she rolled her chair closer, until the wheels touched Brooke's.

"The clicking is annoying," Claire said.

"Then leave."

"No."

"Compelling strategy."

"Sit with me downstairs."

"I'm working."

"You can work downstairs."

Brooke turned from the monitor. "Why?"

Claire's answer came too quickly. "Because I asked."

She smiled after saying it, trying to make the sentence lighter. Brooke recognized the adjustment. Claire had heard herself sound demanding.

“Give me twenty minutes.”

“Ten.”

“Thirty now.”

“That’s not how bargaining works.”

Claire watched the screen while Brooke reviewed footage from before the hospital: Claire at lunch leaving the sandwich untouched, Cooper moving behind Brooke’s chair, Claire on the stairs reaching for her hand. In the corner of the monitor, the current Claire leaned closer.

“Don’t use the part where I throw up.”

“I didn’t.”

“Promise?”

“It’s your face. You get a veto.”

Claire relaxed. “Okay.”

The ordinary response made Brooke feel ashamed of the question forming in her mind.

At noon, Sarah took a work call upstairs. Brooke carried her laptop to the sofa. Claire curled beside her beneath the heavy blanket, shoulder pressed along Brooke’s arm. Each time Brooke shifted, Claire shifted too.

The highest-rated comment beneath *My sister got sick* called Claire’s behavior a trauma response and told Brooke to be kind. Brooke wanted it to be right.

The comments argued more with each other than with her. Two threads had already turned into a fight over whether she was exploiting Claire. Below them, three accounts had posted the same paragraph about supporting recovered family members, including the same missing comma. Brooke clicked through to see whether they were bots. One belonged to a middle-aged man who posted fishing photographs. One belonged to a local church. The third had been created that morning.

She saved screenshots, then felt ridiculous. Repeated language was not evidence of anything except copying, and copying was what the internet did best.

Claire fell asleep against her. Brooke waited until her breathing deepened, then eased one arm free and stood.

Brooke made it to the kitchen before Claire appeared in the doorway with the blanket around her shoulders.

“You left.”

"I got water."

"You could've told me."

Cooper stood in the hall. Claire crouched and held out both hands. "Are you done being weird?"

He turned his head away.

"Cooper."

Brooke touched his collar. The fur beneath it felt warm. "Come on, buddy."

Claire reached for the side of his face.

The growl came without warning.

It was lower than a bark and louder than the sound he had made outside Claire's room. His lips did not lift. His body simply became rigid beneath Brooke's hand.

Claire froze.

Sarah appeared at the top of the stairs with her headset still on. "What happened?"

"He growled at me," Claire said.

Cooper backed behind Brooke.

"Did somebody step on him?" Sarah asked. "Startle him?"

"Claire touched him."

Sarah came down and checked his paws, collar, and ears.

Cooper tolerated everything while watching Claire.

"Maybe he's sick," Sarah said.

"He isn't."

"You don't know that."

Claire remained crouched in the hall. Her face had gone blank with hurt.

"It's okay," Brooke told her.

Claire looked at Cooper. "I didn't do anything."

She did not shout at him or reach again. She stood slowly and moved beside Brooke instead, close enough that their hands brushed.

Sarah said they would call the veterinarian. Brooke nodded. Maybe there was a sore place beneath his fur, or some smell from the hospital that had not washed away.

The veterinarian could not see Cooper until Friday. A technician asked whether his eating, drinking, and bathroom habits had changed. Sarah answered no to everything.

"Any new people or animals in the home?"

Sarah looked at Claire and then away. "My daughter came home from the hospital."

"Different smells can make dogs cautious. Medication, disinfectant, stress hormones. Give him space and don't force an interaction."

Brooke wrote the last sentence in her notes.

Claire saw. "Seriously?"

"It's what she said."

"About the dog."

"Yes."

"You're making another list about me."

Brooke locked her phone. "I'm writing down the explanation too."

"So you can prove Mom wrong later?"

Sarah ended the call and set the phone on the counter.

"Enough."

Claire turned away first. She opened the pantry and stood looking inside, not choosing anything. Brooke remembered her at eight years old, furious because Brooke had made a chart tracking how often Claire borrowed her clothes. The chart had lasted two days before Sarah made Brooke take it down. Claire had called it creepy then too.

Brooke deleted the note about the veterinarian. Five minutes later, in the bathroom, she restored it from the trash.

At dinner Claire functioned so normally Brooke began to distrust her own discomfort. She complained about homework she had not started. She argued that a twenty-four-hour fever deserved at least three days without chores. She took Brooke's last dinner roll and denied it while chewing.

Then Sarah stood to refill her water, and Claire stood too.

"Where are you going?" Sarah asked.

Claire looked surprised. "Nowhere."

"Then sit."

Claire sat. Her gaze followed Sarah to the sink and back. When Sarah returned, Claire moved her chair close enough that its leg touched Brooke's.

Brooke waited for Sarah to notice. Sarah noticed everything. A damp towel on the floor could summon her from another level of the house.

This time Sarah kept eating.

That night, Claire appeared in Brooke's doorway carrying her pillow.

"No."

"I didn't ask yet."

"You brought a pillow."

"Can I sleep on the floor?"

"You have a bed."

"I don't want to be alone."

Brooke looked past her toward the dark hall. Cooper lay at the foot of Brooke's bed, head raised.

"I'll sit with you until you fall asleep," Brooke said.

Claire considered this. "In my room?"

"That is where your bed lives."

Brooke followed her across the hall. Claire climbed beneath the covers and took Brooke's wrist, holding it lightly against the mattress.

"You don't have to hold on."

"Do what?"

"Hold me here."

Claire loosened her fingers. "I'm just holding your hand."

Brooke stayed until Claire's eyes closed, then slipped her hand free.

In the hall, she waited.

Claire's breathing remained slow. Brooke crossed to her room, eased the door nearly shut, and sat on the edge of her bed without turning on a light. Cooper lifted his head from the rug. For the first time all day, nobody was touching her or asking where she was going.

The relief lasted less than a minute.

Claire's door opened. Bare feet crossed the hall and stopped outside Brooke's room.

Brooke watched the narrow dark line between the door and frame. Claire did not knock. She did not call her name. She stood there long enough that Cooper rose and placed himself between the bed and the entrance.

At last Claire whispered, "Brooke?"

Brooke could have pretended to be asleep. Instead she said, "I'm here."

The door opened immediately.

Claire did not enter. She looked at Cooper, then at Brooke, and held the pillow against her chest. "You said you'd stay until I fell asleep."

"You fell asleep."

"I woke up."

"People do that."

"Come back."

Brooke went because it was late, because Claire had almost died, and because every reason Sarah offered still sounded reasonable when Claire stood in the doorway looking thirteen. This time Brooke sat in the desk chair rather than on the bed. Claire watched her until her eyes closed.

Brooke counted to three hundred before leaving.

At one hundred and twelve, Claire smiled without opening her eyes.

"You're still here," she murmured.

Brooke stopped counting.

CHAPTER 9

Preferences

Brooke woke before her alarm because someone was humming.

Claire sat on the floor beside the bed with her back against the wall. She wore Brooke's blue hoodie and held her knees beneath it. The tune had no melody Brooke recognized.

"What are you doing?"

The humming stopped. "Waiting."

"For what?"

"You to wake up."

The clock read 5:53. "How long have you been there?"

Claire shrugged. "Not long."

"Go back to bed."

"I'm not tired."

She looked rested. That was almost worse.

At breakfast, Claire ate plain oatmeal. She had once required brown sugar and still complained that its texture resembled paste. Now she finished the bowl without adding anything.

Brooke set her phone beside the plate. "Say what you're eating."

Sarah looked up. "Don't."

"I'm asking a question."

"You're filming her breakfast like she's evidence."

Claire leaned toward the phone. "Sad oatmeal. Breakfast of people who survived."

"You hate it."

"I changed my mind."

"About everything at once?"

Claire took another bite. "You wanted me to try new things."

Sarah pushed the phone facedown. "She is eating. She slept. She has no fever. The pediatrician cleared her for school tomorrow. Stop making her feel watched."

"Cooper growled at her."

"Cooper has a vet appointment."

"He only avoids Claire."

Sarah's expression hardened. "Do you hear how unkind that sounds?"

Claire reached under the table and rested a hand on Brooke's knee. "It's okay."

The reassurance made Brooke move her chair back.

Claire's hand remained suspended for a moment before returning to her lap.

When Brooke carried her bowl to the sink, Sarah remained at the table. Claire had started humming again. Sarah watched her for several seconds, then noticed Brooke looking and reached for her coffee.

Later, Brooke went to school alone. Sarah said Claire needed one more day despite the pediatrician's clearance, which meant Sarah could be cautious when the caution was hers.

Ashcroft High had placed handwashing posters over the old dance flyers. Teachers wiped desks between periods. The nurse's office door stayed open, and a line formed before second bell.

In chemistry, Nora pointed toward the rear lab station. "Mason's back."

Mason Lee had left class vomiting on Thursday. The school had allowed him back after forty-eight symptom-free hours. Now he sat shoulder to shoulder with a boy Brooke had never seen him speak to before. Their stools touched. When the teacher asked them to separate for the lab, both moved to the same empty station.

"He recovered," Nora said. "My mom says almost everyone does."

Mason caught Brooke looking and smiled. Nothing about his face seemed wrong.

During the lab, Mason reached across his partner for a container instead of asking him to move. His arm stayed against the boy's chest while he measured the solution. The boy did not object. When Ms. Delaney separated them again, she did it laughing.

“We appreciate the enthusiasm, but everybody gets their own oxygen.”

Mason and the boy looked at each other. Then both smiled at precisely the same moment.

Brooke missed the next instruction and added twice the required water. Nora swore under her breath and rescued the beaker.

“Are you okay?” Nora asked.

“Yeah.”

“You keep staring at Mason.”

“He was sick.”

“Half the school was sick.”

Brooke looked around. Two students shared a stool at the counter although an empty one stood beside them. At the sinks, a girl washed her hands while another rested her chin on the girl’s shoulder. None of it was impossible. Ashcroft High had always contained couples, best friends, people who treated hallways like their living rooms.

The difference was not any single act. It was how often Brooke saw it once she began looking.

At lunch, the televisions displayed an interview with a hospital administrator. The captions read *RECOVERY RATES CONTINUE TO IMPROVE*. The administrator thanked families for supporting patients through a frightening but brief illness.

At the next table, Mason peeled the mushrooms from a cafeteria pizza and ate them one by one. Brooke had watched him pick them off every Friday since freshman year, sometimes with a plastic fork so the cheese would not touch his fingers.

“Did Mason always eat mushrooms?” she asked.

Nora followed her gaze. “Maybe he finally grew up.”

A girl beside Mason offered him a container of cold spinach left over from the salad bar. He took a forkful, chewed, and passed the container to the boy from chemistry. They ate from it in turn without talking.

Brooke raised her phone, then lowered it before recording. Mason was not Claire. He had not agreed to become evidence in a story he did not know existed.

She typed the observation into a private note instead.

Brooke opened her comments, saw another accusation that she wanted something to be wrong with Claire, and closed the app before the words could arrange themselves into Sarah's voice.

At home, Claire met her at the door.

"You took forever."

"School lasts the same amount every day."

"Sit with me."

"I have homework."

"Do it downstairs."

She had used the same words yesterday.

Brooke went upstairs and locked her door, then felt ridiculous and unlocked it. Claire entered without knocking five minutes later and settled on the bed.

"Mom said you were being mean about my food."

"Mom says lots of things."

"You are."

Brooke turned from her desk. "You watched me sleep this morning."

"I waited for you to wake up."

"From inside my room."

"The hall is cold."

Each answer fit the question and left the problem untouched.

Brooke opened footage from the week before Claire became sick. Claire stole food from Brooke's plate, rejected a mushroom on sight, and wandered out of frame halfway through a conversation because something elsewhere had caught her attention. The current Claire sat perfectly still behind the monitor.

"Can you stop comparing me to me?" she asked.

Brooke looked back. "What does that mean?"

"You keep watching old videos like one of us is wrong."

For a moment, Claire sounded exactly like herself. Brooke minimized the footage.

At 6:14, Mark's morning text arrived.

*Road opened. Crew still waiting on clearance. Call tonight.
Love you all.*

The timestamp showed 8:02 a.m.

Brooke showed Sarah. Sarah blamed the network near the hotel. Claire read the message twice and said, “He loves all of us,” as if that were the only part worth verifying.

After dinner, Brooke uploaded *She’s better. I think*. She kept Claire’s face out of it. Over shots of the untouched dog bowl and the kitchen after breakfast, she described the mushroom request, Claire’s repeated invitations to work downstairs, and Cooper’s refusal to approach her. She did not show the growl. She did not ask Claire’s permission.

Before publishing, she watched the whole thing with the cursor over the button. The video made the house seem darker than it was. Her low voice turned small changes into clues. A viewer who had never met Claire would learn that she hated mushrooms because Brooke said so. They would not see Claire trying them last summer on a dare and admitting one was tolerable. They would not see the dozens of mornings she had followed Brooke around simply to be irritating.

Brooke added a sentence near the beginning.

“None of these things means anything by itself. I know that. I’m recording them because I want to know later whether they became a pattern.”

It sounded defensive. She left it in.

The video reached more people than the first two. Brooke avoided the comments.

Then she created a note on her phone.

THINGS I HAVE SEEN

Cooper noticed before the fever.

She likes food she hated.

She does not want to be alone.

She watches me instead of sleeping.

Brooke stopped before adding anything else. Four observations did not make a pattern. They did not make Claire dangerous. They did not make Sarah wrong.

Across the hall, Claire began humming again.

Brooke added one final line.

Check old videos.

She did.

The family archive was not organized by year so much as by whatever storage device had been available when Brooke copied it. She searched filenames for Claire's name and found hundreds of clips: birthdays, school concerts, failed recipes, Cooper as a puppy, beach trips, arguments filmed accidentally because nobody realized the camera was still running.

Brooke sampled them rather than watching whole years disappear. At nine, Claire followed her through a department store because she was afraid of getting lost. At eleven, Claire spent forty minutes alone building a blanket fort and yelled when Brooke entered without permission. Three months ago, Claire fell asleep during a movie and woke furious when Brooke moved her feet.

The archive did not give Brooke a simple before. Claire had always wanted attention until she did not. She had always borrowed clothes, invaded rooms, demanded company, and then vanished into a book or a game for hours. The difference now was not closeness. It was the absence of its opposite.

Brooke added that sentence to the note, then deleted it because it sounded like narration written after the ending.

She replaced it with:

Before, she sometimes wanted to be alone.

Across the hall, a door opened, and bare feet crossed the landing without hurry.

Claire appeared in the doorway. "What are you watching?"

Brooke turned the laptop enough to show a frame of Claire asleep beneath the coffee table at age seven.

"Delete that."

"Dad filmed it."

"Dad has terrible judgment."

"You were cute."

"I look dead."

The word emptied the humor from the room. Claire studied the frozen image, then climbed onto Brooke's bed and sat against the wall.

"I don't remember that," she said.

"You don't remember most things from when you were seven."

"Do you?"

"Some."

“Remember for me.”

Brooke looked at her. Claire’s request was soft, almost embarrassed. It sounded like the kind of thing a younger sister might ask after a hospital stay had frightened her. Brooke began the video.

For twenty minutes they watched their younger selves. Claire laughed at Cooper sliding across the kitchen floor. She supplied the ending to a family joke before the recording reached it. She remembered that Sarah had burned the cupcakes after the camera stopped and that Mark had gone out for doughnuts.

Nothing in her memory was missing.

When Brooke paused, Claire said, “Keep going.”

“I have homework.”

“You can do it later.”

“So can we.”

Claire’s face settled into stillness. “Why would we stop if we’re together now?”

Brooke closed the archive. A moment later Claire smiled, as if she had heard how the sentence sounded and found the correct expression to place over it.

What They Remember

In less than a week, Brooke had stopped startling when she found Claire in a doorway. Her alarm had faded without the danger passing. Sarah called that getting used to her sister again.

That afternoon Brooke came out of the bathroom and found Claire sitting against the hall wall, knees drawn up, waiting. Cooper lay near the stairs, watching them both. Claire had begun reaching for memories absent from Brooke's footage and finding them exactly where she had left them.

"You were in there a long time," Claire said.

"I was in there four minutes."

"It felt long."

Brooke stepped around her. Claire got up and followed, matching her stride into Brooke's room, and settled onto the end of the bed as though the spot had been assigned to her. Brooke sat at the desk and pulled up the timeline she had been building, the folder called *the color* grown fat with clips she no longer wanted to watch. She was aware of Claire behind her the way she was aware of a light left on in another room.

"What are you making?" Claire asked.

"Nothing. Sorting."

"Can I watch?"

"There's nothing to watch. It's files."

Claire hummed. The tune had no shape Brooke could name. It stopped and started with her breathing, and after a minute Brooke realized she had been listening to it instead of the audio in her headphones, and that Claire had moved from the end of the bed to

the edge of the desk without Brooke hearing the mattress release her.

"You used to let me help," Claire said. "You'd give me the boring part. Logging."

"You hated logging."

"I liked sitting with you while you did the fun part."

It was true. Everything Claire said now sat slightly to the left of where it should have been, aimed at a target Brooke could not see until it was hit. Brooke saved the project and closed the laptop.

"I'm going to get coffee," she said.

"I'll come."

"You don't drink coffee."

"I'll come anyway."

Downstairs, Sarah was at the kitchen table with her work laptop and a legal pad, running the household from a chair the way she had run it standing up for years. She looked better than she had during the hospital week. She had washed her hair and put it up properly, and she was answering emails in the brisk, competent voice Brooke had grown up beneath. The television was off. Claire's empty breakfast bowl sat in the sink.

"There's real coffee in the pot," Sarah said without looking up. "I made too much."

Brooke poured a cup. Claire came in behind her and stood close, closer than the kitchen required, until Brooke could feel the warmth of her along one arm. Brooke shifted left. Claire shifted with her.

"Personal space," Brooke said.

"You smell like coffee already and you haven't had any."

"That's the pot."

"It's you," Claire said, and put her forehead briefly against Brooke's shoulder, and Brooke stepped away before she had decided to, coffee sliding to the lip of the cup.

Sarah looked up. "She's just glad you're around. She spent the whole weekend scared."

"I know."

"Then let her be glad."

An easier version of the morning was available if Brooke let Claire lean against her and called it ordinary. Sarah wanted that

version badly enough to narrate it, laying pleasant music beneath different footage.

Brooke took her coffee upstairs. Claire did not follow this time, which was somehow worse, because it meant she had decided to wait.

Brooke opened *Things I Have Seen*. Four observations waited beneath the title, each ordinary enough to explain alone. Together they sounded like an accusation against a kid who had almost died. She checked the timestamp anyway. She wanted the record for later, when everyone agreed it had not been like this.

She added a second heading beneath the list.

THINGS THAT WERE TRUE BEFORE

Claire stole my clothes.

Claire came into my room without knocking.

Claire hated being left out.

Claire sometimes followed me just to annoy me.

Brooke stared at the two lists. The same behavior could belong in either one depending on degree, timing, and the expression on Claire's face. A record could preserve what happened. It could not preserve the exact pressure in a hand or the moment affection became a trap.

She saved both lists. If she was going to build a case against her sister, she would keep the evidence for the defense too.

The rest of the afternoon went the way the days went now. Claire drifted in and out. She wanted to be in the same room. She did not need conversation or attention, only proximity, and she took it in small helpings that never quite added up to something Brooke could point at. Brooke lay down on top of her covers with a headache building behind one eye, and when she woke an hour later Claire was sitting on the floor beside the bed with her back against the frame, close enough that Brooke's hand, hanging off the mattress, had come to rest against her sister's shoulder in her sleep.

Claire had not moved it. She had let it stay there.

"How long have you been in here?" Brooke said.

"A while. You were breathing loud."

Brooke pulled her hand back. Claire turned to look at her, and her face was so purely Claire's, so unremarkably thirteen, that Brooke felt the accusation in her own head curdle into shame. This was her sister. Her sister had been in the hospital.

"Remember when there were storms," Claire said, "and you let me come in here, and I'd count your breaths so I knew you were still there?"

Brooke went still.

She did remember. Claire could not have been more than seven. She had been afraid of thunder in a way that embarrassed her even then, and she would appear in Brooke's doorway with her pillow, and Brooke, ten and eleven and self-important, had made a rule of it to keep her from making it a habit. One storm. One night. Claire could stay if she stayed quiet, and Claire had lain rigid on the far edge of the bed with her hand flat against Brooke's back, and in the morning she had said, without being asked, that she had listened to Brooke breathing and known she had not left. It was a small thing. Brooke had not thought about it in years. It was not in any video. It had happened in the dark, where nothing was recorded, which was exactly why it should not have been able to reach her the way it did.

"You still do that," Brooke said slowly. "You still listen to me breathe."

"I like knowing you're there."

"You're thirteen."

"So? You liked it too. You never made me leave in the middle."

That was true as well. Brooke stood up, because the conversation had a floor she did not want to find. She stepped over Claire's legs toward the door.

Claire's hand closed around her wrist.

It was not a grab. Claire did not lunge or clutch. Her hand simply closed around Brooke's wrist and tightened past the pressure of affection and past the pressure of a joke, as if she did not know when a wrist was done.

"Claire."

"Stay a minute."

"You're hurting me."

"I don't want to let go." Her voice was calm. Her thumb had found the small bones on the inside of Brooke's wrist and pressed. "I just got you back. I don't want you to keep leaving rooms."

Brooke's heart was going hard. She kept her voice level because level was the only tool she had. "Claire, look at me. You're squeezing too hard."

Down the hall, Cooper barked. One sharp report, then a second, aimed at the closed door.

Claire's hand opened.

It happened all at once, her fingers releasing and her whole face changing, the calm dropping out of it. For one second she looked at her own hand around her sister's wrist as though it belonged to a stranger, and her mouth opened, and something came up behind her eyes that was frightened and thirteen and entirely Claire.

"Sorry," she whispered. "I didn't."

Then the second passed. The fear left Claire's face. She looked at Brooke's freed wrist with mild, distant interest.

"You have marks," Claire said.

Brooke pulled her arm against her chest. Four pale ovals were coming up red along the inside of her wrist, filling in as she watched.

"I'm going downstairs," Brooke said.

Claire did not follow. She stayed on the floor by the bed and began, quietly, to hum.

Brooke sat in the powder room off the dining room with the door locked and her wrist under cold water, which did nothing, and looked at herself in the mirror until her pulse came down. She did not cry. She took out her phone and photographed the marks with the time visible in the corner of the screen, and she did not know what she was building the case for, only that she was building one.

Mark called at eight-forty.

Sarah put him on speaker in the kitchen while she dried dishes, and Brooke came in for it because his calls had a schedule and the schedule was the last dependable thing left in the day. His face loaded slowly, blocky and dim, the light behind him orange and wrong.

"There they are," he said. The audio arrived a half-second behind his mouth. "Both of you. How's my patient?"

“Better,” Sarah said. “Eating. Sleeping.”

“Yeah?” His voice warmed. “Claire, you giving your sister a hard time yet? That’s how I’ll know you’re all the way back.”

Claire had come to the doorway. She looked at the phone on the counter without moving toward it. “Hi, Dad.”

“Hi, bug.”

Behind him, faintly, under the fan-hum of bad service, there were voices.

Brooke heard them before she understood she was hearing them. Not the television. Mark was in a hotel, and hotels had televisions, and she told herself that first. But televisions had music and stings and the shape of edited sound, and this had none of that. It was people. Several people, low and even, none of them raised, none of them close to the phone, saying words the connection would not carry. The cadence of them was wrong in a way she could not have defended to Sarah. They did not sound like a party or a lobby or a crew. They sounded like a room full of people who had all decided to speak at the same soft volume.

“Dad,” Brooke said. “Who’s with you?”

“What?”

“There’s people. Behind you.”

A pause that was too long to be the delay. “Hotel’s full,” Mark said. “They put up families that couldn’t get home. Everybody and their brother stuck here.” His eyes moved off the camera, toward something to his left, and came back. “Listen, the building’s a mess. They found more damage behind the panels than anybody wanted. I don’t know when they’re going to clear us to leave.”

“You said Saturday night,” Claire said. “Four days ago.”

“I know, bug.”

“You keep saying it.”

“I keep meaning it.” He smiled, and the smile was Mark’s smile, tired and real, and it made the voices behind him worse. “Tell you what. When I do get on the road, I’m not stopping for anything. Not gas, not coffee, not your mother’s cousin in Danbury. Straight through.”

Sarah laughed, a small sound. Brooke did not.

“Mark,” Sarah said, “the girls should hear you say goodnight, the connection’s about to die.”

“Goodnight, girls. Claire, be nice. Brooke.” His eyes found the lens and held it, and for a moment the delay lined up and he was looking right at her. “Keep an eye on things. You’re good at that.”

The voices behind him rose slightly. Not louder. More of them.

“Dad,” Brooke said, “can you go somewhere quieter and call back? I want to actually hear you.”

“I’ll try in the morn”

The call ended. Not dropped in the middle of motion, the way calls died in that building, freezing him mid-gesture. It ended clean, the screen going to the flat gray of a finished connection, his name and the duration sitting under a still frame of the empty orange room he had been sitting in.

Mark. 8:41 PM. 3 min 12 sec.

Sarah set down the dish towel. “His phone dies in there. You know that.”

“I know.”

“Then don’t do the face.”

“I’m not doing a face.”

But she had opened the phone’s own recording, the one it made of video calls when she remembered to start it, and she had remembered. She put in one earbud in the powder room with the door locked and scrubbed to the last thirty seconds and turned the volume as high as it went, past the point of comfort, into the hiss.

Under her father’s voice saying he would try in the morning, under the fan and the bad signal and the flat digital wind of the call, the other voices were there. She could not make out a single word. She played it twice more and stopped before noise could become language simply because she wanted it to.

She exported the audio without cleaning it. Noise reduction could invent edges that were not there. She named the file with the date, time, and nothing else.

For the first time, Brooke understood that remembering accurately might require leaving some things unresolved.

She stopped the recording. She sat on the closed lid of the toilet for a while with the earbud still in and the silence in it.

Then she took out her phone and opened *Things I Have Seen*.

They remember everything. Claire counting breaths in the dark lived nowhere but inside the two of them, on no card in the

lockbox or footage Brooke had kept. Claire might only have wanted to remind her that she had once been welcome. Brooke could not tell where remembering ended and pressure began.

Frame by Frame

Brooke showed Sarah the marks in the morning.

She had planned the conversation in the shower. She would be calm. She would show the timestamped photograph and the yellowing ovals still visible inside her wrist. Facts were harder to argue with. That was why she recorded things.

Sarah stood at the counter with her coffee and read a health-department alert aloud. Recovery rates were above ninety percent statewide. Updated guidance replaced *isolation* with *support at home* and encouraged families to provide reassurance after acute symptoms ended.

“Claire grabbed me last night,” Brooke said. “Hard.”

Sarah looked at the marks. “She almost died on Sunday. Now she wants to hold on to her sister.”

“I told her she was hurting me.”

“And she let go.”

“After Cooper barked.”

Sarah set her phone facedown. “I know you’re frightened. I was there when she was sick. But you have decided something about Claire, and now you’re collecting evidence for it. She is not a project.”

“I’m writing down what happens.”

“You’re deciding what it means.” Sarah picked up the phone again. “It’s unkind, Brooke. She adores you, and you’re treating her like she’s contagious.”

The word found the cruel sentence Brooke had used on Claire before the fever. Maybe the list was not evidence. Maybe it was an

alibi, a way to make the sister she had hurt into something that deserved suspicion.

Brooke nearly accepted that because it was the kinder explanation.

At school she carried the argument with her. Every time somebody touched somebody else, she heard Sarah say *collecting evidence*. Every recovered student became a test Brooke had designed after deciding the answer. She filmed nothing.

In media studies, Mr. Vale played a documentary excerpt and asked the class when observation became exploitation. The timing felt so exact that Brooke almost laughed. A filmmaker, he said, could preserve a truth while violating the person whose truth it was. Good intentions did not erase power. Neither did public interest.

“What if the person being filmed doesn’t understand why the footage matters yet?” Brooke asked.

Mr. Vale leaned against his desk. “Then the filmmaker has more responsibility, not less.”

“What if waiting means losing the proof?”

“Proof of what?”

Several students looked at her. Brooke stared at the paused frame on the classroom screen.

“Anything,” she said.

“Then you document the event in the least harmful way available. You keep originals. You separate what you saw from what you think it means. And you accept that sometimes the ethical choice costs you the image.”

Brooke wrote the sentence down even though it was not part of the lesson.

Then she went upstairs and opened the footage.

She arranged the clips by date and watched them once for picture and once for sound. Most contained exactly what Sarah would have seen: humming, following, a shoulder held too close. A camera did not care what Brooke feared. Its indifference began to feel like a verdict.

She created two columns in a notebook.

In the first, she wrote only what the camera contained: Claire entered at 2:13 a.m. Claire stood for forty-seven seconds. Claire placed both hands on the door. Cooper remained downstairs.

In the second, she wrote what she believed: Claire was watching. Claire wanted the door open. Cooper knew something.

The first column looked harmless. The second looked paranoid. Both described the same clip.

She found the frame in a twelve-second hallway clip from two nights earlier. Claire stood at the dark end of the landing, looking toward the stairs while Cooper remained below. When Claire lifted her face, her eyes caught the weak streetlight and returned a greenish shine.

Brooke stopped.

One frame later, it was gone.

She moved backward, then forward. The color appeared only once. It was not a glow. It could have been the sensor forcing detail out of darkness, a passing car, or an ordinary reflection at the wrong angle.

Brooke spent the next hour testing the camera rather than Claire. Her own eyes reflected gray, then caught a weak green edge when she changed the angle. Sarah's flashed white under the phone's automatic processing. Cooper's returned yellow-green almost every time. Cameras made eyes strange in darkness. Claire's frame still looked different, the color sharp inside the pupil, but looking different was not proof.

She copied the original file to the camera card and wrote one line beside the observation: *One frame reflected green. Could be the camera.*

That evening she tried to reproduce it.

She left the overhead light off and set her phone on the shelf facing the bed. The monitor gave the room a weak blue cast. When she opened the door, Claire appeared within a minute and sat at the edge of the mattress.

"You're up late," Claire said.

"So are you."

"I couldn't sleep."

Brooke asked about school and a show they used to watch. She kept Claire talking while the phone recorded, then asked her to move closer to the window because the light was better there.

"Are you filming me?"

The question stopped Brooke.

"The room."

Claire looked toward the shelf. "Am I in it?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

Brooke could have said she was testing the camera. That would have been true. Instead she reached up and stopped the recording.

"I wanted to check something."

"About me?"

Brooke did not answer quickly enough.

Claire's face changed, not into the flat calm Brooke feared but into ordinary hurt. "You said I get a veto."

"You do."

"After you start?"

Brooke lowered the phone. "I'm sorry."

Claire stood. For a moment Brooke expected her to refuse the apology or demand that Brooke follow. Claire only said, "Delete it."

Brooke deleted the clip in front of her. Claire watched the screen until it disappeared, then left the room without asking Brooke to come.

The failed experiment should have made Brooke feel better. It did not. She had used Claire's need for her as bait and learned nothing except that Claire still understood a promise Brooke had broken.

Claire avoided her for almost an hour afterward. She sat with Sarah in the living room and answered Brooke's questions with one word. The distance was what Brooke had wanted all week. Once she had it, guilt made the whole downstairs feel airless.

Brooke brought Claire a glass of water.

"Peace offering," she said.

Claire accepted it without drinking. "Do you think I'm lying?"

"About what?"

"Everything."

Brooke sat in the armchair across from the sofa. Cooper came to her side but kept watching Claire.

"I think something happened to you," Brooke said.

"I got sick."

"After."

"I got better."

Sarah looked up from her laptop. Brooke continued before she could intervene.

“Do you feel different?”

Claire thought about it. That was worse than an immediate denial. “I don’t like being by myself.”

“You used to.”

“Maybe I was wrong.”

“Wrong about liking it?”

“Wrong about needing it.”

Sarah closed the laptop. “This is exactly what I asked you to stop doing.”

Brooke looked at Claire. “Do you hear anything?”

Claire’s fingers tightened around the water glass.

“What would I hear?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then how would I know?”

There was no answer Brooke could give without teaching Claire what answer she wanted.

“I’m sorry I filmed you,” Brooke said.

Claire nodded once. “Okay.”

“That doesn’t mean I’m sorry I asked.”

Claire’s mouth moved toward a smile and stopped. “Okay.”

Brooke went upstairs knowing she had conducted another experiment without a camera.

Later, while clearing accidental recordings, Brooke opened a forty-second clip of her empty bedroom from the previous afternoon. Traffic moved outside. The house settled. Then Claire entered.

She crossed to the desk and looked at the dark laptop. She sat on the edge of Brooke’s bed, hands flat on her knees, facing the doorway.

Near the end, she spoke.

The waveform barely rose. Brooke put in an earbud and increased the volume.

“Wait.”

Or perhaps it was the beginning of *wait for me*, cut short when the recording ended. It might have been directed at Brooke downstairs, a memory of something she meant to say, or no word at all. The consonant frayed inside the room noise.

Brooke listened once more. The more she replayed it, the less certain it became.

Downstairs, Claire laughed at something Sarah said. The sound was warm and familiar.

Brooke considered showing Sarah the frame and the audio. She could already hear the reasonable answers: cameras invented color in darkness; a girl alone in her sister's room might say her sister's name, or tell her to wait, or talk to herself. Sarah would be right about the evidence even if she was wrong about Claire.

Brooke saved the original hallway clip and the accidental bedroom recording. She did not label either as proof. In *Things I Have Seen*, she added:

*She may have said wait when she thought she was alone.
Audio unclear.*

Underneath, she added a rule for herself.

Record behavior. Label interpretation. Do not confuse them.

She closed the laptop when the stairs went quiet. The frame had not answered anything. It had only given uncertainty a color.

CHAPTER 12

Everyone Is Fine

Brooke went back to school because staying home had started to feel like agreeing with the house.

Sarah drove her, pleased about it in a way she did not hide, as though Brooke returning to a normal building for a normal day were a small vote against everything Brooke had been saying. Claire wanted to come to the car. She stood on the front step in the cold in her socks until Sarah told her to go back inside, and she watched them pull out with both hands pressed to the storm door glass, and Brooke made herself look forward and not back at the two pale prints her sister's palms left on the door.

Ashcroft High was open and lit and full, and for the first ten minutes it was so ordinary that Brooke felt the accusation settle back over her. The buses idled. The disinfectant bottles still sat by two classroom doors. A banner for the winter fundraiser sagged over the main hall. People had come back. That was the story the building told, and it was a good story, and Brooke wanted to believe it more than she wanted to be right.

It was not, when she looked, quite full. Three lockers down from hers, one had been cleared and its door taped shut. Dwayne Ortiz, who sat behind her in chemistry and had spent all of September narrating soccer scores she had not asked for, was not at his station, and his stool had been moved against the wall. He had gone into Saint Vincent's the same week as Claire. Claire had come home. The stool against the wall was the difference between them, and the building had decided not to look at it.

Then she started to see it, and once she started she could not stop, because seeing was the only thing she was good at.

It was in the way people sat. In the library, a senior and a freshman shared one edge of an otherwise empty table. Brooke was fairly sure they did not know each other. When the freshman got up for a book, the senior turned to keep her in view.

In homeroom, Mr. Bell passed around a plastic container of olives. He had spent three years complaining that the smell of olives ruined the faculty refrigerator. Now he ate them between attendance names and offered them to students with an absent generosity. Three people accepted. One was a girl Brooke had once watched remove an olive from nachos with a napkin.

“New health kick?” somebody asked.

Mr. Bell looked at the olive pinched between his fingers as if he had forgotten it was there. “They taste clean.”

The room laughed. He laughed too, a little late, and set the container on the desk where anybody could reach it.

And it was outside the second-floor bathroom, where a girl stood waiting.

Brooke almost walked past her. She was a small girl, maybe a freshman, standing against the wall beside the bathroom door with her backpack still on both shoulders, and she was not on her phone and not doing homework and not doing any of the things people did while they waited. She was just watching the door. When it opened and another girl came out, the waiting girl straightened and fell into step so close behind her that they moved through the hallway as one shape, and Brooke understood that she had been standing outside a bathroom door for however long it takes, waiting, because the person inside had gone somewhere she could not follow, and the waiting had been the whole activity.

Brooke stood at her locker and felt the specific loneliness of being the only person in a building who could see the water rising.

She went to the counselor’s office at lunch, not because she had decided to but because her feet took her there while her head was still arguing. Ms. Ferro had been the school counselor since Brooke was a freshman, a kind, tired woman with a candy dish and a poster about feelings, and Brooke thought that if she said it out loud to one adult who was paid to listen, she would find out whether she was crazy.

"I'm glad you came in," Ms. Ferro said, before Brooke had said anything. "It's been a hard couple of weeks. A lot of our recovered individuals are back this week, and that's wonderful, but it can be an adjustment for everybody."

Recovered individuals. Brooke had heard the phrase that morning on the news alert Sarah read at the counter, in the same shape, in the same slot in the sentence. Two days ago the word had been *victims*. She had watched it change.

"Some kids seem different," Brooke said carefully. "Since they got better."

"Of course they do." Ms. Ferro smiled. "They've been through something frightening. What they need most right now is reassurance. Closeness. To feel that their people are near." She said *their people are near* like a line she had been given, warm and smooth and slightly too finished, the way you can hear a phone menu underneath a real voice. "The worst thing we can do is make them feel separated after everything. We're all just so glad to have everyone back together."

For a moment her eyes went to a small framed photograph that had not been on the desk in September, a math teacher Brooke half recognized. The smoothness left her voice. "Some families aren't getting their person back at all. When yours walks in the door, you hold on to them." The grief in it was real and unrehearsed, and it made the borrowed phrases around it more persuasive, not less.

"Right," Brooke said.

"Are you sleeping okay?"

"Yeah."

"Your sister's home safe. That's the main thing." Ms. Ferro's eyes were kind and did not have the green in them, and her hands were normal on the desk, and she was, Brooke was almost certain, exactly what she had always been, an unchanged woman repeating language that had been fed to her because it sounded like compassion and cost nothing to say. That was the part that frightened Brooke most in the whole building. It did not need everyone to be changed. It only needed the changed to set the words, and the unchanged to find them reasonable.

Brooke took a candy she did not want and left.

She was tired in a way that had gone past her body by the time the last bell rang. She texted Sarah that she wanted to walk Cooper

before dinner, which was true, and that she would be home by five, which she intended, and Sarah, delighted by the ordinariness of a girl wanting to walk her dog, said fine and did not argue. Brooke walked home, clipped Cooper's leash on in the front hall while Claire hovered and asked twice to come and was told no by Sarah, and got out of the house with the dog and the leash and the leftover daylight, and for six blocks she felt something that was almost like being a person again.

The small dog park off Linden was nearly empty. A man threw a ball for a spaniel at the far end and did not look up. Brooke let Cooper off the leash inside the fence and sat on the low bench. Cooper put his nose to the ground and became a dog again, snuffling the fence line with his tail up.

"He looks relieved," a woman said.

She was sitting at the other end of the bench. Brooke had not heard her arrive, or she had been there the whole time and Brooke had not registered her. She was somewhere in her forties, dressed plainly and warmly, with a paper pharmacy bag beside her and one glove folded inside the other. She had no dog.

"He's had a weird week," Brooke said, because it was easier than deciding not to answer.

"A lot of us have." The woman watched Cooper work the fence. "He's a good watcher. Or maybe he just likes the fence."

Brooke's attention sharpened by a degree. "Yeah," she said. "He does."

"People don't listen to dogs enough." The woman adjusted the pharmacy bag before the wind could tip it over. "I cut through here from the store sometimes. Quieter than Linden."

Cooper came back across the grass. He had been happy, loose, and as he got closer to the bench Brooke watched him take in the woman. He slowed. His tail came down, not tucked, only lowered, and he stopped a few feet off and looked at her, and his nose worked, and he did not come the rest of the way.

Brooke went cold for a second, because she knew that slowing. She had built a whole document around that slowing.

But it was not the same as Claire. Cooper did not back away. He held his ground and watched the woman, tail low, while she kept her hands to herself. After a moment he sat several feet away, still facing her.

“He doesn’t have to come over,” the woman said. “He doesn’t know me. That’s smart.”

“He usually likes everybody,” Brooke said, and heard herself apologizing for the dog, and did not know why she wanted the woman not to feel rejected.

“He likes you,” the woman said. “That’s the important one.”

They sat. The spaniel and its owner left. The light went from gold to gray at the tops of the trees.

“You make videos,” the woman said, and Brooke’s whole body went still, and the woman must have felt it, because she went on gently, without turning it into a demand. “I’ve watched your videos. The ones about the illness. Your sister.” She said it plainly, a fact offered and then set down, no question attached to it. “You see things clearly. Most people don’t. You looked at what everyone was calling recovery and you noticed it was wrong, and you kept noticing, even when it made you the only one.”

It was the thing Brooke had wanted an adult to say to her all day, all week, and it had come from a stranger on a bench who wanted nothing, who had not even asked her a question, who had simply named the true thing and left it there for Brooke to pick up or not. Brooke felt her eyes sting and hated it and looked at the dog.

“Everybody thinks I’m being dramatic,” she said.

“You’re not being dramatic.” The woman said it the way you state the weather. “You’re paying attention. It’s a lonely thing to do. I’m sorry it’s lonely.”

Brooke did not say anything for a while. The woman picked at a loose corner of the pharmacy receipt, folded it, and tucked it into the bag.

Cooper got up, finally, and came to Brooke, and pushed his head under her hand, and turned to keep the woman in his sight while he did it. Brooke clipped the leash on. It was almost five.

“I have to get back,” Brooke said.

“Of course.” The woman pulled on the second glove. “Go carefully. It gets dark fast now.”

Brooke was halfway to the gate before she realized she had not gotten the woman’s name. She looked back. The woman was still on the bench, hands folded, watching Cooper go with an expression Brooke could not read at that distance and did not try

to. She lifted one hand, not a wave exactly, just an acknowledgment. Brooke lifted hers and went out through the gate into the falling dark, feeling lighter than she had in days. After a week of people clinging to her or telling her she was cruel, a person who wanted nothing had felt like water.

That night, in her room, with the house quiet and Claire finally asleep or pretending to be across the hall, Brooke did the thing she had been building toward all week without admitting it. She recorded a short video. No footage, no editing, just her own face lit by the monitor, tired, plain, done with being careful.

"I'm going to ask something and I don't care if it makes me sound crazy," she said. "The people who got sick and got better. Are they different now? Not sad-different. Not tired-different. Different. Do they need to be near you all the time? Do they eat things they used to hate? Do animals not like them anymore?" She stopped. She had a list open off-camera and she did not read from it, but she knew it by heart now. "I'm not saying I know what it is. I don't. I'm asking if anyone else is seeing it, because everyone around me is telling me I'm imagining it, and I need to know if I am."

She titled it *Is anyone else seeing this?* and posted it under her own name and closed the laptop and lay down and did not expect anything, because the last three videos had gotten mockery and a joke about fruit punch.

When she woke in the night and checked, out of the habit she could not break, there were comments.

my mom too. exactly this. i thought it was just me.

our dog won't go near my brother anymore and he grew up with him. what is happening.

Brooke lay in the dark holding the phone above her face, its light the only light in the room, as new replies arrived beneath the first two. She was not alone. That should have helped. Instead, every reply became another house like hers with something quiet walking through it, all of them finding one another in the dark.

CHAPTER 13

There You Are

The comments were still coming the next morning. Brooke did not read them on the bus. The number beside the upload rose each time she checked, proof enough that other people had started saying the same impossible thing.

At school the water had risen another inch. She could not stop seeing it now. By third period she wanted out of the building the way you want out of a dream, and she went to the front office and said she had a headache and asked to sign out early.

Before she left, she saw Mason standing outside the nurse's office with both hands around another student's wrist. The other boy was not struggling. He was crying into Mason's shoulder while the nurse spoke to them in the same calm tone Ms. Ferro had used.

"Nobody is sending anybody away," the nurse said. "We're keeping everyone together until a parent comes."

The boy lifted his face. "My mom said I could walk."

"Your mother will feel better knowing you aren't alone."

Mason looked across the hall at Brooke. His gaze rested on her without embarrassment. The boy's wrist remained enclosed in his hands.

Brooke took out her phone, then remembered Mr. Vale's question. *Proof of what?* She photographed the nurse's office sign and the time on the wall clock, not the boys. In her notes she wrote exactly what she had seen. She did not write what she thought Mason would do if the boy tried to leave.

The woman at the desk was sympathetic and did not let her go. District guidance required a parent or listed guardian to sign out

any student reporting illness, and Sarah could not leave work. The woman offered the nurse's office instead, where people could keep an eye on Brooke rather than send her home alone. She said *alone* like it was the dangerous part.

She lay in the nurse's office until the final bell and then went home, because home was where Claire was, and there was no version of the day that did not end with Claire.

By evening the house had closed around her again.

Sarah made dinner. Claire ate roasted squash and did not comment on it and watched Brooke across the table, not hostile, not anything, just watching, the way she watched now, keeping Brooke in view the way the senior in the library had kept the freshman in view. Sarah talked about ordinary things in an ordinary voice, and it should have been comforting and was not, because the ordinariness had become a thing the house performed at her, a smoothness laid over the top of something to keep her from looking under it.

After dinner Brooke needed to be behind a door.

That was all it was. She was not hiding. She just needed four minutes in a room where no one was watching her, and the hall bathroom was the closest one, and she went in and pushed the little lever lock on the handle and sat on the edge of the tub in the light of the one weak fixture and put her face in her hands and breathed.

She had left her phone charging in her room. She reached toward an empty pocket, then let it go. She was sitting in a bathroom. She did not need to record it.

The knock came soft.

"Brooke?"

"I'm in here."

"I know. Can I come in?"

"I'm using the bathroom."

"You're not, though." Claire's voice was patient and certain on the other side of the door, and the certainty was the first thing that was wrong, because Claire could not have known that, unless she had been standing close enough to the door to hear that Brooke had done nothing but sit down. "You're just sitting. I can come in while you sit."

"No. Go away for two minutes."

There was a pause. Brooke pictured her on the other side of the door, and the picture her mind produced, without her permission, was of Claire standing in the hall exactly the way the freshman had stood outside the second-floor bathroom, backpack off now but otherwise the same, patient, aimed at the door, waiting because waiting was the whole activity.

"I don't want to be out here," Claire said.

"You're fine out there."

"I don't like it. The hall's too big." Her voice did something on *too big*, a small catch, real distress underneath it. "Just let me in. I'll sit on the floor. I won't even talk. I just want to be where you are."

"Claire."

"Please." That was the next rung, and Brooke heard it as a rung even then, the shift from asking to pleading, so smooth it barely had edges. "Please, I'll be so quiet. I don't want to be by myself. Why do you keep going where I can't be?"

"Because sometimes people close a door. That's normal. That's allowed."

"I can't be out here." Not angry. Stated. "You keep going where I can't follow and I can't stand it, Brooke, I can't, please open the door."

Brooke stood up. Her heart had started going. "I'm going to open it in a minute. Go wait in my room. Sit on my bed. I'll come find you."

"I want you now."

"Claire, back up from the door."

The handle turned. It caught on the lock, the little lever holding, and it turned again, harder, the mechanism straining, and Brooke watched the handle jerk against its stop and understood with a slow cold clarity that her sister was not going to stop, that the sounds she had put in a document under the heading of things she had seen were about to become a thing she saw.

"Claire, stop. The door's locked, stop turning it."

"Then unlock it."

"Stop."

She did not stop. There was a short silence, the specific silence of someone changing their grip, and then the handle wrenched sideways with a force that had no anger in it at all, an even

mechanical force like the grip on Brooke's wrist two nights before, and the lever snapped its travel and something in the jamb gave with a splintering crack, and the door shuddered inward against Brooke's hand where she had put it flat against the wood without deciding to.

She stepped back. The door swung open.

Claire stood in the doorway in the weak hall light. She was not breathing hard. Her face was not the face of a girl who had just broken a door. It was calm, and it was glad, and when she saw Brooke standing there against the sink with nowhere to go, her whole expression opened into a warmth so genuine and so wrong that Brooke felt it in her stomach.

"There you are," Claire said.

She came in. She did not lunge. She crossed the small space the way she crossed any room now, unhurried, certain of her welcome, and she put her arms around Brooke and pressed her face into Brooke's shoulder and held on, and it was a hug, that was the unbearable part, it was a thirteen-year-old hugging her big sister, and the arms around Brooke tightened past the pressure of a hug and kept tightening with that same even patience, and Claire made a small satisfied sound against her collarbone and said, muffled, "I don't like it when there's a door."

Brooke stood rigid with her arms half-raised and did not hug her back and looked over Claire's head at the ruined doorframe, the pale splintered wood, the lever handle hanging at a broken angle. There was blood on it. A dark smear along the metal where Claire had wrenched it, and more of it, she saw now, on Claire's right hand where it lay against Brooke's arm, a torn place across two knuckles welling slowly, leaving a small red print on Brooke's sleeve.

"Claire, your hand."

"It doesn't matter."

"You're bleeding, you cut your hand on the lock."

"It doesn't matter." Claire did not look at it. Her hand was split open and pressed against Brooke's arm, but the injury was not enough to make her release the hug.

Cooper appeared in the doorway.

He did not bark. He came into the small bathroom low and stiff, his whole body a line of tension, and he pushed himself

between the two girls, physically, his shoulder wedging in against Brooke's legs, putting his body where the space between the sisters used to be. He did not growl at Claire. He did not snap. He faced her and leaned his weight into Brooke and stood there trembling, insisting on the inch of separation with his own body, and Claire, feeling the dog force his way in against her, loosened her arms and looked down at him.

For one second Brooke thought something would happen to the dog. She got a hand into Cooper's collar without knowing she had moved.

But Claire only looked at him. Whatever it was that had made her break a lock and ignore her own torn hand, it stopped at the dog. She lifted her injured hand away from Brooke, the blood on it dark in the poor light, and she did not touch Cooper, and she did not push him, and something crossed her face that might have been confusion, a flicker of the girl who had grown up with this dog and fed him bread under the table her whole life. Then she stepped back, giving the space Cooper demanded, and the warmth came back over her features.

"He's still weird," Claire said, in a voice that was almost normal, almost her own, and it was that, the almost, that finally undid Brooke's composure.

Sarah came up the stairs then, alerted by the crack of the jamb or by the quality of the quiet. She took in the broken door and the blood and Brooke pinned against the sink with the dog between her and Claire. Her hand closed around the banister. Then she moved to Claire.

"What happened?"

"She broke the lock," Brooke said. Her voice came out flat and careful and much steadier than she felt. "I closed the door and she broke the lock to get in."

Sarah looked once more at the splintered jamb. "The lock was old." She reached for Claire's hand and turned it over, her mouth tightening at the torn knuckles. "Claire, baby, look what you did to yourself. Why would you do that?"

"I wanted to be with Brooke."

"She wouldn't let me in."

"You can't break a door because you want to be with someone." Sarah looked again at the splintered jamb before her gaze returned to Brooke. "Why did you lock it?"

"Because I wanted to be alone for four minutes."

"She almost died last week, Brooke."

"I know that. I keep saying I know that." Brooke heard her own voice climb and pulled it back down, because climbing lost. "Look at her hand. Mom. Look at it. She tore her hand open on the lock and she hasn't looked at it once. Does that seem like a scared kid to you, or does that seem like something else?"

Sarah was pressing a towel to Claire's knuckles. Claire watched her do it with mild interest, the way you watch someone else's small injury being tended. "Kids get hurt and don't notice when they're upset," Sarah said. "Adrenaline. It's nothing."

"It's not nothing."

"Go to your room, Brooke." Not cruel. Exhausted. "Please. I can't do this and take care of her hand at the same time. Just go."

Brooke went. She kept her hand in Cooper's collar and drew the dog with her out of the bathroom and down the hall to her own room, and she shut the door, and she stood in the middle of the room with her heart slamming and understood the true horror of the last ten minutes only now that it was over.

She had no footage. Sarah had already called the lock old, and Brooke could feel the scene becoming arguable.

She wrote it down while it was sharp: the turning handle, the blood on the lever, *There you are*, Cooper forcing an inch of space. A written account was not proof, but it was what she had.

Then she made herself add the parts that complicated it. Claire had stopped when Cooper intervened. Claire had not pushed him. Claire had looked confused. The hug had begun gently.

Brooke wanted a clean account in which every detail pointed in the same direction. The truth would not give her one.

It isn't trauma. I don't know what it is, but trauma does not explain all of it.

Across the hall, through the wall, she heard the water run in the bathroom while Sarah cleaned the blood off the broken lock. And under the water, very quietly, so quietly that Brooke pressed her ear to the cold wall to be sure, she heard her sister, alone for a

moment on the landing while their mother rinsed the towel, cradling the hand she had finally been left alone with, drawing a breath in through her teeth at the sting of it.

So she had felt it. She had felt it the whole time. It had hurt, and she had known it hurt, and it simply had not been enough to make her stop.

Brooke stayed against the wall with Cooper leaning into her legs. Claire had felt the injury. It simply had not mattered until Brooke was no longer within reach.

CHAPTER 14

Sand

Sarah removed the broken bathroom handle before breakfast.

She set the pieces on the kitchen counter beside a roll of gauze and the receipt from the hardware store, as if arranging them neatly might reduce what had happened to an ordinary household repair. The bent lever was still marked with a dark line of Claire's blood. Sarah had cleaned the rest of it from the jamb, but the wood around the latch remained split and pale.

"Your dad can replace the whole assembly when he gets home," she said.

Brooke looked at the empty rectangle where the handle had been. "When is that?"

Sarah took longer than she should have to fold the receipt. "He texted overnight. They're still waiting on an inspection."

"Can I see it?"

"The text?"

"No, the inspection."

Sarah gave her the look that used to mean Brooke was being difficult for sport. It had not changed, which made Brooke hate herself for studying it. "Yes, the text."

Mark had written at 1:14 a.m.

Still here. Site inspection got pushed. Signal terrible. Tell the girls I love them.

No joke. No new promise about tomorrow. Brooke read it twice before returning the phone.

Claire sat at the table with two bandaged knuckles. The injured hand rested beside her bowl, palm down, as if it belonged to somebody seated next to her. Cooper had chosen the strip of floor between Brooke's chair and the back door.

Sarah had made breakfast. Claire was eating. The bathroom needed a new lock. If Brooke told the story wrong, it became a story about a frightened girl, an old handle, and a dog who had gotten underfoot.

She took a picture of the broken lever before Sarah threw it away.

Claire watched her do it. "Are you going to put that online?"

"No."

"Why take it?"

"Because it happened."

"You were there."

"So were you."

Claire considered this. "You could've opened the door."

Sarah stopped wiping the counter.

Brooke looked at the white gauze around Claire's hand. "You could've waited four minutes."

"I tried."

"No, you asked for maybe thirty seconds and then broke the lock."

"It felt longer."

Sarah put the cloth in the sink. "We're not doing this again before school."

Brooke laughed. "She's going to school?"

"Both of you are."

"She broke a door."

"And I am dealing with it."

Claire said, "I feel fine."

That was the phrase everyone trusted now. The anchors said it. The hospital notices said it. Parents wrote it beneath Brooke's uploads as if feeling fine answered every question about what happened after the fever went away.

Sarah told Claire to take her antibiotic ointment to the nurse. Brooke did not point out that there was no medicine for whatever had made the injury unimportant. She went upstairs, packed her

camera, and waited until she heard Claire enter her own room before leaving hers.

At school, Claire stayed close enough that Brooke could feel her without looking.

She appeared outside Brooke's first-period classroom before the bell, leaning against the lockers in Brooke's green flannel. The shirt had vanished from Brooke's chair sometime after midnight.

"Give it back," Brooke said.

"I'm cold."

"You have clothes."

"I like this one."

Brooke reached for the sleeve. Claire caught her wrist with the bandaged hand.

The grip was immediate and firm. Claire did not squeeze hard enough to hurt. She only prevented Brooke from stepping away, her thumb resting above Brooke's pulse while students passed around them.

"Let go."

"Walk me downstairs."

"Your class is downstairs. Mine is here."

"You can come back."

The warning bell rang. A teacher at the far end of the hall called for everyone to move. Claire did not look toward the voice.

"You're going to make me late," Brooke said.

"Then we'll both be late."

Brooke pulled once. Claire's hand tightened.

"Claire."

"Just downstairs."

Brooke walked her downstairs.

By lunch, Claire had found her again. She slid into the seat beside Brooke in the library and pushed her chair close enough that their knees touched beneath the table. The librarian glanced up, saw two sisters together, and returned to her computer.

Brooke had begun choosing public rooms because Claire behaved better in them. That morning proved the strategy had an expiration date.

"Don't you have lunch?" Brooke asked.

"I brought it."

Brooke opened her laptop. A notification count covered the corner of the upload page, but she did not click it. "I'm working."

"I can sit while you work."

"I need to be alone."

Claire's chewing slowed. "Why?"

"Because I do."

"You keep saying that like it explains something."

"It explains enough."

Brooke moved to the chair across the table. Claire moved too. Brooke gathered the laptop and camera bag and stood.

Claire caught the strap.

The camera bag stopped against Brooke's shoulder. Claire remained seated, one hand wrapped around the black webbing, calm as if she had reached out to keep a book from falling.

"Let go."

"Sit down."

"You're doing it again."

"I'm not hurting you."

"That isn't the rule."

Claire looked genuinely puzzled. "What rule?"

The librarian shushed someone near the printers. Beyond the windows, wind moved through the bare branches above the athletic field. Brooke thought about calling the librarian over. She imagined explaining the bathroom lock, the bleeding hand, the grip on the stairs, and the answer she would receive: Claire had been very ill. Claire needed reassurance. Brooke should be patient.

She lowered the bag to the table but did not sit.

"Do you remember the beach?" she asked.

Claire blinked.

"When you were six. You buried my legs."

"I remember."

"What did you say?"

Claire held the strap.

"You kept rebuilding the sand every time the water knocked it down," Brooke said. "You were furious at the ocean."

"It was ruining it."

The answer came quickly, in Claire's old offended rhythm. Brooke felt a painful spark of hope.

"You told me I lived there now."

Claire's gaze moved from the bag to Brooke's face. "You did."

"I didn't. The tide came in."

"You stayed until I was done."

"Because you cried when I tried to move."

"I don't remember crying."

"You cried so hard Dad offered to bury himself instead."

A breath of a laugh left Claire. It was small and unwilling and hers.

Brooke leaned closer. "You put shells all around me. Mom said we had to leave them because something might still live inside. You made me help carry every one back to the water."

Claire's fingers loosened on the strap.

"We were good that day," Brooke said. She did not know what she meant until the words were out. Good sisters, maybe. Good daughters. Good versions of themselves, preserved in a frame before either one knew to distrust memory.

Claire's eyes filled.

The change was so sudden Brooke stopped speaking. Tears gathered along Claire's lower lashes and slid down both cheeks. Claire lifted her injured hand and touched one as if checking whether it was water.

For an instant her whole posture changed. Her shoulders drew inward. Her free hand disappeared into the sleeve of Brooke's flannel, the old habit Claire had whenever she was embarrassed or trying not to cry in public. She glanced toward the librarian's desk and then toward the windows, searching for somewhere to hide.

That was Claire. Not the memory of Claire and not a behavior something else had learned. Brooke knew the small defensive fold of her body as surely as she knew her own face.

"Why am I crying?"

Brooke sat across from her. "Because you remember."

"I remember the beach."

"And before you got sick. You remember what I said to you."

Claire's face tightened. Her hand returned to the camera strap, but she did not pull.

Brooke heard the sentence again in her own voice, precise as recorded sound. *At least you never have to wonder why your real mother didn't want you.*

"I was angry," Brooke said. "I wanted to hurt you, so I said the worst thing I could think of. I'm sorry."

Claire stared at her through tears. "Mom is your real mother."

The exact answer from the hall. Brooke's throat closed.

"I know."

"Then why would you say that?"

For a second Brooke was back on the stairs with the warm flannel in her hands. "Because I wonder anyway."

Claire began to cry harder, silently now. Her shoulders barely moved. She looked frightened by the tears, not by Brooke. The hand on the strap opened.

Brooke could have taken the bag and run.

Instead she reached across the table. "Claire?"

Claire looked at Brooke's hand but did not take it. Something in her face moved beneath the calm, a struggle without language. Her lips parted. Brooke waited for her name, a warning, anything she could use as proof later.

Claire said, "I don't want you to leave."

The sentence was soft and ordinary. It was also the same thing she always said now.

Brooke drew her hand back.

Claire wiped her cheeks. Confusion remained for a few seconds after the tears stopped. Then the confusion smoothed away. She closed her fingers around the strap again, gently this time.

"You can work," she said. "I'll be quiet."

Brooke sat because the bell would ring soon, because the librarian was watching now, because Claire had let go once and Brooke did not know whether leaving would erase whatever had surfaced. They remained across from one another until lunch ended. Neither mentioned the beach again.

At dismissal, Brooke tried to leave through the west doors without Claire.

It was not a plan so much as a test. Claire's last class was on the opposite side of the building. Brooke left before the final announcements ended, cut through the art hallway, and reached the student lot with Cooper's leash looped inside her camera bag for after school. She had crossed half the lot when Claire called her name.

Brooke kept walking.

Claire ran after her. Not fast at first. When Brooke reached the sidewalk without turning, Claire's shoes struck harder behind her.

"Brooke, wait."

Brooke stopped beside the crossing guard. A police cruiser idled at the curb with its lights off. The officer stood near a minivan talking to a man and a crying boy. The boy was trying to get into the back seat while the man held both his shoulders and insisted they needed to go home together.

Claire caught Brooke's backpack and pulled.

"I was looking for you."

"I know."

"You left."

"School ended. People leave."

Claire's face tightened. Her eyes shone again. Whether the distress was the same as it had been in the library or something else, it made the crossing guard look.

The crossing guard did. "Everything okay?"

"She keeps running away from me," Claire said.

"I'm walking home."

The police officer glanced over. "You two sisters?"

"Yes," Claire said.

Brooke said, "She won't let go of my bag."

The officer approached without urgency and looked at Claire's bandaged hand.

"Lot of people on edge right now," he said. "Best thing you can do is stay together and get home."

"She broke a bathroom lock yesterday because I closed the door."

The crossing guard's expression sharpened, but the officer only nodded as if Brooke had supplied evidence for his point.

"Do you need medical help?"

"No."

Claire stood close enough that her shoulder pressed Brooke's. She looked small and tearful and harmless. "I just don't want to walk alone."

Brooke considered showing him the photograph of the broken handle. It would prove a door had broken. It would not prove why.

"Walk home with your sister," he said. "Give your mom one less thing to worry about."

Claire released the backpack when they were a block away. An adult wearing a badge had given her Brooke's company.

"You didn't have to tell him about the bathroom," Claire said.

"You didn't have to break it."

"My hand hurt."

"That isn't an apology."

Claire did not answer. They walked the rest of the way with only an arm's length between them. It was more distance than Claire wanted and less than Brooke needed, which was beginning to feel like the only kind of compromise left.

That evening, Brooke opened the old family video.

Mark's laughter shook the frame. Claire knelt in a purple swimsuit with wet hair pasted to her face, packing sand around Brooke's knees.

"Don't move," six-year-old Claire ordered.

"I can't feel my feet."

"That's because you live here now."

The camera dipped while Mark laughed. The tide came in and collapsed one side of the mound. Claire shouted at it, then began rebuilding before the water had gone out.

Brooke paused on Claire's face. No reflective flicker. No second expression. Just a little girl rebuilding before the water went out.

Brooke opened the bottom drawer of her desk and moved aside a stack of old notebooks. The journal was beneath them, its blue cloth cover faded along the spine. She had not written in it regularly since she started filming. Near the middle, tucked between entries about school and Sarah's rules, she found the beach.

Her ten-year-old handwriting leaned hard to the right: *Claire buried me and said I had to stay forever. I let her because she looked so happy. We put all the shells back after.*

The journal made the memory simpler than the video. Claire had wanted her to stay then too. That did not explain the wanting now.

Tucked into the back cover were the lines she had copied out as a child, her careful print imitating the unfamiliar hand from the letter itself. The letter she kept apart from the journal, in the keepsake box with the adoption papers, the envelope Sarah had given her years ago and then regretted giving her. Brooke's first

name, the original one, was written on the front in that same unfamiliar hand. She did not need to open it. She knew it almost by memory, every vague apology and every sentence that could be read as love or abandonment depending on the day.

The journal held things the camera did not. That was why Brooke rarely opened it now. A video showed what a person had done. Paper showed what Brooke had needed it to mean.

She returned the journal to the drawer and opened her list.

Under *THINGS I HAVE SEEN*, she wrote:

She cried and didn't know why.

Then:

She remembered the beach.

Brooke kept her fingers above the keys. She wanted to write that Claire was still inside. She wanted to write that Claire was gone. Both sentences claimed more than she knew.

She wrote:

Whatever happened to her can use what she remembers. That doesn't mean the memories are empty.

Across the hall, Claire opened her bedroom door.

Brooke closed the laptop but left the old video paused on the screen. Claire appeared in the doorway wearing Brooke's flannel, her face clean and composed.

"Can I watch?"

Brooke looked at the little girl frozen in the sand and then at the girl in the doorway.

"From the chair," she said.

For that night, Claire sat where Brooke told her and watched until Mark lowered the camera.

Somewhere Else

By seven the next morning, Brooke's inbox had become impossible.

The fourth upload had twelve thousand views. The number rose each time she refreshed it, but the views mattered less than the messages beneath them. People were no longer only telling her she was frightened or irresponsible or exploiting Claire. They were comparing notes.

Our dog won't go into my husband's room since he got home from the hospital.

My daughter stands beside the bed all night. She says she's checking that I'm there.

Brooke copied the most specific comments into a document. A medical-information label appeared beneath the video, and several reports disappeared after other users marked them as dangerous advice. The default ranking kept the most reassuring replies near the top.

Recovered people need patience, not suspicion.

This kind of content stigmatizes families during a public-health emergency.

Maybe hug your sister instead of filming her.

Brooke changed the ranking to newest. The reassuring replies vanished beneath a flood of smaller accounts with no polished language and no agreement about what any of it meant.

@jennafromreno: He slept on the floor outside my door. When I opened it, he acted like he had only just walked past.

@writethisdownplease: My aunt keeps eating beets. She has hated beets my whole life. This sounds stupid but please ask people about food.

@northcountyparent: Do not tell them you are leaving until you are already gone.

@mari 88: My son cried when I asked why he was holding me so hard. He said he did not know why he was crying.

The last comment had been posted six minutes earlier. By the time Brooke copied it, the account was unavailable.

She did not know whether the platform had removed it, the writer had panicked, or someone else in the house had found the phone. She added a column for deletion time.

Between the reports came a photograph of a man in a lawn chair, two dates beneath it forty-one years apart, and the line *he didn't get the red medicine in time*. One person answered *I'm so sorry*. Another wrote *at least the ones who make it come home so grateful now, hold them close*. Mourning and gratitude occupied the same thread. Grief had taught the whole feed to distrust distance before the changed said a word.

An interview request arrived from a national morning show. Its producer called Brooke “a brave young documentarian” and asked whether Claire would appear beside her. A second message offered payment for exclusive hospital footage. Brooke marked both unread after opening them, as if that could restore the moment before strangers knew she existed.

Claire slept in Brooke’s desk chair with her knees pulled under Brooke’s flannel. She had come in before dawn and asked permission from the doorway. Brooke had said yes because being asked felt so much like improvement that she had mistaken it for safety.

Cooper lay beneath the desk. His eyes remained open.

Downstairs, a cabinet closed. Then another. Sarah had been moving around the kitchen since five, cleaning with the furious quiet she used when she did not want anyone to ask if she was upset.

Brooke saved screenshots of the most specific reports. She made columns for dogs, sleep, doors, and what happened when

someone tried to leave. The comments did not produce rules. They produced repetition, which was more useful and more frightening.

A direct message from a nursing assistant said discharge staff had begun calling family proximity “recovery support.” Brooke saved it with the others.

She looked toward Claire. Her sister’s head rested against the chair back at an angle that would hurt when she woke. The bandage on her hand was clean. In sleep, her face looked younger and less arranged.

Brooke raised her phone, then lowered it. She had enough footage of Claire sleeping. That sentence alone made her feel ashamed.

Sarah was bent over the sink when Brooke entered the kitchen.

“You okay?”

Sarah straightened too quickly. “Fine.”

The window above the sink was open despite the cold. A lemon-scented cleaner bottle stood beside the faucet. Beneath it, almost covered by paper towels, was a smear of something pale on the drain.

“Were you sick?”

“Coffee on an empty stomach.”

“You don’t drink coffee on an empty stomach.”

“Apparently I don’t anymore.”

Sarah turned on the tap and rinsed the sink again. Her hands trembled beneath the water.

Brooke watched the tremor. “Mom.”

“Don’t start.”

“I’m not starting anything. Your hands are shaking.”

“I haven’t slept. Your sister broke a door, your father is still three states away, and I spent half the night reading messages from parents who think your videos are making their children afraid to come home.”

“Parents are messaging you?”

“The school is.”

Sarah dried her hands. Sweat shone along her hairline, though the kitchen was cold enough for Brooke to feel the open window through her sweatshirt.

“You have a fever.”

“I have work.”

"Sit down."

Sarah almost smiled. "You don't get to order me around because you've watched three first-aid videos."

"Four."

"That changes everything."

The joke sounded right. Brooke wanted to accept it. Then Sarah flinched when Claire switched on the hall light behind them.

"Turn that off," Sarah said.

Claire did. She studied Sarah from the doorway with a stillness Brooke recognized.

"Mom's getting sick," Claire said.

"Mom drank bad coffee," Sarah answered.

Claire looked at Brooke. "We should stay home."

Sarah refused until she tried to eat toast and had to leave the table.

The bathroom door closed. A moment later the toilet lid struck the tank. Brooke stood, but Claire reached across the table and closed a hand around her forearm.

"She wants to be alone," Claire said.

"She doesn't."

"You do."

Brooke pulled free. Claire let her, though her face pinched with immediate distress.

Sarah had locked the downstairs bathroom. The lock held when Brooke tested it.

"Mom?"

"Go get ready for school."

"Open the door."

"Brooke."

The toilet flushed. Water ran. When Sarah emerged, she had washed her face and put on lipstick, a color Brooke had not seen her wear since Christmas. It made her skin look gray.

"I'm driving you," Sarah said.

"No."

"You're not taking the bus with everything going around."

"You're shaking."

"Then you can drive."

Brooke had her permit, not her license. Sarah knew that. The suggestion exposed how hard she was working to preserve the morning.

They stayed home.

Brooke called Mark before Sarah could object. The call did not ring. She sent a photograph of the thermometer instead, then a second message with no photograph because the first seemed too much like proof meant for a stranger.

Mom has the same symptoms. Call me as soon as you see this.

The delivery icon remained hollow.

Sarah watched from the dining room. "He'll call."

"You don't know he got it."

"His signal has been bad."

"For four days?"

Sarah closed her eyes against the light from the window. "I cannot be sick and defend your father at the same time."

Brooke lowered the blinds. "I'm not asking you to defend him."

"You always ask questions as if somebody has to be guilty."

The words were slurred slightly at the edges. Brooke could not tell whether they belonged to fever, the argument upstairs, or something Sarah had believed for years.

Sarah called the school and said Claire's hand needed monitoring. She did not mention herself. Then she took her laptop to the dining room and joined a work meeting with the camera off.

Brooke listened from the stairs as Sarah explained a scheduling delay in a voice so normal that nobody on the call could have known she had a mixing bowl on the floor beside her chair.

At ten, Brooke recorded the fifth upload.

She set the camera in her room with the door open. Cooper lay at her feet. Claire sat in the hall where Brooke could see her, close enough to remain calm but outside the frame. Downstairs, Sarah's voice rose and fell through another work call.

Brooke did not use an intro.

"This isn't just here," she said. "I thought it might be. I thought maybe I was taking things my sister did and connecting them because I was scared. But people keep sending me the same details from places I've never been."

She explained the dogs first, then the watching and the way recovered people reacted to closed doors or plans to leave. She did not call them rules or claim touch spread anything.

"If someone in your house got sick and now they won't let you be alone, write down what happens. Save it somewhere they can't delete. Record dates. Record what they used to do, too. Old video matters because memory changes when you're afraid."

She paused. In the hall, Claire watched without blinking.

"And wanting someone close doesn't make them safe. I know how that sounds."

Brooke had planned to stop there. The recording light remained steady.

"I'm adopted," she said. "I have a mom. I love her. I still wonder why the person who had me never came back."

Downstairs, a chair scraped.

Brooke continued before she could reconsider.

"Sometimes you want to be found so badly you tell strangers exactly where to look." Brooke glanced away from the lens. "Which is probably what I'm doing."

Claire's expression changed at *the person who had me*, a small tightening around her mouth.

"Keep old messages and old videos. If something feels wrong, write down why before somebody talks you out of it."

Brooke ended the recording.

For several seconds, nobody moved.

"Mom is your mom," Claire said from the hall.

"I know."

"You said it like she isn't."

"That isn't what I said."

"She heard the other part."

The observation sounded too precise. Brooke looked toward the stairs.

Sarah stood at the bottom with one hand on the newel post. She had heard enough. Her face was damp and exhausted, her lipstick partly gone.

"Publish it," she said.

Brooke stared at her.

"That's what you do, isn't it? You decide what the family means and put it online."

“Mom, I said I love you.”

“Yes. You always put that part in.”

Sarah turned before Brooke could answer and made it to the bathroom. This time she did not lock the door. Brooke heard her fall against the wall, then the violent emptying sound that had filled Saint Vincent’s emergency department.

The argument vanished.

Brooke found Sarah on her knees with both hands braced on the toilet. Her whole body shook. Claire came to the doorway but would not cross the distance from Brooke to their mother. Cooper stopped several feet back, nails spread against the tile.

“Get towels,” Brooke told Claire.

“You come with me.”

“Claire, towels. Now.”

Claire obeyed, but only after touching Brooke’s shoulder.

Brooke held Sarah’s hair. Sarah vomited until there was nothing left, then continued, her muscles contracting around emptiness. Between waves, she tried to say she was all right.

Her phone rang in the kitchen. The sound continued until voicemail took it, then began again.

On Brooke’s laptop upstairs, the fifth upload finished processing.

By noon, it had more than twenty thousand views.

Comments arrived faster than Brooke could read them.

This happened to my mother.

This happened somewhere else.

Brooke knelt on the bathroom floor with Sarah’s weight against her and understood that being right had not prepared her for anything.

Sarah’s work called four times. Brooke answered the fifth.

“She’s unavailable,” Brooke said.

The woman introduced herself as Sarah’s supervisor, then asked whether Sarah had been exposed to a gastrointestinal illness. Her voice carried the careful calm of somebody reading questions from a screen.

“My sister had it.”

“Has your sister recovered?”

Brooke looked at Claire. She sat in the hall with her back against the wall, close enough to touch Brooke's shoe. "That's not a simple question."

"If Sarah is experiencing active symptoms, she should remain home. Household recovery support is recommended."

"What does that mean?"

"Someone familiar should stay with her."

"I'm seventeen."

"Then is there another adult you can call?"

Brooke almost said Mark. "Not one who can get here."

The supervisor promised to email resources. Its first paragraph concerned paid sick leave. The second linked to state health-department guidance titled *Supporting Recovered Family Members at Home*. The same wording had already reached the hospital, the school, and now Sarah's job through ordinary channels.

Sarah began vomiting again.

The afternoon moved in short failures. Sarah could not keep down water. The thermometer read 101.8, then 102.4. Brooke replaced the bathroom bin with the large kitchen bowl and covered the floor in towels. Claire brought supplies only if Brooke stayed within sight. Cooper would not cross the bathroom threshold.

Brooke made a schedule on the back of the discharge instructions.

12:20 p.m. Water, vomited within five minutes
12:47 p.m. Temperature 102.4
1:05 p.m. Two teaspoons electrolyte drink
1:14 p.m. Vomiting
1:40 p.m. Responsive, confused about date
2:02 p.m. Urinated, dark

She hated the clinical words because they made the day seem manageable. They did not include Sarah apologizing each time she missed the bowl, or Brooke rinsing vomit from her mother's hair, or Claire sitting in the hall asking every few minutes whether Brooke was staying.

At two fifteen, Sarah's supervisor emailed again. The subject line was *WE ARE HERE FOR YOU*. The message offered sick leave, an employee assistance number, and a reminder that

recovered employees could return after twenty-four symptom-free hours with manager approval.

The same message encouraged household members to “maintain reassuring physical presence whenever safely possible.”

Brooke highlighted the phrase. It had not appeared in the morning email.

At three, Brooke tried the hospital’s nurse line. The estimated wait was more than ninety minutes.

At four, Sarah insisted on standing.

“You need bed,” Brooke said.

“I need to clean this.”

“No, you don’t.”

“Claire shouldn’t see it.”

Claire was directly behind Brooke. “I already saw.”

Sarah gripped the sink. Her reflection in the mirror looked shocked by its own face. “Your father is going to walk into a disaster.”

“Dad isn’t walking into anything today.”

“He said morning.”

“That was last night.”

Sarah looked at Brooke as though the distinction required more concentration than she had. “Call him.”

“I have.”

“Again.”

Brooke called. Voicemail answered without ringing.

While Sarah slept in brief, shivering stretches, Brooke checked the upload once. Hundreds of messages waited. One asked for an interview. Another called her a liar and included the name of her school.

She closed the page. Belief felt less like rescue than a weight being transferred.

At six, Claire appeared in the bathroom doorway holding a glass of water.

“She’ll be better,” she said.

“You don’t know that.”

“I got better.”

Brooke looked at Sarah asleep on the tile, her cheek against a folded towel. “Is that what you call it?”

Claire set the water down. Her gaze moved from Sarah to Brooke and stayed there.

“When she wakes up,” Claire said, “we can all stay in her room.”

The fever reached 103 shortly after dark.

Brooke stopped checking the view count.

Carrying Them

Sarah's fever reached 103.4 before midnight.

Brooke called the hospital twice. The first time she waited forty-three minutes and lost the connection. The second time a nurse asked whether Sarah could breathe, whether she had passed out, whether there was blood in the vomit, and whether another adult was present.

"My sister is here."

"How old is she?"

"Thirteen."

"An adult."

"My dad's out of town."

The nurse went quiet long enough for Brooke to hear voices behind her and an announcement calling for environmental services.

"Emergency departments are operating beyond capacity," she said. "But that fever with vomiting needs close monitoring. If she becomes confused, faints, cannot be awakened, stops urinating, or cannot keep even small sips down, call nine-one-one. Do not drive her yourself if she cannot stay awake."

Brooke wrote the warnings beside Sarah's temperature.

The nurse continued in the flatter voice of text being read from a screen. "While she remains responsive and is keeping small amounts down, keep monitoring her at home. Keep family or familiar support persons nearby. Avoid unnecessary separation during recovery."

Brooke looked at Claire, who sat on the bathroom floor with her back against the wall and both hands wrapped around Brooke's ankle.

"What does separation have to do with vomiting?"

"It's part of the updated guidance."

"From who?"

"The department."

"Which department?"

The line clicked. A recorded voice repeated the emergency warning signs, then offered a clinical callback with an estimated wait of more than two hours.

An alert arrived on Sarah's patient portal a few minutes later.

RECOVERY SUPPORT NOTICE Patients benefit from calm, familiar surroundings. When possible, avoid unnecessary isolation from household members during illness and recovery.

Brooke took a screenshot.

Sarah vomited again.

The next twelve hours reduced the house to water, temperatures, and the distance between rooms. When vomiting paused, diarrhea began. When that stopped, tremors tapped the headboard against the wall. Brooke kept the supplies on the bathroom counter, recorded the changes, and cleaned what Sarah could not reach in time.

"Don't look at me," Sarah said once.

Brooke was kneeling beside the bed with clean pajama pants. "I have to."

"No, you don't."

"You did this for both of us."

"You were babies."

"Claire threw up in your purse when she was nine."

From the doorway Claire said, "That was carsickness."

Sarah laughed once. The laugh became a dry heave. Brooke held the bowl until it passed.

Afterward Sarah whispered, "You shouldn't have to."

The sentence hurt more than the work. Brooke fastened the clean clothes and pulled the blanket over her. "There's nobody else."

Claire moved closer at that, offended by being excluded even from a burden she would not carry alone.

Claire followed Brooke through every task, carrying empty cups and walking so close that her socks brushed Brooke's heels. If Brooke closed the bathroom door to help Sarah change, Claire turned the handle until Brooke opened it again.

"I need space to move," Brooke said.

"I can help."

"Then get the blue blanket from Mom's room."

"Come with me."

"I can't leave her."

"Then I won't either."

Claire sat beside the tub and watched Sarah shake beneath two towels. She did not hold Sarah's hand. She watched Brooke hold it.

At three in the morning, Sarah opened her eyes and whispered Mark's name.

"He's still at the job," Brooke said.

"Call him."

"I did."

She had called six times. Each went directly to voicemail. The messages she left grew shorter because she could hear herself becoming a child in them.

Dad, Mom's sick. Call me.

It's the same thing Claire had.

I don't know if I should drive her.

Please call.

His reply arrived at 3:17.

Signal came back for a minute. Still at the hotel. Road crew says morning. Keep everyone together until I get there. Love you.

The message could have been delayed. The road crew could have said morning. He could still be at the hotel. Every sentence gave Brooke something and answered nothing.

She typed, *Call now.*

The message did not deliver.

Brooke called the hotel. The desk clerk confirmed that the electrical crew had checked in before the county advisory, but would not connect her to a room or confirm who remained there. The emergency number on Mark's company website led to a

mailbox too full to accept another message. She saved both call times, then stopped because proof that the numbers existed was not proof her father could answer them.

At four twelve, a voicemail appeared without a missed call. Mark's voice sounded distant and compressed.

Brookie, I got your messages. Listen, keep your mom drinking. Tiny amounts, don't let her gulp it. If she passes out and you can't wake her, call an ambulance. The site manager says we may get the trucks out after daylight. I know I keep saying that. I'm sorry. Tell Sarah I'm trying. Tell Claire I love her. I love you. I'll call when I can.

Behind him, somebody said something too low to understand. Mark paused as if listening. Then the recording ended.

Brooke played the voicemail for Sarah when she woke. Sarah smiled at *Brookie*. Claire asked to hear the part where he said he loved her again.

Brooke replayed it twice. The third time, she listened only to the silence before the message ended.

She followed his instructions anyway. A bottle cap of electrolyte solution, then another after Sarah kept the first down. Mark's voice did not bring him home, but it gave Brooke the next thing to do.

Sarah curled toward the toilet. Brooke put the phone down and caught the bowl before Sarah knocked it over.

"You're good at this," Sarah whispered when the spasm passed.

"I'm not."

"You are."

Her voice had no strength for an argument. Brooke wiped her face with the corner of a towel.

"I posted another video," Brooke said.

Sarah's eyes remained closed. "I know."

"You heard it."

"Enough."

"I wasn't saying you're not my mother."

Sarah swallowed. Even that hurt. "Not now."

"I need you to know."

"Brooke."

"I don't want another mother." The sentence came out smaller than she intended. "I want you to stop deciding what I can survive.

I want you to stop being scared every time I leave. But I don't want somebody else."

Sarah's face tightened. Brooke could not tell whether she was crying or whether fever had made her eyes water.

"I need you," Brooke said.

Sarah moved her hand beneath the towel. Her fingers found Brooke's wrist and rested there without closing.

"I know," she whispered.

Brooke lowered her forehead to the edge of the mattress.

By morning, the symptoms shifted. The vomiting slowed. Sarah asked twice why Claire was not at school, then remembered she had kept both girls home before Brooke could correct her. Sunlight through the blinds made her turn her face toward the wall.

Claire sat on the bedroom floor with a book open in her lap. She had not turned a page.

Brooke checked Sarah's pulse and wrote the number down. When she looked up, Claire was watching her, not Sarah.

"Why don't you sit with Mom?"

"I am."

"You know what I mean."

Claire moved closer to Brooke until their shoulders touched.

Around eleven, Sarah tried to walk to the bathroom by herself.

Brooke heard the bedframe move and came in from the hall in time to catch her against the dresser. Sarah's knees folded. Brooke took her weight beneath the arms and lowered her to the floor rather than trying to hold her upright.

"I can walk," Sarah said.

"You just proved you can't."

"Don't be smart."

"Then stop doing dangerous things."

It was Sarah's sentence, returned in Brooke's voice. Even sick, Sarah recognized it. A weak smile moved across her face and vanished when another tremor went through her.

Claire stood in the doorway.

"Help me get her up," Brooke said.

Claire came forward reluctantly. She placed one hand beneath Sarah's elbow but kept the other on Brooke's back. Together they moved Sarah the few steps to the bathroom. Sarah was not heavy, but her body had stopped helping. Brooke felt every pound of her

and thought of all the times Sarah had carried sleeping children from the car without waking them.

"I used to carry both of you," Sarah murmured.

"Not at the same time."

"You don't remember."

"I was four when Claire was born."

"Then maybe I remember wrong."

The admission frightened Brooke more than confusion would have. Sarah had always defended her memory.

They settled her beside the toilet. Claire crouched against Brooke instead of their mother. Sarah looked at the way Claire clung to Brooke's sleeve.

"Give your sister room," she said.

Claire did not move.

"Claire."

The second time, something in Sarah's voice reached her. Claire released the fabric and sat back. Brooke watched both of them. Sarah's eyes were unfocused with fever, but the instruction had been automatic and maternal. For a moment the house contained its old arrangement: Sarah setting a limit, Claire resenting it, Brooke relieved not to be the only person who saw the need.

Then Sarah leaned over the toilet and the moment ended.

The purge changed Sarah's appetite before it restored it. Near noon she asked for canned beets.

Brooke thought she had misheard. "We don't have beets."

"Back of the pantry."

Sarah bought them once a year for Mark and complained that opening the can made the kitchen smell like wet dirt. Brooke found two cans behind the soup.

"You can't eat that."

"I want them."

"You haven't kept down water."

Sarah closed her eyes. "Then later."

Claire stood beside Brooke in the pantry doorway. "I like them now too."

They looked at each other. Claire smiled as if this were a shared family preference they had only just discovered.

Brooke moved the cans to the highest shelf.

Brooke changed the sweat-soaked sheets while Claire remained in the bathroom. By noon, Sarah's fever began falling. The relief was so physical that Brooke had to sit on the bathroom floor before her legs did it for her.

She had been awake for more than twenty-seven hours.

"Sleep," Claire said.

"I need to check her again at one."

"I'll wake you."

Brooke looked at her.

"I can tell time," Claire said, with enough irritation to sound thirteen.

Brooke set three alarms anyway. She lay on top of Sarah's bed with her shoes on, leaving space between herself and her mother. Claire sat on the floor near the door. Cooper remained in the hall, unwilling to enter.

Brooke dreamed of Saint Vincent's. In the dream, every patient held the same red cup and every person turned toward her at once.

When she woke, the room was dark.

Her phone lay beneath her hand. The alarms had been dismissed.

Claire sat on the edge of the mattress.

She was not looking at Sarah. She was looking at Brooke.

"What time is it?"

"Two sixteen."

Brooke pushed herself upright. "Why didn't you wake me?"

"You needed to sleep."

"I had to check Mom."

"I checked her."

Sarah lay still on her side. Brooke reached across the blanket and pressed two fingers to her neck. Her skin was cooler. Her pulse was steady.

"What did you check?"

"If she was breathing."

"How?"

"I watched."

Brooke's mouth was dry. "From where?"

Claire glanced at the indentation beside Brooke. "Here."

"You sat here the whole time?"

"You kept moving in your sleep."

Sarah stirred. Claire turned toward her at last. Sarah opened her eyes without confusion and looked first at Brooke, then Claire, then the dark window.

"What time is it?" she asked.

"After two."

"In the afternoon?"

"Yes."

Sarah pushed herself up. Brooke reached to help, but Sarah was already sitting. Her hair stuck to her face and her lips were cracked, yet the feverish slackness was gone. She looked exhausted and entirely present.

"You need water," Brooke said.

"I need a shower."

"You almost passed out this morning."

"Then I smell worse than I thought."

It was exactly the kind of thing Sarah would say. Brooke laughed, and the laugh broke halfway through.

Sarah saw it. Her face softened. "Come here."

Brooke did.

She leaned into Sarah carefully, mindful of the sick heat still trapped in the sheets. Sarah wrapped both arms around her. For one moment Brooke let herself be held without measuring the pressure.

"You took care of me," Sarah said into her hair.

"There wasn't anybody else."

"There was you."

Behind Brooke, Claire shifted closer on the bed. Sarah opened one arm to include her, and Claire pressed herself into the space immediately.

Brooke was between them.

Sarah kissed the top of her head. "We're all right."

Cooper stood in the doorway, watching.

Sarah saw him and patted the mattress.

Cooper did not enter.

Sarah's hand remained raised for a moment. Hurt crossed her face before she lowered it.

"He'll come around," Claire said.

Sarah looked at Claire. Something quiet passed between them, not a signal Brooke could name, only the ease of two people arriving at the same conclusion.

“Of course he will,” Sarah said.

Brooke was still inside her arms. Sarah rubbed slow circles between her shoulder blades, the motion she had used when Brooke was little and homesick after sleepovers. It soothed Brooke before she could decide whether she wanted to stay.

Having You Home

The next morning, Sarah made pancakes.

Brooke woke to the smell of butter and the sound of the kitchen cabinet that never closed correctly. For several seconds she lay still, listening to Sarah move through the downstairs rooms, and the house sounded restored. A plate touched the counter. The kettle clicked off. Claire laughed at something too quiet for Brooke to hear.

She found Sarah at the stove in clean pajamas with her damp hair combed behind her ears. The mixing bowl from the night before had been washed and returned to the cupboard. The towels were already in the machine. Even the broken bathroom handle had disappeared from the counter.

"Sit," Sarah said. "You look terrible."

"You had a fever yesterday."

"And you haven't slept since Tuesday."

"It's Thursday."

"Exactly."

Sarah slid a pancake onto Brooke's plate. It was too dark around the edge, the way Sarah always made the first one.

Brooke looked at Cooper. He sat beside the back door rather than beneath Sarah's chair. When Sarah tore off a corner of pancake and offered it, he lowered his head.

"He was up all night," Sarah said.

"He wouldn't come into your room."

"Because people were vomiting in it."

"You were in your room."

Sarah placed the pancake piece on the floor. “Do you want breakfast or an interrogation?”

The words were light. Brooke sat.

Sarah asked about school, the assignments they had missed, and whether Claire’s hand needed another bandage. She sent two work emails while standing at the counter and called the hardware store about a replacement latch. She remembered that Brooke’s permit paperwork needed a signature. She reminded Claire about an overdue library book.

Claire loaded the dishwasher without being asked. She complained about the pan taking up too much space, put two cups in the wrong row, and flicked water at Brooke when Brooke corrected her. Sarah told them both to stop. For thirty seconds, the kitchen held an ordinary morning argument.

Then Claire cut the remaining pancakes into equal pieces and divided them among three plates.

“I’m done,” Brooke said.

“You barely ate.”

“I’m not hungry.”

Claire moved one piece back onto Brooke’s plate. “You should finish.”

Sarah looked over from the sink. “Leave her alone.”

Claire obeyed immediately. She did not pout or steal the piece for herself. She sat beside Sarah and ate it from Sarah’s plate instead. Sarah let her.

Brooke watched their shoulders touch. The two of them seemed less like allies than parts of the same household rhythm, each anticipating where the other wanted closeness and supplying it without discussion.

Nothing in her behavior was impossible.

That became the problem.

For the next hour, Sarah repaired the evidence of her illness. She stripped the towels from the bathroom floor, disinfected the sink, opened windows, and made a grocery list. When Brooke offered to help, Sarah told her to sit down. When Brooke remained standing, Sarah put a hand on her shoulder and guided her toward the table.

The pressure was gentle. Brooke went where it directed her.

“You don’t have to do everything,” Brooke said.

"Neither do you."

"You passed out yesterday."

"I nearly passed out."

"You were on the floor."

"People can lie down on floors voluntarily."

Brooke stared at her.

Sarah smiled. "That was a joke."

The delivery was right. The timing was wrong by only enough to make Brooke wonder whether she was inventing the distance.

At nine, Sarah emailed the school to say both girls would remain home another day.

"I can go," Brooke said.

"You can barely keep your eyes open."

"I slept."

"You lost a day taking care of me. Stay home."

"You didn't ask."

Sarah looked up from her laptop. "I didn't think I needed permission to let my exhausted daughter recover."

The phrasing struck the same place as the workshop argument. Safety presented after the decision. Concern that left no room for refusal.

"You could've talked to me first."

Sarah's face changed, not into anger exactly. Hurt arrived first. "You filmed yourself telling thousands of strangers that you want another mother while I was sick downstairs."

"That is not what I said."

"I heard you."

"Then you heard the part where I said I love you."

"You always make sure that part is in there."

It was nearly the same sentence Sarah had used before the purge.

There was no clean way to interpret the fact that Sarah remembered exactly where to hurt.

Sarah closed the laptop. "I am glad you're home."

"I'm always home."

"No, you're always halfway out the door. School, that workshop, filming, whatever comes after graduation. Even when you're in this house, you're watching it like you're already somewhere else."

Brooke's hand moved toward her pocket. Her phone was there, recording nothing.

"I'm allowed to leave," she said.

"Of course you are." Sarah's answer came too fast. Then, more softly, "I just don't understand why you fight so hard to."

Claire had stopped eating. She watched them from the table.

Brooke stood. "I'm going upstairs."

"Take your plate."

The ordinary instruction almost made her laugh. She carried the pancake to her room and closed the door. The handle clicked. A minute later, Claire tried it once, found it unlocked, and came in.

"Mom's sad," she said.

"Mom is always sad when I disagree with her."

"You make it sound like she does it on purpose."

"Does what?"

"Loves you."

Brooke looked at Claire. Her sister sat in the desk chair but did not roll it closer. The boundary from the night before remained, or the memory of getting what she wanted by respecting it did.

"Did she say anything to you while I was asleep?" Brooke asked.

"She was asleep too."

"This morning."

Claire shook her head.

At eleven, the local station ran a segment from Saint Vincent's.

The camera stayed close on a hospital administrator in a pale blue suit.

"Our recovery numbers are encouraging," the administrator said. "The most important thing families can provide is a calm, supportive home environment. Recovered individuals may experience distress when isolated unnecessarily."

A banner beneath her read:

FAMILIES HEAL TOGETHER

The anchor identified the message as new state health-department guidance. "A good reminder that compassion is part of recovery."

Sarah stood in the living room with a basket of folded laundry against her hip. "See?"

Brooke looked away from the television. "See what?"

"You don't have to treat your sister like she's dangerous."

"She broke a lock."

“She panicked.”

Claire appeared behind Sarah and took the basket from her.

“I’m tired of being examined,” Sarah said. “I was sick. I got better. Your sister was sick. She got better. You could let that be good news.”

The broadcast moved to a commercial. A family gathered around a dining table while a soft voice described the importance of staying connected.

The station returned with a family therapist and the hospital administrator. Their panel concerned stigma, fear, and rebuilding trust. The therapist advised gentle boundaries but warned that withdrawal could intensify separation distress.

No one asked whether the recovered person had broken the door.

At the bottom of the screen, a ticker announced reduced hours at two urgent-care clinics because of staffing shortages. The anchor did not mention it.

Brooke went upstairs.

She waited until Sarah started the vacuum before opening the recording app. She did not set up the camera or turn on her lights. She sat on the floor beside her bed with the phone close to her mouth.

“Day sixteen,” she whispered. “Mom’s fever is gone. She’s eating, working, cleaning, and remembering everything. Cooper won’t go near her. She canceled school without asking me. The hospital and the news are both using the same language about separation.”

The vacuum stopped downstairs.

Brooke paused.

Footsteps came up the stairs. She saved the file, renamed it with the date, and moved it into a folder labeled *chemistry*. Then she slid the phone beneath a stack of folded shirts as Sarah opened the door.

“What are you doing?”

“Looking for my charger.”

The lie came easily. Brooke had never hidden footage from Sarah before. She had hidden embarrassing edits and bad grades and searches about her biological mother, but not evidence. Sarah

was the person she showed things to when she needed another adult to confirm that she had seen them correctly.

Sarah leaned against the frame. "Your charger is plugged in beside the desk."

"Found it."

"You weren't near the desk."

Brooke held her gaze.

Sarah's expression softened. "You don't have to be afraid of me."

"I didn't say I was."

"You don't have to say everything."

For a moment Brooke thought Sarah might cross the room and search the bed. Instead she stayed at the doorway.

"Your dad said seven if they get clear," Sarah said. "Maybe we can all eat together while he's on."

"Did he answer you?"

"He texted."

"Can I see?"

Sarah's fingers tightened around her phone. Then she handed it over.

Mark's message had arrived at 6:08 that morning.

Should have service tonight. Seven if the crew gets us clear.

Miss you.

It sounded more like him than the last one. Brooke held on to that. The conditional promise was irritatingly normal. Seven if. Tomorrow if. Home when.

"He might call," Sarah said.

At seven, they set Mark's place at the table and propped Sarah's phone against the salt shaker.

At seven fifteen, the screen remained dark.

At seven thirty, Sarah served the food anyway. Cooper stayed beneath Brooke's chair.

At eight, Sarah texted Mark once.

At nine, Brooke called and reached voicemail.

At nine twenty-three, another voicemail appeared.

This one contained only seven seconds of sound. Fabric brushed the microphone. Mark breathed once, close to the phone.

Farther away, several people spoke in the same calm murmur Brooke had heard during the live call.

Then Mark said, "Home."

The recording ended.

Sarah played it twice. "He pocket-dialed."

"He said home."

"Because he wants to come home."

"Or somebody asked where he was going."

"Or he was talking to a coworker. Or a television was on. Or the transcription cut off the rest."

There was no transcription.

Sarah deleted the voicemail from her screen before Brooke could stop her.

"Why did you do that?"

"Because listening to seven seconds of noise until it becomes a threat is not helping you."

Brooke recovered it from the deleted folder while Sarah carried dishes to the sink. She forwarded the audio to herself and saved it beside the earlier call.

It was the last time Mark's voice reached the house.

Sarah did not appear worried. "He warned us about the signal."

"He also said seven."

"He said if."

Brooke looked at the empty place setting. "You always tell me not to make excuses for people."

"Your father is working."

"Do you know that?"

Sarah's fork stopped. "What is that supposed to mean?"

"Nothing."

"No, say it."

Brooke stood and carried her plate to the sink. "I'm tired."

Upstairs, she added the missed call to the private recording. She included Mark's exact message and the time. Then she copied both files to the memory card in her camera.

She slept with the camera bag beneath the bed and Cooper against the door.

Sometime after midnight, the mattress shifted.

Brooke kept her breathing even.

Sarah stood beside the bed. Moonlight from the window gave her face no expression Brooke could read. She did not touch Brooke. She watched her chest rise and fall, then bent close enough that Brooke could feel breath move against her hair.

“There you are,” Sarah whispered.

Cooper lifted his head.

Sarah looked at him. For several seconds, neither moved. Then she straightened, crossed the room, and closed the door almost silently behind her.

Brooke waited until the hall floor stopped creaking before opening her eyes.

The first thing she did was reach beneath the bed and make sure the camera was still there.

Recovered Individuals

Sarah was already dressed when Brooke came downstairs.

Not pajamas. Work clothes. A navy blouse, black pants, earrings small enough for video calls. She stood at the kitchen island answering email while Claire packed lunches neither of them had been told they were taking anywhere.

“You’re going to school,” Sarah said.

Brooke stopped on the last stair. “Yesterday you wouldn’t let me.”

“Yesterday you were exhausted.”

“And today?”

“Today you need routine.”

The decision had been made before Brooke entered the room. Sarah’s laptop was open to an email from Ashcroft High with the subject line *RECOVERY, ATTENDANCE, AND FAMILY SUPPORT*. Brooke could read only the first sentence from where she stood.

As our community moves forward together...

“You emailed them again,” Brooke said.

“They emailed everyone.”

“I mean about us.”

Sarah closed the laptop. “I told them you’ve received attention online and may need support.”

“What kind of support?”

“The kind where adults know strangers have identified your school.”

Brooke looked at Claire. "Did you tell her?"

"It was in the comments," Claire said.

"You were reading my comments?"

"They were about us."

Sarah put both hands on the island. "A reporter called the house at six thirty. Someone sent the school a link. Two parents complained that your videos are frightening their children. This is no longer only your account."

"It was never only my account. That's the point."

"No. The point is that you showed our home, your sister, the hospital, and me. Now people know where you go to school."

Every fact was true. Sarah did not have to raise her voice to make truth feel like a locked door.

"Give me my phone," Brooke said.

"It's charging."

"Where?"

"In my room."

Brooke stared at her.

Sarah's expression remained patient. "It kept going off all night. You need one morning without strangers demanding answers."

"You took it while I was asleep."

"I put it somewhere quiet."

"That is taking it."

Claire slid a lunch bag across the counter. "You can have mine."

"I don't want yours."

"Brooke," Sarah said.

"No. Don't do the voice like I'm making this hard. Give me my phone."

Sarah held her gaze for a moment, then went upstairs. She returned with the phone and placed it on the island rather than in Brooke's hand.

The screen showed thirty-seven missed notifications, three interview requests, a message from the assistant principal, and a warning from the video platform. The warning did not remove the upload. It said the account's medical claims were under review and future posts could have their reach limited.

Another notice sat beneath it.

Recommendation update

Content concerning current health events may be shown alongside authoritative recovery resources. Repeated unsupported claims can affect search placement and recommendations.

Brooke searched the exact title of her fifth upload. The first results were news explainers, the state health department, and a hospital page about separation distress. Her own video appeared below two reaction clips accusing her of exploiting Claire.

When she searched her full name, the video came first.

The platform had not hidden her. It had separated her warning from the people who might need it and made her identity easier to find than the information.

At the top of the screen was an incoming call from an unknown Connecticut number.

Sarah looked at it. "That's probably another reporter."

Brooke declined the call.

"Thank you."

"I didn't do it for you."

"I know."

Sarah said it without anger. That made Brooke want to argue more.

On the television behind them, a morning anchor interviewed a state health official. The caption called people like Claire and Sarah *recovered individuals*. The official explained that post-illness distress could be worsened by abrupt isolation and recommended calm routines, familiar support, and avoiding "unnecessary family separation."

Brooke opened the school email on her phone. The counselor's message used the same phrase.

The platform warning used *supportive recovery information*.

Sarah's employer had sent *Supporting Recovered Family Members at Home*. Different offices, different logos, the same handful of words.

Sarah was expected back at the office Monday morning for a short check-in before she resumed her normal schedule. She had sounded pleased by the idea. The house would be empty for the first time since Claire became sick, except for Cooper.

"Where did the school get this?" Brooke asked.

Sarah glanced at the television. “The health department, probably.”

It was an ordinary answer. That was what frightened her.

Brooke went upstairs with her phone. Claire followed as far as the landing.

“I need to record,” Brooke said.

“I can be quiet.”

“I need the door closed.”

Claire’s eyes moved to the new bathroom handle visible down the hall. Sarah had replaced it with one that did not lock.

“For how long?”

“Ten minutes.”

“Five.”

“Ten.”

Claire looked downstairs. Sarah was on a work call, her voice carrying from the kitchen.

“Seven,” Claire said.

Brooke almost refused because negotiating privacy made it no longer privacy. Instead she said, “Fine.”

Claire sat against the wall outside the bedroom. Brooke closed the door.

She recorded Upload Six in one take.

“They say we’re fine,” she began. “Not just my family. The hospital, the school, the news. They keep using the same words. Maybe it’s all the same health-department guidance. Maybe that part is normal. But it doesn’t match what’s happening in houses.”

She showed the platform warning, the school email, and the hospital notice without displaying names or addresses. She described Sarah’s recovery but did not include the nighttime recording. That remained in the chemistry folder and on the camera card.

Brooke built the edit as a comparison rather than an accusation. Three documents filled the screen one after another. She highlighted the repeated phrases in yellow:

Hospital: Avoid unnecessary isolation.

School: Reduce unnecessary separation.

Platform: Promote supportive recovery information.

She recorded the dates each phrase appeared and said she could not prove where the wording originated. She left in that uncertainty because the similarity was frightening without being impossible. Public institutions copied language from one another every day.

“My mom is working. My sister goes to school. They eat and sleep and remember everything. That doesn’t mean nothing happened to them.”

Brooke stopped. Outside the door, Claire shifted against the wall.

“People keep asking what to do, and I don’t know. I know dogs notice. Closed doors upset them. They remember things, but sometimes they make those things mean something else.” She stopped, rubbed both hands over her face, and started again. “I don’t know how to say this without sounding dramatic. If every request for space gets treated like cruelty, then you stop being allowed to ask for space.”

She looked directly into the lens.

“If somebody says they feel safer when you can’t leave, that isn’t the same as you being safe.”

Brooke ended the recording at four minutes and twelve seconds. She cut one false start and left the rest alone.

Claire was still sitting outside.

“You said them,” she said.

“I said people who recovered.”

“You said them.”

Brooke opened the door wider. “What should I say?”

“Our names.”

“I have.”

“Then say them again.”

Brooke did not answer. Claire stood and brushed lint from Brooke’s flannel.

“Mom says we have to leave in four minutes.”

“You counted?”

“You said seven.”

At school, the assistant principal met them before first period.

Mr. Dorsey had always looked uncomfortable around students, as if teenagers were an audience he had not prepared for. That

morning he held his office door open and asked Brooke and Claire to sit together on the small couch.

Brooke chose the chair.

"We've had some calls," he said.

"From reporters?"

"One reporter. Several parents. A local account reposted part of your video with the school name."

"I didn't give them the name."

"I understand."

"Do you?"

Mr. Dorsey folded his hands, unfolded them, then pushed his glasses higher. "I don't know what the right response is yet. I do know we have students being followed by reporters and other students being called monsters."

Claire sat at the end of the couch, watching Brooke.

"She broke a bathroom lock," Brooke said.

"At home?"

"Does it matter?"

"It affects what the school can address."

"She's left class to find me more than once."

Mr. Dorsey turned to Claire. "Is that true?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

"I wanted to know where she was."

He nodded. "Wanting reassurance makes sense. Leaving class without permission doesn't. Both things can be true."

"Okay," Claire said.

Brooke laughed once. "That's the whole response?"

"No. Claire stays in class unless a teacher releases her. You can ask for separate counseling appointments. But Brooke, the school cannot treat your sister as dangerous based on videos and family conflict."

"The videos are evidence."

"They're edited."

The word landed harder than it should have. Brooke had said the same thing about other people's clips. Editing did not make something false, but it meant someone had chosen what remained.

Mr. Dorsey slid a printed page across the desk. The heading read *TEMPORARY SEPARATION DISTRESS: SCHOOL SUPPORT GUIDANCE*.

"The counselor will speak with you both," he said.

Brooke left the paper on his desk. Mr. Dorsey looked at it as if he was no more certain what it meant than she was.

During second period, the intercom asked teachers to avoid sending recovered students into hallways alone. The announcement framed the request as a temporary accommodation, no different from elevator access or extra testing time.

In the cafeteria, tables had been pushed closer together. A sign near the doors read *NO ONE EATS ALONE*. It had been borrowed from an old anti-bullying campaign and therefore looked wholesome. Staff redirected students carrying lunches toward occupied tables.

Brooke chose a chair at the end of a crowded row. Claire appeared five minutes later with permission from her teacher, carrying a tray with spinach, olives, and plain rice.

"You don't have this lunch period," Brooke said.

"Ms. Ferro said family support can happen during the school day."

Claire sat before Brooke could object. Across the cafeteria, Mr. Dorsey saw them together and gave Brooke a tired, encouraging smile.

By lunch, three students had asked whether Claire's eyes really glowed. One asked Brooke to film him pretending to vomit red medicine. A sophomore she did not know whispered, "My dad does it too," then walked away before Brooke could ask what she meant.

Her sixth upload passed ten thousand views before the final bell. The top reply said:

Your mother is trying to protect you. Stop turning love into evidence.

Brooke saved the comment.

At home, Sarah stood inside the front door waiting.

"You're eleven minutes late."

"Mr. Dorsey kept me."

"You could have called."

“You had my phone half the morning.”

“And then I gave it back.”

Claire entered behind Brooke. Sarah touched her shoulder, then Brooke’s, counting them by contact.

“I worry when I don’t know where you are,” Sarah said.

The sentence could have belonged to any mother. Brooke heard Claire’s voice beneath it anyway.

Upstairs, she opened her public archive to check what strangers could see. Hundreds of old videos waited beneath the outbreak uploads: school projects, Cooper as a puppy, Claire ruining takes, Mark fixing lights, Sarah calling everyone to dinner.

Brooke chose one from three years earlier and scrubbed through the foyer shot. Claire entered the front-door code while Brooke narrated something about composition. The keypad flashed blue at the edge of the frame.

The digits were visible. Brooke watched the sequence twice, sick with the stupidity of it. She had spent years insisting the camera remembered what people missed. Apparently it remembered passwords too.

Brooke paused, zoomed in, and watched Claire’s hand enter the code again.

She set the video to private.

Then she called Sarah.

“The front-door code is in an old video.”

Sarah was quiet for a beat. “Take it down.”

“I made it private. That doesn’t erase copies. We have to change the code.”

“I’ll look at the keypad manual tonight.”

“No, now.”

“Brooke, I am working.”

“Someone knows where I go to school.”

That reached her. Brooke heard keys clicking on Sarah’s end, then a drawer opening. “The installer card isn’t here. Your father kept all of that in the garage file box.”

“Then call him.”

“I will.”

Mark had not answered a live call in days.

“What do we do until then?”

“The dead bolt is locked when we’re home. Cooper is there when we’re not. I will call the keypad company after my check-in tomorrow.”

Brooke looked at the frozen blue buttons on her screen.

“Tomorrow is not the same as now.”

“I know.”

Sarah sounded worried. The worry did not change the code.

After they hung up, Brooke checked the video’s analytics. Most of its lifetime views came from years ago, but eleven people had watched it in the past week. The platform did not show who they were or whether anyone had saved it.

She began checking the rest of the archive anyway.

The video had never been popular. Forty-six lifetime views, most from relatives and classmates when Brooke first posted it. Eleven recent views should not have meant anything. Her older uploads were receiving stray traffic because strangers were searching her name.

Still, she downloaded the analytics page and saved the old video’s upload date, recent traffic sources, and the countries listed beneath them. Ten views came from channel pages or direct links. One came from search. The platform did not reveal the query.

Brooke changed every family video to private. For several minutes she watched thumbnails disappear from the public grid: Mark replacing the porch light, Claire learning to ride a bike, Sarah dancing badly in the kitchen. The outbreak videos remained, surrounded by blank space.

She had built the archive so memory would survive them. Now protecting the family meant making its ordinary life invisible.

CHAPTER 19

Something Moved

Cooper planted himself against Brooke's knees when she came downstairs and refused to move.

Sarah insisted Brooke go to school anyway.

"Yesterday you wanted me home," Brooke said.

"Yesterday I wanted you rested. Today I want you to finish the week."

"It's Monday."

"Then finish Monday."

Sarah stood at the front door with Brooke's lunch in one hand and Cooper's collar in the other. The dog had tried to follow Brooke outside. He kept his body angled away from Sarah while she held him.

Sarah's work bag and office badge waited beside the door. After dropping the girls off, she was driving to her first on-site check-in since the fever.

"Let him go," Brooke said.

"He can't go to school."

"I mean let go of his collar."

Sarah did. Cooper immediately crossed to Brooke and leaned against her knees.

"He needs a walk," Brooke said.

"Claire and I will take him."

Cooper looked up at Brooke.

"I'll do it after school."

"Straight home," Sarah said.

"I know."

“Say it.”

Brooke stared at her. “Straight home.”

Sarah smiled and kissed Brooke’s forehead. The affection was warm, familiar, and impossible to refuse without turning the morning into an argument.

“Did Mark answer?” Brooke asked.

“No. I found the keypad company’s number. I’ll call after the check-in.”

The code remained the same.

Brooke left with the place Sarah’s lips had touched feeling cold in the wind.

The school had added a counselor table near the entrance beneath a sign offering *RECOVERY SUPPORT CHECK-INS*.

Brooke kept her camera in her bag.

At ten thirty, Brooke received a message from the counselor.

Please report to Student Services before leaving campus today. We want to review a family-supported safety plan and discuss responsible online communication.

She took a screenshot.

At lunch, Nora Patel sat across from her without asking.

“You’re famous,” Nora said.

“No.”

“A reporter was outside this morning.”

Brooke looked toward the cafeteria doors.

“Security made him leave,” Nora continued. “He asked if anyone knew you.”

“Did you?”

“I know you.”

“That’s not what I asked.”

Nora tore open a packet of mustard. “I didn’t tell him anything.”

Brooke believed her. She was no longer sure belief was a safe habit.

“People are saying your mom called the school,” Nora said.

“She did.”

“People are saying Claire attacked you.”

Brooke looked toward the far side of the cafeteria. Claire sat with two girls from her grade, shoulder pressed to one of theirs. She was watching Brooke over the other girl’s head.

“She broke a door.”

“That’s not what people are saying.”

“What are they saying?”

Nora lowered her voice. “That you locked her in a bathroom to get footage.”

Brooke’s appetite disappeared. “Who said that?”

“Claire told the counselor the handle broke while you were inside. Somebody in the office heard. After that, I don’t know.”

The story was wrong in several directions at once. Brooke pictured trying to correct it online and feeding it more details. She pictured Sarah reading every correction as another public betrayal.

“You should probably stop posting,” Nora said.

“You sound like my mom.”

“Your mom might be right about one thing.”

The sentence made Brooke stand.

“I didn’t mean she’s right about Claire,” Nora said.

“You don’t know anything about Claire.”

“Neither does anyone watching six-minute videos.”

Brooke left before the bell.

In the bathroom, she searched her own name. A local discussion board had posted the neighborhood where the Bennetts lived, narrowed from the school bus route visible in an old snow-day video. One reply named Sarah and Mark and linked a county property record. The board had hidden the link, but its cached preview still showed the front windows, the split maple by the walk, and enough of the street number for Brooke to recognize her own house. Another person claimed to have driven past it.

Brooke reported the post. The automated response thanked her and said location context did not necessarily violate policy unless it included a precise address or credible threat.

She sent Sarah one screenshot containing the post, preview, and time.

Sarah called immediately.

“Do not leave campus,” she said.

“I was already trying.”

“Stay with an adult until I get there.”

“Adults are the ones keeping me here.”

“Brooke, please.”

The fear in Sarah's voice was real. It was also useful to whatever part of her wanted Brooke contained. Brooke hated that she could no longer separate those truths.

The exterior doors near the gym had been locked from a panel Brooke could not reach. She pushed the bar anyway, out of disbelief more than hope, and it gave the flat quarter inch of a door that was not going to open. A security officer stood a few feet back, polite and unbothered, a laminated card clipped to his jacket.

"Where are you headed?"

"Home."

"Do you have dismissal approval?"

"I'm seventeen."

"That's not approval."

Brooke showed him the counselor message and said she felt sick. He nodded like a man who had been told this might happen and directed her to the nurse. He did not open the door. He was still standing beside it when she looked back from the end of the hall.

At Student Services, the counselor spoke about harassment, family privacy, and how public attention could distort judgment. She recommended Brooke take a forty-eight-hour break from uploading and asked whether Sarah could pick her up.

"I can walk."

"Your mother's asked us not to release you alone while you're receiving threats."

"She asked that?"

"It's a safety request."

Brooke looked at the counselor's open doorway. A girl waited outside with both arms around another girl's waist.

"Call her," Brooke said.

Sarah answered on the first ring. She could not leave work immediately, so Brooke waited forty minutes in the main office while the reporter's car remained across the street.

When Sarah arrived, Claire was with her.

"Why isn't she in class?" Brooke asked.

"She was upset."

"So you took her out?"

"She wanted to come."

Claire reached for Brooke's hand. Brooke put both hands in her coat pockets.

The drive home took six minutes. Sarah asked twice whether the reporter had spoken to Brooke and once whether anyone had followed them. Her concern was practical enough to be useful.

"You see why I worry," she said.

Brooke watched the houses pass. "You called the school and told them not to let me leave."

"I told them there were threats."

"You made them keep me there."

"I made sure you weren't sent into a parking lot with a stranger waiting."

Brooke had no answer that did not sound reckless. Sarah reached across the console and squeezed her knee.

"You don't have to prove you're independent every minute," she said.

At home, the keypad gave its usual two-note chirp when Claire entered the code. Brooke watched the front door swing inward.

Cooper met them in the foyer. He rushed past Sarah and Claire to Brooke, whining as he pushed his nose against her hands. The fur along his shoulders was still raised.

The water bowl beside the kitchen was overturned. Damp paw prints crossed the foyer and stopped near the front door.

"I said we'd walk him," Sarah said.

"Did you?"

Sarah looked at the time. "We were interrupted."

Brooke took the leash. "I'm going now."

"Not alone."

"Mom."

"The reporter knows where you go to school."

"He doesn't know where I walk."

"You don't know that."

Claire reached for the second leash hanging in the coat closet. "I'll come."

Cooper backed away from her.

Brooke unclipped the leash and went upstairs instead.

Cooper followed halfway, then returned to the front door. He sniffed the threshold, paced to the kitchen, and came back whining. Brooke crouched beside him.

“Did somebody come in?”

His ears shifted toward the garage. The furnace started, and Cooper barked once at the sound. Then he drank from the puddle around his overturned bowl.

Sarah watched from the stairs. “He was alone and anxious.”

“He doesn’t knock over his water when he’s anxious.”

“He knocks over his water because his feet are the size of dinner plates.”

That was also true. Brooke photographed the paw prints before wiping them up, then noticed every print belonged to Cooper.

Her bedroom door was open.

She usually left it open. She stood in the hall trying to remember that morning. Sarah had kissed her at the front door. Brooke had come down with her camera bag and closed the bedroom door because Cooper had been inside.

Maybe she had left it open after all.

The room looked normal. Bed unmade. Charger beside the desk. Camera batteries lined up beneath the monitor. The blue journal was still in the bottom drawer.

Brooke crossed to the family photograph on the dresser. It showed all four Bennetts at the beach, Claire’s hands sandy and Brooke laughing from inside the mound. The frame sat closer to the edge than she remembered.

She touched the dust behind it. A clean rectangle marked where it had been.

The frame itself was warm from the afternoon sun. Brooke lifted it and checked the back as if a stranger might have left a note there. One metal tab sat raised. Behind the photograph was nothing but cardboard.

Her closet door stood open by two inches. Brooke always left it open because the lower hinge squealed. The jewelry dish on the dresser held the same cheap silver necklace, three hair ties, and one earring without its mate. A scarf Sarah had given her was folded on top of the hamper instead of inside it.

Each detail could have been old. Together they made the room feel recently considered.

Only an inch. Maybe less.

“Mom?” she called.

Sarah came to the bottom of the stairs. “What?”

“Were you in my room?”

“I put laundry on your bed yesterday.”

“Today.”

“No.”

Claire appeared beside her. “I was.”

Brooke looked over the railing. “When?”

“Last night.”

“Did you touch my dresser?”

“I don’t remember touching it.”

The answer was narrow enough to be truthful and broad enough to leave Brooke nowhere.

Brooke closed the bedroom door and knelt at the foot of the bed. The keepsake box was pushed beneath the frame, where it always stayed. She drew it out.

Inside were birthday cards, old film-festival programs, and the adoption folder. The slim paper container holding copies of her adoption documents was not fully closed. One corner of the lid rested above the clasp.

Brooke lifted it. The papers inside appeared untouched: amended birth certificate, agency summaries, copies Sarah had given her when she turned sixteen. Beneath them was the envelope containing the original letter from her biological mother.

She did not open it.

Sarah had read Brooke’s journal before. Claire took her clothes and entered her room. Either one could have moved the photograph and opened the box.

Brooke looked at the dark camera lens on her desk.

There was no footage of the room. No timestamp. No way to prove whether anything had moved or whether stress had changed the location in her memory.

Downstairs, Sarah called that dinner was ready.

Brooke closed the adoption container carefully and pressed the clasp until it clicked. Then she crossed to the desk, drew the blue journal from beneath the notebooks in the bottom drawer, and set it inside the keepsake box beside the adoption folder. If someone had been standing in her room, the things she could not replace belonged together, in one place she could seal.

She took photographs of the box, the drawer, the dresser, and the bedroom door. Then she tore a sliver from the blank edge of a

sticky note, laid it across the keepsake-box seam, and photographed that too. It would fall if someone lifted the lid.

She wedged an old phone behind the books on her desk with its camera facing the room. The battery would not last all day, but it could record while they were gone.

Only then did she slide the box beneath the bed and take one final photograph.

Downstairs, Claire had set the table. Sarah was chopping spinach while Claire rinsed mushrooms in the sink. They worked around each other without colliding, passing the knife and colander with the ease of people who had cooked together for years even though Claire had never volunteered for dinner before.

"There you are," Sarah said when Brooke entered.

The phrase tightened Brooke's stomach. Sarah glanced up, noticed, and softened it with a smile.

"Wash your hands."

Claire put a mushroom into her mouth. "I made enough for you."

"I don't like mushrooms."

"You could change your mind."

Brooke looked from Claire to Sarah. Sarah kept chopping.

"She doesn't have to eat them," Sarah said.

Claire accepted the correction. "Okay."

Brooke sat at the table with Cooper pressed beneath her knees. The meal was ordinary. That did not make the upstairs room feel empty of whoever had stood inside it.

CHAPTER 20

Missing

The next morning, Brooke checked the keepsake box before school. Before going downstairs, she started the old phone recording behind the books.

The clasp was closed. The photograph matched the image on her phone. The beach frame remained where she had left it. The paper strip still bridged the keepsake-box seam.

She almost stayed home.

Sarah made the decision impossible by asking, “Do you want me to call the school?”

The offer sounded generous. Brooke heard the price inside it: another day in the house, another day with Sarah deciding when her phone was too loud and Claire counting minutes outside the door.

“No,” Brooke said. “I’m going.”

Sarah drove both girls. At the curb she said, “Straight home,” and Brooke answered without making her repeat it.

“Did you call the keypad company?”

“They need the installer number or Mark’s account verification. I left him another message.”

“So the code is still the same.”

“The house is locked, Brooke.”

“With a code strangers can watch me type.”

Sarah’s mouth tightened. “I am handling it.”

Sarah continued toward the office after they got out. Cooper would be alone again until she returned.

The reporter was gone. Students still recognized Brooke in the hall, but most only looked. The attention had changed overnight from curiosity into something flatter. The platform had added a larger information panel beneath Upload Six, and its view count rose more slowly than the previous post.

At lunch, Brooke received an email from a regional news producer asking for a remote interview with parental consent.

She deleted it.

Then she restored it from trash and saved a screenshot.

She spent the final period watching the clock.

At 3:04, Sarah texted:

Are you leaving now?

At 3:06:

Claire says she can't find you.

At 3:07:

Please answer so I know you're safe.

Brooke had not yet left the classroom.

She typed *I'm coming* and deleted it. She put the phone away and walked to Claire's room.

Claire stood outside the door waiting.

"You couldn't find me?" Brooke asked.

"You weren't answering."

"For three minutes."

"It felt longer."

The phrase had become a family argument no one else could hear.

They walked home together. Claire did not touch Brooke, but she remained close enough that their coats brushed at every turn.

The front door was locked. Brooke entered the code and watched the buttons light beneath her fingers. The same digits still opened it.

Cooper met Brooke in the foyer but did not settle. He sniffed along the base of the front door, crossed to the stairs, then returned to the foyer with a low sound in his throat.

The kitchen water bowl was upright. One cabinet door stood open above the counter.

"Did Mom leave that?" Brooke asked.

Claire glanced in. "Probably."

Sarah did not leave cabinets open. Mark did. Brooke closed it and found nothing disturbed inside except the tea box facing backward.

Cooper went to the back of the house and sniffed the garage door. The alarm panel showed no warning. Whoever knew the code would not have triggered one.

Her bedroom door was closed.

She had closed it that morning. The dresser photograph had not moved. The keepsake box remained under the bed with its clasp fastened. The paper strip lay on the carpet beside it.

Brooke checked the old phone behind the books. Its battery was dead. The recording ended after fifty-three minutes, showing only an empty room and a bar of changing daylight.

Brooke opened it anyway.

The adoption container was closed. The letter remained inside. The blue journal was gone.

She emptied the box onto the floor.

Cards, programs, loose photographs, two ticket stubs from a movie Mark had taken her to when she was eleven. No journal.

Brooke pulled open the bottom desk drawer. Old notebooks. Cables. A dead external drive. She checked beneath the bed, behind the dresser, inside the camera bag, and between the mattress and wall.

She opened the old phone's final recording again and checked its metadata. Fifty-three minutes. No interruption, no corruption, no movement beyond the light. The battery had died before ten.

The keypad video had shown the code. The school schedule was public. Brooke had announced online that Sarah and Claire had recovered and that the house frightened her. She had given a stranger every ingredient except the address, and strangers online were already working on that.

The thought was too large and shapeless. Claire was standing downstairs. Claire had a history of taking things. Anger preferred a person it could reach.

Cooper followed each movement, then left the room and stood at the top of the stairs facing the front door.

Brooke opened the keypad app Sarah had installed years ago and forgotten. It showed battery status, not an entry history. From

the front window she could see the neighbor's doorbell camera aimed toward the street, with the Bennetts' hedge blocking its view of their door.

Someone could have used the code while the recording phone was already dead. Someone could also have entered the room the night before, before Brooke set any of it up.

Claire had watched Brooke put the journal away. Sarah had read it once. Those facts felt closer than a stranger because Brooke already knew how to be angry at them.

"Claire!"

Her sister appeared almost immediately.

"Give it back."

"What?"

"My journal."

Claire looked at the objects spread across the floor. "I don't have it."

"You were in here."

"Not today."

"You take everything."

"Clothes."

"You took my memory card once."

"I gave it back."

"Because I caught you."

Claire's face changed. Not anger. Hurt, or something close enough to use the same muscles. "I didn't take your journal."

Brooke stood. "Where is it?"

"I don't know."

"You knew it was in the drawer."

"You showed me."

During the beach video, Brooke remembered setting the journal back beneath the notebooks while Claire stood in the doorway.

"You watched me put it away."

"Yes."

"And yesterday you were in my room."

"At night."

"How do I know?"

Claire stared at her. "Because I said."

The answer stopped Brooke. If Claire had taken it today, she could not say she had not. If she had moved it without remembering, or if someone else had entered, the words still held. Brooke knew that. She also knew Claire had broken a bathroom lock to reach her.

"Did you see anyone near the house?"

"No."

"Did Cooper bark?"

"I was at school."

Brooke heard how stupid the question was and hated Claire for making her hear it.

"Open your room."

"Why?"

"Because I'm looking."

Claire did not move.

"If you don't have it, let me look."

"You don't let me look in here."

"That's different."

"Because it's yours?"

"Yes."

Claire's mouth tightened. "Mine is mine."

Brooke pushed past her.

Claire caught the back of Brooke's coat but released it before Brooke turned. Cooper moved between them, not growling, only insisting on space.

Claire's room smelled like the citrus shampoo she had used for years. Brooke opened the top desk drawer, checked beneath the bed, moved stacks of borrowed clothes from the chair.

"Stop," Claire said.

"Then tell me where it is."

"I don't know."

Sarah came upstairs while Brooke was opening the closet.

"What are you doing?"

"She took my journal."

"No, I didn't," Claire said.

Sarah looked at the room, then at Brooke. "Get out of her things."

"She goes through mine whenever she wants."

"That doesn't make this okay."

"The journal has private stuff in it."

"I know."

Brooke turned. Sarah's face had shifted at the mention of the journal.

"Did you take it?"

"No."

"You've read it."

Sarah did not deny that. "Not recently. I did not take it."

The direct answer should have narrowed the possibilities.

Instead it left Brooke with nowhere to put her anger.

Claire stood beside Cooper. "I said I didn't."

"You also broke a lock."

"That isn't the journal."

"You don't get to act like boundaries matter now."

Claire flinched.

It was small. Brooke saw it and continued anyway.

"You follow me, take my clothes, come into my room, grab me when I leave. Why wouldn't you take it?"

Claire's eyes filled.

Brooke remembered the library. The tears she had not understood. The apology Claire still deserved and the one Brooke had finally given too late.

"Maybe you hid it so I couldn't leave," Brooke said.

Claire looked frightened then, but not by the accusation. By the word *leave*.

"Where are you going?"

"That's not the point."

Sarah stepped between them. "Brooke, enough."

"You both keep saying enough when you mean stop asking."

"I mean stop hurting your sister."

"You remember being my sister when it's useful."

Claire's tears stopped moving. Sarah went still.

Brooke wanted to pull the words back before they became another last thing the real Claire heard. Instead she stood there breathing hard while Cooper pressed against her leg.

Claire said, "I remember being your sister."

Nothing in her voice proved who was speaking.

Brooke left the room.

In the hall, shame caught her. She had reached for the same wound again, only with different words.

She returned to Claire's doorway.

Sarah was kneeling beside the bed gathering the clothes Brooke had thrown aside. Claire stood at the window with her arms crossed tightly over Brooke's borrowed flannel.

"I shouldn't have searched your room," Brooke said.

Claire did not turn.

"I shouldn't have said that."

"Which part?"

Brooke swallowed. "That you only remember being my sister when it's useful."

Claire looked over her shoulder. Her face was dry now. "You think I'm gone."

Sarah stopped folding.

"I think something happened to you," Brooke said.

"That isn't what I said."

Brooke understood the trap because she had built it. Claire wanted an answer Brooke did not have and could not give without causing harm.

"I don't know," Brooke said. "I'm sorry."

Claire's shoulders lowered by a fraction. "I didn't take it."

"Okay."

"Do you believe me?"

"I believe you said it."

It was not enough. Claire turned back to the window.

Sarah carried the folded clothes past Brooke without touching her. "That was cruel."

"I know."

"Knowing afterward doesn't protect her."

Brooke almost said that Sarah had failed to protect either of them. She let the sentence remain unspoken.

She searched her own space again, slower this time. The drawer where the journal had been was not arranged the way she remembered. One notebook faced spine-in. The envelope in the adoption container sat beneath the agency papers instead of above them.

Or she had moved it yesterday while checking.

She opened the letter.

The name at the bottom was still there in blue ink, her biological mother's full name beneath a paragraph Brooke had read enough times to know by shape. The envelope was present. So were the agency copies and the photograph Sarah had given her at sixteen.

The journal was the only thing missing.

Downstairs, Claire began to cry.

Brooke sat on the floor with her back against the bed. Cooper rested his chin on her knee.

She opened the photographs from the previous afternoon and compared them one by one. The sticky-note seal had fallen, but it could have slipped when the heat started. The keepsake box sat at a slightly different angle. The journal was visible beneath the notebooks in one image, a strip of faded blue cloth no wider than her finger.

Someone had taken it after she placed the seal.

Brooke zoomed in on the bedroom doorway reflected in the beach photograph's glass. The reflection showed only the empty hall and the raised phone in her own hand.

Proof that the journal had existed yesterday did not identify who held it today.

CHAPTER 21

Not Yet

Sarah took the keepsake-box key the following morning.

She did it in front of Brooke. No deception. She held out her hand and waited until Brooke gave her the tiny brass key to the keepsake box.

"You tore through Claire's room," Sarah said. "You're too upset to keep escalating this."

"It's my key."

"And the box is still in your room."

"Locked."

"For now."

Brooke looked at Sarah's open palm. "You're taking my key because I accused Claire of taking my journal."

"I'm keeping one argument from becoming five."

"You don't get to decide that."

"I am your mother."

The words were not louder than anything else Sarah said. They carried more weight.

Brooke dropped the key into her palm.

Sarah closed her fingers around it. "Thank you."

"Don't thank me."

"You gave it to me."

"Because you stood in the doorway until I did."

Sarah's face softened. "I don't want to fight with you."

"Then stop making every choice."

"I canceled one workshop because your father was away and people were getting sick. I kept you home when you hadn't slept. I

asked the school not to release you alone while a reporter waited outside. Which one proves I want to control your life?"

Each decision had an explanation. Together they had walls.

"Give me the key."

"Not while you're this angry."

"What has to happen before I get it back?"

"You have to calm down."

"How will you know?"

Sarah reached toward Brooke's face. Brooke stepped back.

Pain crossed Sarah's expression. Genuine pain. "This is what I mean. Every time I try to help, you act like I'm taking something from you."

"You are holding the key."

Sarah looked down at it as if she had forgotten. Then she put it in her pocket.

"Stay home today," she said. "We can talk when neither of us is performing for an audience."

"I haven't recorded you."

"Not yet."

The phrase made Brooke's skin tighten.

Sarah noticed. "What?"

"Nothing."

"Brooke."

"I said nothing."

Sarah allowed her to leave the room. That was how Brooke thought of it now, even when no one blocked the doorway.

Before going downstairs, Brooke checked the public comments. The newest upload had stopped climbing overnight. Searching the title returned a state information page and a clip from the morning news in which an anchor warned against "unverified narratives that divide recovering families."

The anchor did not name Brooke. The comments did.

She is a minor having a family crisis in public.
--

Her mother needs to take the camera away.

Someone should bring that girl home before the internet destroys her.

Brooke saved the page locally. When she refreshed, the third comment had moved to the top.

She went downstairs and found Claire sitting on the kitchen floor with Cooper's leash in her lap. Cooper stood on the other side of the island.

"He won't come," Claire said.

"Give me the leash."

Claire held it out. Brooke took it without touching her hand.

"Are you still mad?"

"Yes."

"I didn't take the journal."

"I heard you."

"You don't believe me."

Brooke clipped the leash to Cooper's collar. "I don't know what I believe."

Claire nodded once. It was a more ordinary reaction than pleading would have been.

Sarah came into the kitchen. "Where are you going?"

"Walking Cooper."

"I asked you to stay home."

"You told me to."

"Brooke."

"He needs to go out."

"Then we'll all go."

Cooper moved behind Brooke.

"He won't walk with you."

Sarah looked at the dog. "He will."

"He won't."

The certainty in Brooke's voice sharpened the room. Sarah did not argue with it. She picked up her coat.

"We can try."

Brooke unclipped the leash.

"Fine," she said. "He can stay."

Sarah stopped with one arm in her sleeve. "You were just insisting he needed to go."

"I changed my mind."

"Because I wanted to come?"

Brooke set the leash on the counter. "Yes."

Sarah took off the coat. Her hurt returned, quieter this time.

"Direct pursuit makes you run," she said.

Brooke stared at her.

“What?”

“Nothing.” Sarah folded the coat over a chair. “You’ve always been like that. The harder I try, the farther away you go.”

It was true. Brooke had written versions of it in the missing journal. She had probably said it in videos. Sarah did not need secret knowledge to know her own daughter.

Still, Brooke stored the sentence.

The television ran in the living room. A hospital spokesperson described a new family-reunification desk for patients experiencing “prolonged temporary separation.” The service would help verify addresses, contact relatives, and arrange transportation after discharge.

A phone number appeared beneath the hospital logo. Brooke searched it and found a new page describing the service.

Family Reunification can assist recovered individuals whose household members are temporarily unreachable, displaced, or reluctant to resume contact. Trained coordinators may confirm residence information through available public and emergency records.

Reluctant to resume contact.

Brooke took a screenshot. The page offered no instructions for the person who did not want to be found.

The segment showed a woman embracing an adult son outside Saint Vincent’s. Neither released the other before the clip ended.

Sarah watched from the kitchen doorway.

“That’s good,” she said.

“Is it?”

“People are scared. They want their families.”

“What if their families don’t want them?”

Sarah turned. “Why wouldn’t they?”

Brooke looked at Claire.

Claire had gone upstairs. A few minutes later Brooke heard her bedroom door close.

The house became quiet enough for the refrigerator motor to sound loud. Sarah returned to work at the dining table. Brooke sat on the living-room floor with Cooper and pretended to review footage on her laptop.

At noon, Claire crossed the landing. Brooke heard one floorboard, then nothing. She waited for Claire to come

downstairs, ask what she was doing, or sit close enough to watch the screen. Claire did none of those things.

Brooke carried an empty glass to the kitchen and paused at the stairs. From above came a murmur too soft to separate from the television.

Maybe Claire said, "It's okay."

Maybe she was reading something.

Brooke took one step upward. The sound stopped.

"Claire?"

"What?"

Her voice came from her room.

"Were you talking?"

"Yes."

"To who?"

A pause. "Myself."

It was a complete answer. It proved almost nothing.

"What did you say?"

"I said you need space."

Brooke waited.

From behind the door, Claire whispered something else. This time Brooke heard the separate words.

"Not yet."

"What?"

The room went silent.

Brooke opened the door before remembering that Claire had asked for privacy by closing it.

Claire sat at her desk with a math worksheet in front of her and Brooke's missing green pen in her hand. She looked up, startled.

"Who were you talking to?"

"Myself."

"You said not yet."

Claire looked at the worksheet. "I wasn't done."

"You weren't writing."

"I was thinking."

Brooke searched her face for the reflective green and saw only irritation. "What isn't happening yet?"

"I don't know what you mean."

The answer was direct. If the no-lie rule Brooke suspected was real, it mattered. If Claire genuinely did not know what she had repeated, it mattered more.

Brooke noticed her own position in the doorway, blocking the exit while demanding access to a private thought. She stepped aside.

“Sorry.”

Claire’s gaze moved to the open hall. “You always say that after.”

Brooke closed the door again, gently.

Brooke gripped the empty glass. It could have been Claire trying to remember a rule. It could have been mockery. It could have been the ordinary intelligence of someone who had finally noticed that following Brooke made her leave.

“Okay,” Brooke said.

Claire did not open the door.

Sarah ended her work call at one.

“Are you calmer?” she asked.

Brooke looked toward the ceiling. “Yes.”

It was a lie. Sarah appeared relieved.

“Then we can talk.”

“Later.”

Sarah nodded. “Whenever you’re ready.”

No demand. No reaching hand. No reminder about the key in her pocket.

Brooke understood only that the method had changed. Sarah had raised her for seventeen years. She did not need whispers or secret instructions to know that direct pressure made Brooke pull away.

That afternoon Sarah returned the key without being asked.

She set it beside Brooke’s laptop and said, “I don’t want you to feel trapped.”

Brooke looked at the small brass shape. “Then why take it?”

“Because you were hurting Claire and I wanted the fight to stop.”

“Did it?”

“No.”

The admission was so ordinary that Brooke nearly apologized. Sarah sat in the armchair across the room, leaving the space between them open.

"I called the keypad company," she said. "They still need Mark's verification. I asked for an emergency override. They said someone will call tomorrow."

"Did you tell them the code was online?"

"Yes."

"Did you dead-bolt the door?"

"Yes."

Sarah had answered every practical question. Brooke could not accuse her of doing nothing. She also knew the journal had disappeared through a locked house while everybody was away.

"Your father will answer," Sarah said.

Brooke looked at her.

Sarah corrected herself. "I hope he will."

It was the first time she had allowed uncertainty into the sentence.

She opened the private observation file and typed beneath the entry about memory:

Sarah is giving me more room after taking the key. Claire stayed upstairs after I said I was angry. Maybe they are learning when not to push. Maybe they already knew.

Brooke saved the file to the chemistry folder and copied it to the camera card.

Across the room, Sarah folded laundry while giving Brooke exactly enough space to keep typing.

CHAPTER 22

The List

By morning, Brooke's warning had become harder to find than the advice telling people to ignore it.

Upload Six still existed, but an exact-title search while logged out placed a health-department panel and two similarly worded news clips ahead of it. Brooke's appeared fourth with a gray medical-context notice. The frightened reports remained under newest; the default ranking favored verified local accounts and official guidance.

Do not isolate someone who loves you.

Recovery can look different for every family.

Brooke's mother is trying to keep her safe.

Brooke took one dated screenshot of each search state, then stopped when her phone storage warning appeared. Deleting ordinary family footage felt like cooperating with the thing happening to the house. She moved the verified originals, hospital footage, uploads, Mark calls, keypad clip, and observation file onto the external drive, then put a second copy of the observation file on the camera card. Three copies in the same house were not real backup, but cloud storage felt like handing the files to the systems already burying her uploads.

Dogs notice first.

They remember everything.

They do not like being alone.

They can say true things that make you believe something else.

Closed doors make it worse.

They remember enough to use it.

The list looked embarrassingly small compared with what had happened. It did not explain the purge, the food, the reflective eyes, the words Claire might have whispered, or why different people wanted the same things. It did not explain why the hospital and school and news had started sounding like Sarah.

It only described what Brooke had survived long enough to notice.

She added:

Direct pursuit makes me run.

The sentence sounded obvious. It also felt important.

Cooper lay beneath the desk with his shoulder against her ankle. When Sarah passed the open door carrying folded towels, he raised his head and watched until she disappeared into the bathroom.

"You can close it," Claire said from across the hall.

Brooke looked up. Claire stood in her own doorway wearing Brooke's green sweatshirt. She had not asked for it.

"Close what?"

"Your door."

Brooke waited for the condition.

Claire touched the cuff of the sweatshirt. "I won't sit outside."

"Why?"

"You don't like it."

The answer could have been kindness. It could have been strategy. Brooke was tired of every gentle thing arriving with two meanings.

"Take off my sweatshirt."

Claire looked down at it. "I like this one."

"That's why you keep stealing it."

"Borrowing."

The word belonged to the old Claire so perfectly that Brooke nearly smiled. Claire saw the almost-smile and stepped forward.

Cooper stood.

Claire stopped at once.

"I'll leave it outside later," she said.

She went back into her room and shut the door.

Brooke closed hers too. She took the keepsake box from beneath the bed and checked it again, using the key Sarah had returned. The broken strip of paper remained on the carpet where Brooke had left it. She had photographed it, the empty place where the journal had been, and the front-door keypad. None of it proved who had entered.

Someone had known the code.

That fact was no longer abstract. Eleven recent views on the old family video meant at least eleven chances for a stranger to pause on the same blue-lit numbers Brooke had missed for years. She had accused Claire after understanding that. She had searched Claire's room because anger had been easier than imagining an unknown person standing beside her bed.

Brooke opened the old phone's recording again. Fifty-three minutes of an empty room. At minute twelve, Cooper barked downstairs. At minute fourteen, he barked again. The sound was distant and blunt, nothing like the sustained alarm he used for delivery drivers.

At minute fifty-three, the recording stopped.

The journal could have disappeared any time after that.

She checked the search results for local break-ins. The police department's latest post advised residents not to travel alone and encouraged families to report missing relatives through the hospital's reunification desk. Searching *home entry keypad Ashcroft* produced installer advertisements and a news article about keeping familiar access codes during emergencies so relatives could come home.

The local news site had replaced its red banner with pale blue. The lead story showed a family embracing outside Saint Vincent's beneath the headline *ASHCROFT FINDS ITS WAY HOME*.

Farther down, a smaller article reported that police response times had increased because of illness and staffing reassignments. The police chief asked residents to reserve emergency calls for immediate physical danger and to resolve "family separation concerns" through the reunification desk.

Brooke saved both pages. The first told people how to feel. The second explained why help might not come.

Downstairs, Sarah's phone rang, and Brooke heard her answer in the careful voice she used for people she did not know.

Brooke came to the top of the stairs.

"Yes, this is her mother." A pause. "They're both here. We've all been home." A longer pause, Sarah's tone staying pleasant, almost grateful. "Of course. I can confirm that."

She confirmed the address. She confirmed that Claire had been discharged from Saint Vincent's and that she herself had recovered without complications. When the voice on the other end asked, she spelled Brooke's name, gave her date of birth, and said yes, seventeen, still at home, still enrolled. She wrote something on the pad by the toaster and read it back to make sure she had it right.

"Who was that?" Brooke asked when she hung up.

"Family Reunification. They're confirming everyone made it home after discharge." Sarah looked pleased to have an answer that was entirely true. "The hospital forwards the records. I filled in the parts they were missing."

"They were missing my birthday."

"They asked for it."

"They didn't have it before. Now it's in a file with our address."

Sarah glanced at the pad, where a case number sat in her neat handwriting, then moved her coffee cup over it without appearing to decide to. "It is a desk that helps families find each other. That is all it is."

That was the part no one would hear from her. The desk was exactly what it claimed to be. It was staffed by someone polite, working from real discharge records, and it had just opened a file on a girl who had told the internet she wanted to leave a house she was afraid of. None of it had to be sinister to close around her. It only had to be efficient, and to treat a person trying to leave as a family it had not finished bringing home.

Brooke went back upstairs with the case number memorized and nowhere to put it.

Brooke searched *someone entered my house after recovery*.

The first result was her own video.

The next was a forum thread with most replies hidden for violating community standards. Brooke opened the cached version. A user named WrenHollow had written:

My husband says nobody came inside. The dog hid behind the washing machine. Our wedding album was on the kitchen table.

She saved the page as a PDF and tried to message WrenHollow. The account no longer existed.

At noon Sarah made grilled cheese and tomato soup. She brought Brooke's plate upstairs instead of calling her down.

"You need to eat," she said.

"Put it on the dresser."

Sarah did. She did not look at the screen or ask what Brooke was doing.

"The keypad company called back," Brooke said.

"They need your father's authorization or an installer reset."

"He's not answering."

"I know."

"Then we replace it."

"With what money today?"

"A lock."

"We already have a lock."

"A lock strangers don't know."

Sarah sat on the edge of the desk chair. Cooper moved from beneath it before she could touch him.

"I locked the dead bolt," she said. "I put a chair under the back-door handle and turned on the window chimes. No one is coming in while we're here."

"Someone came in while we weren't."

"You don't know that."

"Claire and you said you didn't take the journal."

"We didn't."

"Then somebody else did."

Sarah's face tightened. "Or you moved it. Or you hid it because you were frightened and don't remember. You haven't been sleeping."

"You think I staged this too?"

"I think you're scared enough to turn every uncertainty into proof."

Brooke looked at the camera on her desk. "And I think you use uncertainty whenever the truth would make you let me leave."

Sarah absorbed the sentence without flinching. "Where would you go?"

Brooke had no answer ready. Nora's house would be the first place Sarah called. The police would return her. The hospital would reunite her. Mark was a silence in another city.

Sarah stood. "Eat before it gets cold."

At the door she paused.

"I didn't read it again," she said.

Brooke looked at her.

"Your journal. I read it years ago. I should not have. I did not take it, and I did not read it again."

Every word was precise enough to hurt.

After Sarah left, Brooke locked the bedroom door and ate half the sandwich. She opened a message to Claire.

I should not have searched your room after you told me no.

Brooke read the sentence twice. It was true and insufficient. She saved it as a draft instead of sending it.

Then she searched her email for the interview requests she had ignored, looking for one person who might believe her without turning her into a segment.

The unknown Connecticut number from two mornings earlier had left no voicemail. A new email waited in the public address attached to her channel.

The sender's name was Anna.

The message contained four lines.

We met while you were walking Cooper.

You were right to be careful.

I think I may know something about the question you have been asking the longest.

You decide whether we speak.

Below the signature was the name of a diner near the town green and a time the following evening. No demand. No promise. No request that Brooke come alone.

Brooke searched the name Anna beside the email address and found nothing useful. The profile image attached to the message was blank. The question she had been asking the longest was not about Claire.

Brooke moved the email to trash.

Then she restored it and took a screenshot.

She opened the message headers. The sending service had hidden the originating address behind its own servers. The account was less than a week old. Its recovery email and phone number were private.

Brooke replied without committing to the meeting.

How did you find the dog park?

Anna answered eleven minutes later.

I did not find you there. I was already there.

Technically plausible. Impossible to verify.

How did you get this email?

It is listed on your channel.

Brooke checked. The address was visible behind a button she had created for film-work inquiries two years ago.

Anna had not demonstrated secret access. She had demonstrated patience with public information, which was what made the message dangerous.

Pack Light

Brooke learned how little of her life fit inside a backpack.

Two shirts. Underwear. Socks. Toothbrush. Charger. Camera batteries. The camera itself wrapped in a sweatshirt Claire had not stolen. Cooper's collapsible water bowl. Cash from the envelope behind her editing manuals. Mark's small flashlight from the garage.

She packed everything beneath a layer of schoolbooks and left the bag where it always sat beside the desk.

The obvious things were too dangerous to take. The framed beach photograph would leave a clean rectangle in the dust. Brooke had the keepsake-box key, but taking the box would leave an obvious gap beneath the bed. Brooke could not take every hard drive without Sarah noticing the empty shelf.

She copied the chemistry folder, observation list, hospital footage, and family recordings onto one external drive, then opened several files on the old laptop to verify the copy. Mark's final voicemail still contained the single word that might have meant home. She left the dated filenames unchanged and slipped a paper inventory beneath the camera-bag lining. She recharged the old phone and left it powered on and connected at home.

Her phone held the diner address, Anna's messages, and every current contact. Brooke turned off location sharing with Sarah, then discovered the family safety app would notify Sarah of the change. She left it on.

Instead she disabled mobile data and practiced turning it back on from the lock screen. The map to the diner was simple enough

to remember. She would use airplane mode after leaving and accept that the gap itself would tell Sarah she had gone.

There was no invisible way out of a family that monitored her for love.

She thought of the stool moved against the wall in chemistry, of the crossing guard whose whole remaining life now fit in two minutes at the bottom of a folder, of her father's voice breaking into squares and then into nothing. Leaving people was how you lost them. She knew that the way she knew her own footage, and she was packing the bag anyway, choosing to be the absence this time, because the alternative was a house where love had learned to lock the doors. She did not know how to dread losing the people she had and plan to leave them in the same hour. The backpack did not get lighter for the trying.

Sarah had decided they were all staying home again.

"The school can manage without you for one day," she had said.

"Yesterday you wanted routine."

"Yesterday a reporter was outside."

"Was he there today?"

"I don't know."

It was the first answer Sarah had given in days that sounded like an admission instead of a door closing. Brooke almost trusted it.

She checked Anna's email again.

Brooke had replied at 1:13 that morning:

What question?

Anna answered at 1:19.

The one about who looked for you.

Brooke had stared at those words until the screen dimmed.

She wrote:

Who are you?

Anna replied:

Someone who watched every second you asked people to watch.

A second message arrived a minute later.

That sounded less strange before I sent it. I mean your public videos.

True, if she meant the videos. Intimate anyway.

Brooke asked why the diner.

It is public. You can sit near the door. You can leave whenever you want.

No heart. No *please*. No attempt to make refusal cruel.

Brooke had not answered again.

At noon she took Cooper into her room and closed the door. He settled on the rug without scratching to leave. Across the hall, Claire's floorboards creaked once, then stopped.

Brooke opened the window.

Cold air pushed the curtain inward. The porch roof sat below at a shallow angle, dark shingles damp from the morning mist. She had climbed onto it once when she was twelve because Claire had locked them out of the upstairs bathroom and Brooke wanted to prove the windows connected.

Mark had caught her halfway across.

If you break your neck, your mother will kill me before the fall does, he had said.

He had shown her where to place her feet while helping her back through the window.

Brooke set one boot on the sill. Cooper stood immediately.

"Stay."

He whined.

"I'm checking."

She leaned out far enough to see the porch edge and the maple tree beyond it. The garage roof over the rear addition was lower, and its slope ended near the wooden trellis. Cooper could not follow either route without help.

A metallic scrape sounded beneath her.

She froze with one hand on the sill.

The sound came again from the garage. A heavy latch, then metal sliding over metal.

Mark's gun safe.

Brooke stepped back inside.

Sarah appeared in the driveway below carrying a box of old installer paperwork from the garage. She set it on the hood of the

car and began sorting. Beyond her, the safe remained bolted beside the file cabinet, exactly where Mark had installed it.

The sound had been the metal file cabinet beside the safe, not the safe itself.

Brooke closed the window. Her pulse did not slow.

She started to add the route to the observation file, then erased it. If Sarah searched the laptop, Brooke would be writing her own instructions for capture. She memorized the sequence instead: window latch, roof angle, trellis, fence gate, back road.

Brooke checked Cooper's harness and packed the collapsible bowl beside two sealed water bottles. He watched every item disappear into the bag and began panting although the room was cold.

"We're not going anywhere," Brooke told him.

His ears moved toward the door.

The lie sounded worse aloud. Brooke crouched and pressed her forehead to his. "I don't know where we're going."

Cooper licked her chin and sneezed.

She added a small towel, antiseptic wipes, and the roll of gauze Sarah kept in the upstairs bathroom. The items made the backpack heavier and the plan more real.

At three, Sarah stopped at Brooke's doorway, not entering farther.

"The keypad company is sending someone Monday morning," she said.

It was Thursday.

"We can't wait until Monday."

"We are home all weekend."

"That's what I'm afraid of."

Sarah's expression shifted, but she did not reach for her. "I know you believe that."

She left the door open behind her.

Brooke locked the keepsake box and put the key in the backpack.

The original letter was still inside. She considered taking it, then imagined Sarah finding the empty envelope. She photographed every page instead. The handwriting looked more personal through the camera than it did in her hands.

The woman who wrote it had said she hoped Brooke would grow up somewhere safe. She had not promised to return. She had not asked to be forgiven. The letter was an explanation shaped like an absence.

Brooke opened a message to Mark.

I don't know if you're getting these. Mom and Claire are both wrong. Someone came into the house. My journal is gone. If you are still you, call me and don't ask Mom first.

She did not send it. If Mark had changed, the message told him she planned to leave. If he had not, it might be the last cruel thing she ever sent him.

She saved it as a draft.

She recorded one version instead.

"Dad, I'm leaving the house tonight. I'm taking Cooper. The evidence drive is with me. I tried calling you."

The recording sounded like a note police would play after something terrible happened. She deleted it.

In the end, she left the unsent text exactly as it was. Uncertainty was not a reason to leave no record. It was also not permission to tell a possibly changed father how to find her.

At dinner Sarah served roasted vegetables over rice.

The news played quietly from the living room. A banner advised residents to remain with household members through the weekend because temporary service disruptions could delay transportation and emergency response. Ashcroft's emergency order also placed minors under an eleven o'clock curfew while staffing remained reduced.

"Convenient," Brooke said.

Sarah put down her fork. "It is an advisory."

"It tells everybody to stay home."

"It says emergency response may be delayed."

Claire looked between them. "We could watch the beach videos tonight."

Brooke's fork stopped.

"Why those?"

"They make you less mad."

"No, they make me sad."

Claire considered this. "Sometimes those look the same."

Sarah reached for Claire's hand. Claire took it.
Brooke went upstairs before dinner was finished.
At eight forty, Anna sent one more message.

If you do not come, I will understand.

Brooke waited for a second line. Nothing arrived.

She imagined the diner: glass windows, two exits, people at nearby tables. She imagined a woman who knew the real name at the bottom of the letter. She imagined Sarah discovering the backpack before Brooke learned whether the only person offering her a choice was real.

At nine, Brooke put Cooper's leash beneath the top flap of the bag. She placed shoes beside the window and loosened the screen.

Cooper lay down on her side of the closed bedroom door.

Claire stopped in the hall.

"Good night," she said.

Brooke did not answer.

After a moment, Claire went away.

Brooke rested her hand against the door above Cooper's head and listened to the house she planned to leave.

Downstairs, the television anchor repeated the weekend advisory. Sarah lowered the volume. Claire asked whether Brooke was still angry.

"She needs time," Sarah said.

"How much?"

"Let her choose."

The phrase was soft enough that Brooke might have imagined it through the floor and walls.

Claire answered, "Okay."

Neither came upstairs.

Brooke sat beside the packed bag and understood that space could become another way of guiding her. She checked Anna's last message again.

If you do not come, I will understand.

Every person in the house had finally learned to wait.

CHAPTER 24

Outside

Brooke left through the front door.

The choice felt reckless after the backpack, the loosened screen, and the route mapped over the porch roof. It was also the only exit that did not announce escape.

Sarah was in the garage sorting the installer papers. Claire had fallen asleep on the couch with one hand hanging toward the rug. Cooper lay several feet away near the foyer and opened his eyes when Brooke crossed it.

Brooke put one finger to her lips.

Cooper stood anyway.

She could not leave him in the house with both of them, and she could not take him into a diner without making herself easier to find. She clipped on his leash.

The keypad chirped when the door closed behind them.

Brooke waited on the porch for Sarah to call her name. Nothing happened.

She walked toward the back road instead of the town center, keeping to streets with dark yards and parked cars. Cooper moved quickly but checked behind them every few houses.

The town was not empty. A grocery store near the green remained open. People carried takeout. A bus sighed at the curb with six passengers sitting in three close pairs. Church bells marked ten o'clock as if the week had earned an ordinary Friday night.

The diner windows glowed at the corner.

Brooke stopped across the street.

Anna sat alone in a booth near the front, exactly where someone would sit after promising Brooke the door.

Her hair was different from the dog park. Darker, or perhaps only styled with a side part that made her face look narrower. She wore a soft blue cardigan and a small oval pendant. None of it should have meant anything.

Brooke had seen that shade of blue in the photograph inside the adoption folder.

Cooper stared through the glass. His tail stayed low, but he did not growl.

Anna looked up. She did not wave.

Brooke crossed the street. Before entering, she started an audio recording and put the phone in her coat pocket with the microphone exposed.

She sent the automatic filename to the old phone at home before switching off mobile data. The file itself had not uploaded, only the name and start time. If Brooke disappeared, the record would show where the conversation began.

The waitress objected to Cooper until Anna asked whether the patio could be opened. The outdoor tables had been stacked for the season, but the waitress relented when Brooke said they would sit near the gate. Anna carried her own coffee outside. The cup tipped against the doorframe and coffee ran over her thumb.

"Sorry," Anna said, irritated with herself. She wiped her hand with a paper napkin and left a brown crescent on the cuff of the blue cardigan. She did not take Brooke's leash or pull out her chair.

"You came," Anna said.

"You gave me an address."

"Yes."

"That's not the same thing."

"No."

Brooke chose the chair closest to the sidewalk. Cooper sat beneath it, body angled toward Anna.

Anna looked at him. "Hello again."

His ears shifted.

"Don't touch him," Brooke said.

"I won't."

Anna folded both hands around the coffee cup.

Up close, the resemblance was less convincing and harder to dismiss. The eyebrow shape. The angle of her head when she listened. The pendant, almost like the one worn by the young woman in Sarah's photograph.

Brooke hated herself for cataloging it.

"How do you know what question I've been asking?"

"You told everyone."

"Not her name."

"No."

The answer sat between them.

"What is it?" Brooke asked.

"The name you copied into the journal."

Brooke said the full name from the bottom of the letter.

"Yes."

Brooke's hand tightened around Cooper's leash.

The street sounds receded. A car passed. Inside the diner, a server laughed too loudly at something near the counter.

"Where did you hear that?"

"From something written for you."

Brooke thought of the letter inside the locked box. She thought of the missing journal where she had copied the name and parts of the letter as a child, practicing the letters until they looked like they belonged to her.

"My journal."

Anna did not answer.

"Were you in my house?"

"You should ask every question you need to ask."

"That isn't an answer."

"No."

Brooke took out her phone and set it faceup between them. The recording timer advanced.

"I'm recording."

Anna looked at the screen. "Yes."

"You knew before I said."

"Your hand stayed in your pocket until you sat down. The microphone was uncovered."

Brooke had believed she was being subtle. "Do you want me to stop?"

"No."

"Why not?"

"Because you should have your own record."

Anna's answer appealed to the deepest habit Brooke had. That did not make it false.

Brooke pushed her chair back an inch.

Anna did not move. "You can leave."

"You know my mother's name."

"Yes."

"You know what she wrote."

"I know what she wanted you to know."

"Did she send you?"

"No."

The direct denial struck harder than a comforting answer would have.

Brooke looked at Anna's face again, searching for something inherited rather than assembled. "Are you Evelyn?"

Anna's expression changed. Not guilt. Something quieter.

"You want me to say yes."

"Are you?"

"I came because of you."

Brooke heard the evasion and filled it with hope anyway.

"Why now?"

"Because now I knew where to find you."

"You watched the videos."

"Every second."

"And before that?"

Anna looked down at her coffee. "I did not understand before."

Brooke felt the words enter the empty place her biological mother had occupied for years. Regret. Shame. A woman too frightened or too broken to return until she saw the daughter she had lost speaking to strangers online.

There were other meanings. Brooke could still see them if she tried.

"You should not trust me because you want this to be true," Anna said.

It was exactly what a safe person would say.

"Sarah is my mother."

"Yes."

No jealousy. No correction.

"I love her."

"I know."

"Even now."

"Especially now."

Brooke looked away because the answer was too kind.

Anna waited.

"What was in the letter?" Brooke asked.

Anna's attention returned to her. "An explanation that did not explain enough."

"That's my opinion."

"Yes."

"You read my journal."

Anna looked down at the stained cuff.

"Say you didn't."

"I will not say something because it would comfort you."

The sentence avoided the accusation. It also sounded principled enough to make avoidance feel like care.

"What did I write about Sarah?"

"Things written in anger do not always describe the person who caused it."

Brooke remembered entire pages composed after arguments, pages Anna could have read in the house. She also remembered saying nearly the same thing publicly after the workshop video. Every private answer had a public source close enough to preserve doubt.

No questions about where Brooke lived. No demand to see the letter. No request for forgiveness. She let silence remain silence instead of turning it into pressure.

"Why did you leave me?" Brooke asked.

Anna's fingers tightened slightly around the cup.

"I cannot give you the answer you deserve."

The sentence was not an explanation. Brooke heard it as one.

"Did you ever try?" Brooke asked.

Anna waited before answering. "I tried to understand what would make you listen."

Brooke heard shame in the pause because shame was what she needed. "You could have written."

"You receive messages from strangers every minute."

"You could have used her name."

“Then you would have known I had information. You would not have known what it meant.”

The distinction sounded like the careful reasoning of someone who had rehearsed this meeting for years. It could also belong to someone who had spent days studying Brooke’s distrust.

“What did I look like as a baby?”

Anna’s gaze moved over Brooke’s face. “Small.”

Brooke almost laughed. “That’s nothing.”

“Angry in one photograph. Asleep in another. There was a yellow blanket.”

“What hospital?”

“I do not know.”

“What time was I born?”

“I do not know.”

“What did she call me?”

Anna’s fingers tightened around the paper cup. “A name that was changed.”

Brooke had never shown the baby photographs online. The original name appeared on the letter and amended records, but Anna had not said it. Brooke kept asking until she reached the edge of the materials in the keepsake box. Anna knew the biological mother’s full name, the yellow blanket, and the copied letter. She did not know the delivery room, the weather, or whether Brooke had cried immediately.

Those gaps should have disproved the story Brooke wanted. Instead they resembled trauma. Seventeen years was enough time to forget details. Shame was enough reason not to volunteer them.

Cooper rose and pressed his shoulder against Brooke’s shin. Anna watched him, then looked toward the diner window. A girl eating alone had glanced up from her phone and seemed to recognize Brooke.

“You should go,” Anna said.

Brooke almost laughed. “You asked me here.”

“And you came. You do not owe me anything else.”

“Will I see you again?”

Anna’s gaze returned to her. “If you choose to.”

Brooke stood. She wanted Anna to stop her. The fact that Anna did not made Brooke want to stay.

“What do you want from me?” Brooke asked.

Anna's expression became uncertain for the first time. "To know you are safe."

"That's what Sarah says."

"Then she wants something good."

"She locks doors."

"Wanting something good does not make every way of getting it good."

The answer gave Brooke permission to love Sarah and fear her at once. No adult had offered her both truths without trying to choose one.

"And your way?"

"You decide."

Anna said it quietly, without satisfaction.

"I don't know what to call you," Brooke said.

"Anna is true."

Another careful sentence.

Brooke led Cooper through the patio gate. When she looked back, Anna remained seated with both hands around the cup.

She had not asked for a hug.

At the corner, Brooke stopped the audio recording. Anna's voice and Brooke's questions were clear. The file proved that Anna knew the biological mother's name and refused to answer whether she entered the house. It did not prove who Anna was.

Brooke copied the file to the camera card through the short adapter in her bag. The transfer consumed another three percent of the phone battery. She kept both copies.

Across the street, a man beneath the pharmacy awning glanced at her, then returned to his phone. The waitress came outside carrying a bus tub and noticed Brooke standing alone with Cooper.

"Are you all right?" the waitress called.

"Fine."

"You're out late."

"My mom knows."

The words came automatically. They were also a lie.

A girl who had been eating alone came through the diner door behind the waitress. "That's Brooke Bennett," she said. "From the videos."

The waitress's concern sharpened. "The missing girl?"

"I'm not missing."

Cooper gave a low warning.

Brooke shortened the leash and kept walking.

The girl followed as far as the corner. "I can walk with you."

"No, thanks."

"You shouldn't be alone."

Brooke looked back toward the patio.

Anna was inside at the register, paying the bill. She met Brooke's eyes through the glass and did not come out.

Brooke turned onto the darker road toward home. Footsteps followed at an unhurried distance.

The girl from the diner was following her.

CHAPTER 25

Contact

The girl followed Brooke for two blocks before calling her name.

“Brooke, wait.”

Brooke kept walking. Cooper looked back, ears flat.

“I just want to make sure you get home.”

“I don’t need help.”

“Your family reported you missing.”

That explained the recognition without making it less frightening. Brooke took out her phone. The audio from the diner had saved. She started a new video and held the camera low, catching the sidewalk and Cooper’s moving legs.

The missing-minor bulletin appeared when she searched her name. Sarah had supplied a school photograph from the previous fall, Brooke’s coat, Cooper’s description, and a warning that Brooke might avoid assistance because of “acute stress related to online harassment.”

Nothing in it was a lie.

It made every refusal sound like a symptom.

“I’m on Birch heading toward Weller,” she said. “A girl from the diner is following me after I told her to stop.”

“You don’t have to make me sound bad,” the girl said.

Brooke crossed the road. The girl crossed too.

A sedan slowed beside them. The driver rolled down her window.

“Everything okay?”

“She needs to get home,” the girl said.

“I am going home.”

It was the first time Brooke had admitted the destination. Anna had offered a future Brooke wanted, then let her walk away alone. The house was dangerous, but it had water, chargers, the window route, and a mother whose need to have Brooke home might still make her open the door.

The driver looked at the dog, Brooke's backpack, and the phone recording. "Do you want a ride?"

"No."

"Her mother reported her missing," the girl said.

The driver unlocked the doors. "Then I'll call the police."

Brooke ran.

The girl followed for half a block, then stopped. She shouted that Brooke was heading toward Weller. The sedan remained at the curb while its driver made the call.

By the time Brooke reached the gas station, nobody was directly behind her. She went inside because Cooper was panting and her phone battery had dropped below twenty percent.

Two employees stood behind the counter. The younger one, a woman with a silver nose ring and MAYA on her name tag, was restocking cigarettes. The other came around the counter when Brooke asked to use an outlet.

"You okay?" he asked. His tag said DEVON.

"I need to charge my phone and get water for my dog."

Maya looked at Cooper. "There's a bowl in the stockroom."

Before Brooke could thank her, the girl from the diner appeared outside with the sedan driver. They had not tracked Brooke through the dark. They had driven the obvious road after she was seen running toward Weller.

"That's her," the driver said through the glass.

Brooke moved away from the window. "Don't let them in."

Devon looked from her to the people outside. "Do you know them?"

"No."

The driver entered first. "Her mother reported her missing. Police are looking for her."

"I am not in danger from being outside," Brooke said. "I am in danger from people trying to return me."

Maya stopped restocking.

The girl entered behind the driver. "She thinks everyone is against her."

"You followed me."

"Because you were alone."

Devon nodded slowly. "Okay. Everybody calm down."

Brooke set her phone against a display and kept recording. "I'm at the SunMart on Weller Road. I told both of them not to follow me."

"You can record," Devon said. "That's fine."

He moved between Brooke and the entrance, not threatening her, only making the exit less available.

"Call the police," the driver said.

"Don't," Brooke said.

Devon reached for the store phone.

Maya came around the counter with a plastic bowl and set it near Cooper. "Stockroom outlet works faster," she said.

Brooke looked at her.

Maya's face gave nothing away. "Back wall."

Brooke took the phone and Cooper's leash. Devon was explaining the situation to dispatch while the girl watched Brooke cross the store.

In the stockroom, Maya plugged Brooke's charger into an outlet beside the delivery schedule.

"The rear door alarms," she whispered. "It still opens."

"Why are you helping me?"

"Because you said no."

It was the first uncomplicated answer Brooke had heard in days.

Maya glanced toward the swinging stockroom door. "Do you have somewhere safe?"

"No."

"Someone who isn't family?"

Brooke thought of Nora, then of Sarah calling Nora's parents before Brooke reached the porch. "No."

"Shelter line?"

"They'll ask my age and call police."

Maya nodded. She did not tell Brooke she was wrong. "Then charge as much as you can."

Brooke used the minute to send the diner audio and her newest video to a new draft email without a recipient. The attachments reached sixty percent before voices rose in the store.

She canceled the upload. A partial cloud transfer was worse than a local file she controlled. The phone battery showed twenty-two percent.

Maya filled a bottle from the utility sink and gave it to her. "Go when I drop the cartons."

"They'll ask which way."

"I'll tell them the road."

Brooke's phone reached twenty-two percent before a stack of flattened boxes crashed in the store. Devon swore. The girl turned toward the sound.

Brooke pushed through the rear door with Cooper. The alarm screamed.

She ran along the service alley toward the drainage path. Her phone continued recording for another seventeen seconds before she stopped it and confirmed the file had saved locally.

Only then did she realize the backpack was gone.

She had left it beside the outlet near the front counter. The camera, external drive, cash, photographs of the letter, and Mark's flashlight were inside.

Brooke almost went back.

The rear door opened. The girl from the diner stepped into the alley holding the backpack against her chest. Blood marked one palm where she had caught it on the door hardware.

"You forgot this."

She held it out.

"Put it down."

"I brought it to you."

"Put it down and go inside."

The girl looked hurt. "I'm helping."

Maya appeared behind her. "She said put it down."

For a moment neither moved. Then the girl placed the backpack on the pavement, keeping it out of a puddle.

Brooke retrieved it after both women went inside. Nothing was missing.

They did not want her camera or money. They wanted to return her to the people who loved her and could not understand why that might be worse.

Brooke checked the backpack beneath the alley light. The drive remained inside its padded pocket. The camera powered on. The photographs of the biological-mother letter were still on the card. She opened the diner recording and listened to three seconds of Anna saying, *You can leave.*

Evidence could prove that a person had given her permission. It could not prove why.

Brooke followed the drainage path toward the back road. She stopped recording to preserve the battery and zipped the phone into her coat. The diner audio and gas-station video remained on the device.

A police cruiser found her forty minutes later.

It approached without a siren and stopped far enough away that Cooper did not lunge. The officer remained beside the open driver's door.

"Brooke Bennett?"

Her face had been attached to the missing-minor bulletin since Sarah reported her. The town's emergency order kept minors off public streets after eleven because reduced staffing had slowed transport and response. None of the officer's knowledge required anything impossible.

"Your mother wants you home," he said.

"Did she say I was in danger?"

"She said you left without permission and may be experiencing distress."

"I'm not getting in the car."

"I haven't asked you to yet."

That almost made him sound safe.

The sedan driver pulled onto the shoulder behind the cruiser. She pointed through the windshield. "That's her."

The officer glanced back. When he turned toward Brooke again, his patience had changed shape.

"Let's make this easy."

Cooper growled.

Brooke moved toward the wooded shoulder.

"If you run, you're going to get hurt."

“Then don’t chase me.”

The officer took one step.

Brooke ran.

Branches struck her face before her eyes adjusted. The ground dropped sharply beyond the shoulder, and she half slid through wet leaves with Cooper pulling beside her. Behind them the officer shouted her name, then warned that the dog could be hurt.

Brooke hated him for choosing the warning that might work.

She reached a chain-link fence, followed it until she found a place crushed beneath a fallen limb, and pushed the backpack through first. Cooper scrambled over the low metal. His harness caught. Brooke freed it while white light swept the trees behind them.

“Brooke, stop. We can talk.”

The officer had not drawn a weapon. He had not threatened arrest. Every reasonable choice remained available except the one Brooke had asked for.

She climbed the fence and tore her coat on the top wire.

He did not follow far into the woods. She heard him call for another unit and give her direction of travel. That was enough. A porch light came on when she crossed the next yard. A man called that he had seen the missing girl. Later, a delivery driver slowed and asked whether she needed a ride home. None of them coordinated. Each received the same story and made the same reasonable choice.

Brooke changed direction until she no longer knew which road she was paralleling.

The woods were not wilderness. They were drainage strips, back lots, and undeveloped parcels between subdivisions. Brooke crossed roads she recognized from car windows and lost them again behind fences. Wet leaves soaked through her jeans. Thorn branches caught the backpack. Cooper slipped once on a concrete culvert and came up favoring his front paw.

Brooke stopped beneath a highway overpass and checked it by phone light. The pad was scraped but not bleeding heavily. Cooper pulled the paw away when she touched it.

“I know. Sorry.”

She rinsed it with half a bottle of water and wrapped it loosely with gauze from the pack. Cooper stood before she finished, anxious to keep moving.

The phone showed eleven percent. Brooke turned the brightness down until the map was barely visible, memorized the next two turns, and shut it off.

For twenty minutes she followed the sound of traffic without reaching a road. The drainage channel narrowed, forcing her through brush where Cooper could not avoid using the injured paw. Each time he stumbled, Brooke considered carrying him. He weighed more than sixty pounds. She could barely lift the front half of him over fallen branches.

At the edge of a backyard, a motion light exposed them. Brooke froze beside a swing set. A child appeared behind the sliding glass door, then an adult woman joined him. The woman opened the door.

“Are you Brooke?”

Brooke backed toward the trees.

“Your mother is terrified.”

“Please don’t call anyone.”

“Come inside. You can warm up.”

The offer nearly worked. Heat spilled through the open doorway. A blanket lay across the sofa. The child stood pressed against the woman’s hip, watching Brooke with an expression too calm for the hour.

“Can I use your charger outside?”

“Don’t be silly. Come in.”

The woman stepped onto the patio barefoot. Cooper growled.

Brooke returned to the drainage channel. The woman called the police before Brooke reached the trees.

Near three in the morning, Cooper began to limp. Her phone showed six percent. The temperature had dropped, and every public place would recognize her as soon as someone checked the bulletin. A television inside the Hawthorne fire station displayed the Saint Vincent’s family-reunification number. At a twenty-four-hour pharmacy, an employee looked up from beneath a blue *FAMILIES HEAL TOGETHER* poster. Brooke kept walking.

Every lit building offered warmth on the condition that somebody decide where she belonged.

She could not keep running toward nowhere.

Brooke opened the observation file one last time. The phone took several seconds to load it.

Dogs notice first.

They remember everything.

Direct pursuit makes me run.

The list had predicted every danger except exhaustion. It had no instruction for a dog who could no longer keep pace or a body that needed warmth. Evidence could identify a pattern. It could not choose the least terrible door.

She added:

They do not have to coordinate if everyone believes returning you is kindness.

The battery dropped to five percent when she saved.

Home had the charger. The rear window. Her room. Sarah, who might refuse to let her leave but could not bear to keep her outside. Brooke hated that she understood how to use that love.

She turned toward the Bennett development.

The final mile took nearly an hour. She stayed behind fences and crossed the wooded strip instead of using the road. No group followed her. Once she saw blue lights pass at the far end of a street. Once a woman on a porch called, "Brooke?" and Brooke kept moving.

Before dawn, the Bennett roof appeared through the trees.

Her phone held twenty-three messages from Sarah. The last said:

The door is locked. Tell me when you are outside.

No promise that Sarah would open it.

Cooper leaned against Brooke's leg. Somewhere behind them, a car door closed and a person called that they had seen someone in the woods.

Brooke looked at the dark house and started toward it.

You Came Home

The front walk was longer than Brooke remembered.

Her legs shook beneath her. Cooper leaned into the leash instead of pulling, favoring one paw as they crossed the yard. The house remained dark except for the weak yellow light above the front door.

Brooke stepped onto the porch and tried the handle.

Locked.

The window chimes Sarah had installed glowed red along the frames. The chair beneath the inside handle cast a crooked shadow through the sidelight. Sarah had turned the house into the secure place Brooke demanded, only the security faced both directions now.

Cooper lifted the injured paw and leaned against Brooke's shin. She crouched to check the gauze. It had gone dark with water and dirt but held. Her fingers shook too badly to retie it.

She knocked softly. "Mom."

Nothing moved inside.

Her phone showed three percent. She called Sarah.

The ringing came through the door, faint but close. Sarah was standing somewhere in the foyer listening to it.

"Mom, open the door."

The call ended.

Brooke knocked harder. Cooper turned toward the street and gave a low growl. A car had stopped at the corner. Its headlights remained on.

"Please."

Sarah's voice came through the door. "Are you alone?"

"Yes."

It was true for the moment.

"Did anyone touch you?"

"No."

"Where were you?"

"Outside."

"The officer said you met a woman at the diner."

Brooke looked at the dark glass beside the door. She could see only herself and the porch light behind her.

"I met her at the diner."

Silence.

"Who is she?"

"I don't know."

That was also true.

The car at the corner rolled forward. Not fast. Its headlights moved across the neighboring lawns and stopped halfway down the block.

The woman in the first car had been on the porch behind the swing set. Brooke recognized the pale robe beneath her open coat. The second vehicle was the sedan from outside the gas station, or one like it. No group had planned to converge here. Sarah's bulletin and a night of phone calls had simply taught the neighborhood where kindness should deliver Brooke.

"Mom, let me in."

"You left without telling me."

"I know."

"You took Cooper."

"I know."

"The police have been looking for you all night."

"They found me."

"And you ran."

Brooke pressed her forehead to the door. "Yes."

The dead bolt did not move.

Sarah said, "You told strangers I was dangerous. Then you left our house in the middle of the night to meet someone you do not know."

"The officer said people were following you," Sarah continued. "I don't know who you brought to our door. I don't know whether they touched you. I need to know it is safe to open this."

"I'm sorry."

The apology was too quick. Brooke heard it fail.

Cooper's growl deepened. A woman had stepped out of the car. Brooke could not see her face, only the open coat and hands held away from her sides.

"Brooke?" the woman called. "The officer asked us to keep you where you are."

Us. Another car turned onto the street behind the first.

Brooke struck the door with the side of her fist. "Mom."

"You wanted to leave," Sarah said.

"I was scared."

"Of me."

The woman reached the sidewalk. "Nobody is angry with you."

Cooper barked.

Brooke lowered her voice. "Mom, I should have listened."

The words tasted like surrender.

Inside, a floorboard creaked.

"I shouldn't have left," Brooke continued. "I shouldn't have taken Cooper. I made everything worse."

"Why did you go?"

The woman entered the yard.

Brooke looked over her shoulder. "Stop there."

The woman did. "The officer who lost her near Weller asked us to keep her in sight if she came through here."

"Mom, please."

"Why did you go?" Sarah asked again.

Brooke knew the answer Sarah needed. Not truth exactly. A shape made from true pieces.

"Because I thought you didn't understand me."

The porch stayed silent.

"I thought you were trying to keep me because you didn't trust me. I thought leaving would prove I could take care of myself."

Brooke looked at Cooper's lifted paw. "I was wrong."

The words were true in the narrowest possible way. Brooke had been wrong that leaving proved anything. She had been wrong that

evidence could make strangers respect her decision. She had been wrong that outside meant free.

Inside, Sarah heard the version she needed.

The choice in front of her had nothing to do with Sarah being right. The woman was halfway across the yard, another car had stopped at the curb, and Cooper could barely stand on one paw. Brooke could choose the people closing around her or the locked house whose windows and exits she knew. She chose the house.

The second car stopped in front of the house.

Claire's voice came through the door. "Is she there?"

"I'm here," Brooke said.

Something struck the inside of the door. A palm, maybe.

Claire's palm placed flat against the wood.

"I didn't take your journal," Claire said.

Brooke closed her eyes. "I know."

She did not know who took it. She knew Claire had told the truth.

"I'm sorry I searched your room."

The apology she had saved and never sent came out sounding smaller than it had on the screen.

Claire began to cry.

Sarah said, "Tell me why you came back."

The woman in the yard took one step closer. Cooper lunged and Brooke nearly lost the leash.

"Because I need you," Brooke said.

The dead bolt clicked once, then stopped.

Brooke felt Sarah waiting behind it.

"Because you're my mother." Her voice broke on the last word without Brooke having to force it. "I love you. Please let me come home."

The dead bolt turned.

The door opened six inches. Sarah stood behind it in Mark's old sweatshirt, her face pale with exhaustion. Claire pressed against her side.

Sarah's eyes moved over Brooke with a speed that felt like touch: torn coat, wet jeans, backpack, dog, empty hands. She checked the yard after checking Brooke. She was still the mother who counted dangers before allowing relief.

Cooper forced his nose through the opening first.

Sarah looked past Brooke at the people near the sidewalk.

"Come in."

Brooke squeezed through with Cooper and the backpack. Claire reached for her. Brooke let the hug happen because the door was still open and the woman in the yard was moving again.

Sarah shut the door.

The woman knocked immediately. "Mrs. Bennett? An officer asked us to keep her in sight."

Sarah locked the dead bolt. Then the chain. Then she pushed the chair beneath the handle exactly as she had promised.

"She's with her family," Sarah called.

The knocking stopped.

"An officer is coming," the woman said through the door.

"Thank you," Sarah answered. Her voice carried the firm politeness she used with delivery drivers and school secretaries. "We'll wait inside."

Footsteps withdrew across the porch. A car door closed, but the engine remained running at the curb.

Brooke stood in the foyer with Claire's arms around her and Cooper pressed between their legs. For several seconds relief was stronger than fear. The house smelled like coffee, laundry detergent, and the soup Sarah had made two days earlier. The stairs rose toward Brooke's room. Her charger was upstairs. The window was upstairs.

Sarah touched Brooke's wet hair. "You're freezing."

"Cooper's hurt, and I need to charge my phone."

Brooke tried to step toward the stairs. Claire did not let go.

"Claire."

"I missed you."

"I know."

"You were gone all night."

"Let me go upstairs."

Claire's arms tightened.

Sarah touched Claire's shoulder. "Give her room."

Claire released Brooke immediately.

The obedience frightened Brooke more than the grip.

"Thank you," Brooke said.

She took one step toward the stairs. Sarah moved between Brooke and the first riser.

Her expression remained warm. Almost relieved.

"I need my charger," Brooke said.

"After you sleep."

Sarah reached for the backpack. Brooke stepped away.

The front-door handle moved once.

The dead bolt held. The chair held.

Sarah did not look toward the door.

She looked only at Brooke.

"You came home," she said.

Brooke looked at the chain, the chair, and Sarah's bare feet planted between her and the stairs.

"Yes," Brooke said.

Sarah smiled with exhausted tenderness. "I knew you would."

The certainty made Brooke understand that the front-door bargain had not ended anything. It had only taught Sarah which words opened Brooke.

Separation Distress

Brooke made it upstairs by pretending she was too tired to fight.

Sarah followed close enough to catch her if she fell. Claire carried the backpack after Brooke finally let her take it. Cooper climbed the stairs slowly, pausing before each step that required his sore paw.

"Bathroom first," Sarah said. "Then sleep."

"I want my bag."

Claire held it out.

Sarah took it before Brooke could.

"I'll bring it in after you change."

"There are camera batteries in there."

"They'll still be there."

Brooke looked at the hand gripping the strap. "Give it to me." Sarah did.

The immediate surrender made Brooke hesitate. Sarah had learned that obvious resistance gave Brooke something to push against.

"Thank you," Brooke said.

She entered her room with Cooper and closed the door.

Sarah's hand struck the other side before the latch caught.

"Keep it open."

"I'm changing."

"Use the bathroom."

"The bathroom doesn't lock."

No answer came for a second.

"I will keep Claire downstairs," Sarah said.

"I need my room."

"Brooke."

"Five minutes."

Sarah's fingers remained around the edge of the door.

Brooke said, "If you force it, I'll scream."

The fingers disappeared.

Brooke closed and locked the door.

The room showed the evidence of the night's absence. Her loosened screen leaned against the wall. One shoe remained beside the window where she had left it. The old phone on the desk displayed the automatic diner-recording filename she had sent before leaving.

Brooke photographed the closed door, the time, the backpack, and Cooper's wrapped paw. Then she placed the phone where the charger could reach without pulling it from her hand.

She moved before Sarah could reconsider. Desk chair beneath the handle. Low dresser dragged across the carpet and wedged behind it. The sound was loud enough that pretending became impossible.

"Brooke," Sarah said.

Brooke opened the backpack. Camera. External drive. Charger. Cash. The photographs of the letter. Everything still there.

Her phone died as she plugged it in.

"Move the furniture."

Brooke checked the window. It opened. The loosened screen lifted without resistance.

Cooper watched her from the rug.

"Not yet," she whispered.

Sarah knocked once. "You came home because you knew you needed us."

Brooke powered on the camera instead of answering. The battery showed forty-one percent. She set it on the desk facing the door and pressed record.

"It is Saturday morning," she said quietly. "I got home after the police and other people tried to return me. My mother let me in. Now she won't let me leave my room unless I leave the door open."

She gave the date and repeated it once to make sure the numbers were clear. A trustworthy record did not ask exhaustion to remember for her.

"That is not what I said," Sarah called.

Brooke looked at the camera. "She can hear me."

Claire sat down outside the door. Brooke recognized the soft impact against the wall.

"I didn't take your journal," Claire said.

"I believe you."

"Then open the door."

"Those are different things."

Claire began to cry.

Sarah said, "Your sister has been terrified."

"I was terrified too."

"We know. Let us help."

Brooke connected her phone to the charger. One percent. She waited until the emergency-call screen appeared.

The dispatcher answered on the second ring.

"Nine-one-one. What is the address of your emergency?"

Brooke gave the street number before Sarah could hear enough to interfere.

"I'm locked in my bedroom. My mother has been sick and she won't let me leave."

"Is your mother threatening you?"

"She took my things. She's outside the door. My sister is too."

"Are there weapons in the home?"

Brooke looked toward the floor, as though she could see through it to the garage. "A shotgun. It's locked in a safe."

Sarah stopped talking.

The dispatcher said, "Try to remain calm."

"Send someone."

"The weapon is secured?"

"Right now."

Keys clicked beneath the dispatcher's voice. "The calling number and address match an active missing-minor return for Brooke Bennett. Is that you?"

"Yes."

"A unit has been notified. The weapon is still in the safe, correct?"

"Yes. My mother knows the combination."

"Tell me immediately if that changes. Do not antagonize her while you wait."

"She can hear this."

"Then keep your voice low if you can."

Brooke gripped the phone. "No, it isn't."

More keys. Then the dispatcher read in the flattened cadence of words supplied by a screen. "The return notes say the missing minor may resist reunification because of separation distress. Staying in a secured room is the safest immediate option while the weapon remains locked."

The words matched the school handout.

"I am already inside."

"Good. Remain where you are."

"She is trying to get through the door."

Sarah had gone completely silent.

"Do not make any sudden attempt to leave while she is at the door."

Brooke stopped breathing. Her name had not come from recognition. It had arrived with the address, phone, and return file. The system had explained exactly how it knew her and made the knowledge worse.

"Officers are managing multiple family-reunification calls," the dispatcher said. "Your report is currently coded as a welfare return with a secured weapon. If the safe is opened or the weapon is moved, call back immediately and say that first."

"You didn't send anyone."

"A unit is pending."

"Is one coming?"

A pause.

"Reduced staffing has extended response times. Remain in the secured room and call back if the weapon status changes."

The dispatcher told her she could disconnect to preserve the phone battery. Brooke ended the call.

Brooke stared at the screen. Two percent battery.

The call log listed 911 and the duration. Brooke took a screenshot before the phone could die again. She held the screen toward the camera and repeated the dispatcher's phrases while they were fresh: separation distress, welfare return, secured weapon, unit pending. The words sounded less frightening without the dispatcher's calm voice. Brooke saved them anyway.

Outside the door, Claire whispered, "They said to stay."

"You heard one side of it."

"I heard enough."

Brooke returned to the camera.

"If you're seeing this," she began, then stopped.

The sentence sounded like an ending. She was not ready to give the day one.

She started again.

"The police know who I am. The dispatcher knew before I told her. They are not coming. If somebody in your house got sick and recovered, don't let the word recovered make the decision for you. Don't wait for them to look wrong."

Her voice shook. She left it in.

"They remember you. They love you. That doesn't mean they will let you leave."

Brooke saved the recording without uploading it. There was no time to check metadata, remove the address, or decide whether posting would lead more people to the house.

Sarah scratched one fingernail down the door.

"I am trying very hard not to frighten you," she said.

"Then go downstairs."

"You came back because outside was dangerous."

"You are dangerous."

The scratching stopped.

Claire said, "Don't say that."

"It's true."

Sarah's voice changed. Not louder. Less careful.

"After everything I have done to keep you safe."

"You canceled the workshop. You took my key. You reported me missing."

"Because you needed me."

"Because you needed me here."

"Because I know what happens when nobody is there," Sarah said. "Your father disappears. Strangers find your school. People follow you through the dark. You come home bleeding and freezing. Every time I let you prove you can handle something alone, somebody hurts you."

"You canceled the one thing that could help me leave."

"I canceled a workshop."

"You made it a rule. Then the school made it a rule. Then the police made it a rule."

"I am not the police."

"You use the same words."

Sarah's hand struck the door once, not hard enough to break it. "Because the words are true."

The door moved inward half an inch. The chair legs scraped.

Brooke shoved the dresser harder against it.

Claire began pleading. "Just let me hug you. One time. I won't hold too hard."

"No."

"I promise."

"You can't promise that."

Claire's hand appeared beneath the door, fingers searching across the carpet. Cooper approached, sniffed, then backed away.

Claire withdrew her hand before he could growl.

The pressure against the door increased. Wood complained around the latch.

Brooke picked up the camera, the external drive, and the phone. She put them in the backpack and pulled the straps tight.

"Mom, if you come through that door, I'm going out the window."

The pressure stopped.

Sarah said, "You will fall."

"Then don't come through."

"You could break your neck."

"Then stay out."

For a moment, nobody moved.

Sarah began to cry.

The sound was the same as every exhausted, frightened cry Brooke had heard through childhood walls. Brooke pictured Sarah sitting on the hall carpet, one hand over her mouth, trying not to make the girls worry.

"I don't know how to help you anymore," Sarah said.

Brooke pressed both hands to her eyes.

"Let me leave."

"I can't."

The honesty hurt worse than another plea.

"Why?"

“Because I love you.”

Brooke sat with her back against the dresser. On the other side, Sarah lowered herself too. Brooke heard fabric slide down the wood.

“You are my mother,” Brooke said.

Sarah drew a breath.

“I meant what I said outside. I love you.”

“Then open the door.”

“Love isn’t the door.”

The sentence sounded like something Brooke would edit out for being too neat. Sarah began to cry harder.

“It is for me,” she said.

Brooke lowered her hands.

The hall went quiet.

Not the quiet of waiting. The quiet of absence.

“Mom?”

No answer.

Claire was gone too.

Brooke waited beside the window. One minute. Two. The house settled around her. Pipes clicked. A vehicle passed on the street.

Maybe Sarah had listened. Maybe the last honest answer had broken something open.

Then metal struck metal in the garage.

Brooke knew the sound because she had mistaken the file cabinet for it two days earlier.

The safe door.

Brooke looked toward the backpack. The camera’s red recording light remained visible through the partly open zipper. She said what she knew without claiming more.

“The safe is in the attached garage. Dad showed Mom the combination for emergencies. The shotgun was secured when I called. I think she is opening it now.”

She checked the phone. Four percent. No missed call from police. No approaching siren.

Mark had shown Sarah the electronic combination when he bought the safe. If the alarm failed or he was hurt, she was supposed to know how to reach the twelve-gauge pump shotgun inside. Brooke had watched him make Sarah enter the numbers twice.

She lifted the window.

“Cooper.”

He came to her despite the bad paw.

Brooke removed the screen and pushed the backpack onto the porch roof. Cold air filled the room. She climbed onto the sill and lowered one foot to the shingles.

Footsteps reached the stairs.

Sarah was coming back.

Brooke climbed out and turned to Cooper. “Come.”

He put his front paws on the sill, then recoiled from the drop.

The bedroom doorknob turned.

“Brooke,” Sarah called. “Move away from the window.”

Brooke dialed 911 again and put the call on speaker while she pulled Cooper toward the sill.

“Weapon out of the safe,” she said as soon as a new dispatcher answered. “My mother has the shotgun in the hall.”

The second voice sharpened. “I am upgrading the call. Stay away from the door. If you have a safe exit that does not take you toward her, use it now.”

Brooke pushed the phone into her coat pocket without ending the call.

Brooke grabbed Cooper’s harness and guided his front legs over the sill. He scrambled, nails striking wood, and Brooke pulled until his weight carried him onto the roof beside her.

The door shuddered.

“I don’t want to hurt you,” Sarah said. “Stay below the window. I only need the latch.”

Brooke heard Sarah order Claire downstairs. Claire protested once, then her footsteps retreated toward the landing.

Brooke crouched outside below the window line, one hand locked in Cooper’s harness. From the hall, Sarah could hear the open window and the scrape of Cooper’s nails. She knew Brooke was no longer standing where she had been, but she could not know exactly where Brooke’s body ended beyond the wall.

“I’m opening it,” Sarah said.

The shotgun fired.

The blast carved a low diagonal path through the latch-side jamb, lock metal, and the front corner of the dresser. Pellets struck

the floor and side wall. The chair overturned. The damaged door kicked inward against the barricade.

Brooke could not see Sarah or the barrel through the wall. She knew only the path the shot left through opaque wood. Sarah had fired without a view of where Brooke was beyond it.

Powdered drywall blew through the open window with the bitter smell of burned propellant. A lamp crashed inside. In the backpack on the roof, the camera continued recording darkness, the gunshot, Brooke's breath, and the dispatcher saying that shots had been fired and the call was now priority.

Cooper tried to bolt down the roof. Brooke held him until the echo left the air.

Downstairs, Claire screamed.

Sarah said, "Brooke?"

The fear in her voice was real.

Brooke moved.

She slid down the wet shingles with Cooper beside her, caught the gutter, and lowered herself toward the porch railing. Her boots struck wood. Cooper jumped past her into the flower bed and yelped when his sore paw landed.

Brooke dropped after him.

The upstairs window opened wider behind them.

"Brooke, wait."

She ran through the side gate and into the street.

The backpack struck her spine with every step. The camera inside was still recording. Her phone, external drive, diner audio, gas-station video, and photographs remained with her. For once the evidence and the person who made it escaped together.

A car alarm began shrieking two houses away. Porch lights came on. A man opened his front door, saw Sarah in the upstairs window with the shotgun, and disappeared inside with his phone already raised.

No siren came. No cruiser turned the corner. The house remained lit behind Brooke, warm in every window.

Brooke ran until the second gunshot she expected never came. Then headlights switched on ahead.

Headlights

The car waited at the curb with the engine running.

Brooke slowed only because Cooper did. He stood in the road, chest heaving, watching the dark sedan as if he remembered it.

The passenger window lowered.

Anna sat behind the wheel.

She wore the same blue cardigan from the diner. A brown coffee stain marked one cuff.

She looked imperfectly prepared. The cardigan was wrinkled. An empty paper cup sat in the console. Her hair had fallen loose from the style Brooke had noticed at the diner. If she had been waiting all night, the waiting had cost her something visible.

“Brooke.”

Brooke looked behind her. Sarah had reached the front yard. She was barefoot, still holding the shotgun angled toward the ground.

“Come back,” Sarah called.

Anna did not tell Brooke to get in.

She reached across the console and opened the passenger door. Then she waited.

Cooper growled once. Not the wild alarm he gave Sarah. A low, uncertain warning that ended when Anna kept both hands visible.

“I won’t touch him,” Anna said.

The same promise as the diner.

Brooke reached the car.

“How are you here?”

“I stayed after you left the diner.”

“Where?”

“On Hawthorne. Two streets over.” Anna hesitated. “I heard the shot.”

“You followed me.”

“I followed the roads after other people followed you. Then I stopped.”

“Why Hawthorne?”

“It connects the town center to your neighborhood without passing the front of your house.”

Brooke knew the route. It was the same road she used when filming long walks with Cooper. Anna could have learned it from those videos, a map, or prior surveillance. The answer explained location without innocence.

The answer should have frightened her.

Sarah stepped into the street. “Brooke, you do not know her.”

Behind Sarah, Claire stood on the porch crying. The ruined bedroom door was somewhere above her. The 911 dispatcher had told Brooke to remain with her family. The police had found Brooke outside and tried to return her. Every official door led back to the same house.

The open passenger door asked nothing.

“Where are you going?” Brooke asked.

“Somewhere quiet.”

“Can Cooper come?”

“Yes.”

Anna did not reach for his leash.

Sarah came closer. “It isn’t safe out here.”

It was true. Brooke climbed into the car anyway.

She pulled the seat forward and Cooper climbed into the back, dragging the sore paw. He turned twice without lying down.

Brooke closed the passenger door herself.

Anna drove.

Brooke kept one hand on the door handle until the house disappeared. The lock was mechanical. She tested it once. It opened.

Anna heard the click. “You can leave it unlocked.”

She did not activate the child lock or ask Brooke to stop. Brooke closed the door again because cold air rushed through the seal.

Sarah reached the car too late. Her palm struck the rear window once, then slid away. Anna did not accelerate hard or swerve. She turned onto the back road with both hands steady on the wheel.

In the side mirror, Sarah ran toward the driveway. The garage light came on before the trees hid the house.

Brooke watched the Bennett house shrink in the side mirror.

Claire remained on the porch. Sarah stood in the street. The shotgun was no longer visible. For one second they looked like a mother and daughter watching someone leave for an ordinary trip.

Then the trees hid them.

Far behind, a siren rose on another road. It had come after the shot, after the neighbor saw the gun, after Brooke was already in a stranger's car. Whether it was finally coming for the Bennett house or passing toward another emergency, Brooke could not tell.

Brooke's phone vibrated.

It isn't safe out there. Come home.

She read the message twice.

Sarah did not say Anna was dangerous. She did not say the house was safe. She had built the plea from two true statements and left Brooke to connect them.

Brooke turned the phone facedown.

Anna kept her eyes on the road.

"Are you going to ask what happened?"

"You can tell me if you want."

"My mother shot through my door."

Anna's hands tightened on the wheel. "Were you hit?"

"No."

"Is Cooper bleeding?"

"I don't think so."

"There is water behind your seat."

Brooke found two sealed bottles, a folded towel, and a paper pharmacy bag holding gauze and antiseptic spray. She poured water into Cooper's collapsible bowl. Anna had not known Brooke would still have it. She had prepared for a dog anyway.

"You knew I was going to run," Brooke said.

"I knew you might."

"How?"

“You told me what happens when people push you.”

The supplies were ordinary enough to belong in any careful driver’s car: drugstore first-aid kit, old towel, bottled water, flashlight. The gauze package had already been opened. Anna said she had used some on her own hand after the coffee burn blistered.

Brooke checked the burn. A pink crescent crossed Anna’s thumb. It made the diner spill feel less like a planted imperfection and more like a mistake that continued after Brooke stopped watching.

Brooke had told everyone.

“Did you take my journal?”

Anna’s eyes stayed on the road.

“I know why you are asking.”

“That isn’t an answer.”

“No. It isn’t.”

For the first time, Anna sounded frustrated. The single word came too quickly, aimed at Brooke’s accusation about the answer rather than the question beneath it. She breathed in through her nose.

“I should have answered differently.”

“Answer now.”

Anna’s jaw tightened. “You are hurt and exhausted.”

“That’s true. You’re avoiding it.”

“Yes.”

“Did you take it?”

Anna looked ahead. “If I answer the wrong question, you will hear what you need instead of what I say.”

“Then answer the right one.”

“I do not know which question that is yet.”

Each sentence preserved the possibility Brooke feared without confirming it. Brooke reached for the door handle again.

Anna slowed and pulled onto the shoulder.

“If you want to get out, I will stop,” she said.

Brooke looked back. The road behind them was empty, but Ashcroft remained only minutes away. Police had her description. Sarah had a gun. Cooper could barely walk.

“Keep driving,” Brooke said.

Anna did.

Brooke looked at the dark profile she had wanted to resemble. Anna had been near the house. Anna knew private words. Anna had waited within hearing distance of the shotgun.

Brooke did not forget any of it. She measured it against Sarah firing through the bedroom door, police returning her to that house, and Cooper's scraped paw trembling on the back seat.

She wet the towel and cleaned dirt from Cooper's paw. The pad was scraped, not split. He watched Anna through the gap between the seats.

"He doesn't trust you."

"He shouldn't yet."

The answer loosened something in Brooke's chest.

Streetlights disappeared as they reached the quieter state road. Dawn had left the sky colorless, but beneath the trees it still felt like night.

"I thought you left me at the diner," Brooke said.

"You asked to leave."

"I didn't ask."

"You stood up."

Brooke remembered Anna staying behind the glass while the girl followed. At the time it had felt like abandonment. Now it looked like respect.

"Were you watching the house?"

Anna took a second too long to answer.

"I was watching for you."

"Why didn't you come to the door?"

"I almost did when the cars stopped outside." Anna rubbed her thumb once across the coffee stain on her cuff. "I thought seeing me might make you run again."

Brooke took out her phone and started an audio recording. She left it facedown in her lap.

"I don't know what happens now."

"You do not have to decide now."

"Where is quiet?"

"There is a motel beyond the county line. It allows dogs. We can stop there, or keep driving."

"Whose name is the room under?"

"Mine."

"Do you have an extra phone?"

“No.”

“Did you tell anyone you were waiting?”

“No.”

Brooke asked whether she could choose a different motel and keep the room key. Anna said yes to both. She never sounded offended by suspicion. Sarah had treated distrust as an injury. Anna treated it as a right.

The car heater warmed Brooke’s wet jeans. Cooper’s breathing slowed behind her.

Anna kept both hands on the wheel. She did not ask Brooke to call her anything. She did not ask for forgiveness or gratitude. She did not touch Brooke.

Brooke thought of the porch, Sarah’s face behind the opening door, Claire’s arms around her, and the gunshot breaking the room where she had once believed a lock meant privacy.

Anna turned into an unlit scenic pull-off and stopped beneath a bare oak. She shifted into park but left the engine and heater running.

Brooke reached across the console.

Anna did not move toward her.

Brooke wrapped both arms around Anna as far as the seat belt allowed and pressed her face against the stained blue shoulder.

For one moment Anna remained perfectly still.

Then she lifted one hand and rested it lightly against Brooke’s back.

No grip. No pull. Only enough pressure to answer.

Brooke closed her eyes.

Anna returned her hand to her lap before Brooke pulled away.

Brooke remained close for one breath after the pressure disappeared. She had not hugged anyone willingly since Claire got sick.

“Try to sleep,” Anna said.

“Where are we going?”

“To the motel first. After that, you decide.”

Anna put the car in gear. Brooke watched the dark road unspool ahead of them.

It was not an answer.

It was enough.

Continue Learning

Brooke slept against the passenger window.

Her phone lay facedown in her lap, the recording still running and Sarah's message unanswered beneath the dark screen. One hand remained curled near the center console, close enough to Anna that the space between them looked accidental. The last image in her camera roll was Claire at the beach, half buried in sand and wearing Brooke's towel.

Cooper did not sleep.

He lay across the back seat with his sore paw extended, head raised whenever the car slowed. The farther they traveled from Ashcroft, the fewer houses appeared along the road. Bare branches crossed the sky. Morning gathered gradually behind them.

Anna drove without the radio.

The motel remained seventeen miles ahead according to the road sign. Anna passed one turnoff without slowing. The final-drive recording continued to collect tire noise, heater fan, Cooper's breathing, and the occasional click of a turn signal.

At a long, empty stretch between intersections, she opened the center console.

The blue journal lay beneath a folded map.

Its cover was worn at the corners. A pale rectangle marked where a sticker had once been. Brooke had searched drawers, accused Claire, and locked the keepsake box around the absence of it.

Anna placed the journal open across her lap while keeping one hand on the wheel.

She had wrapped it in a clear produce bag against moisture. A receipt from an Ashcroft pharmacy marked a page near the middle. The date on the receipt was the day Brooke first found the photograph moved.

She did not begin at the first page.

The copied name appeared near the front in Brooke's childhood handwriting, each letter practiced several times beneath sentences from the original letter. Later pages held questions Brooke had never uploaded. Whether Sarah loved Claire differently. Whether being chosen once could outweigh being left first. Whether recording people was easier because a camera could know her without asking her to trust it.

Anna turned past those.

She stopped at the beach.

Brooke had written the memory years after it happened. Claire was small enough to sit inside the hole they dug in the sand, her knees tucked beneath Brooke's borrowed towel. They had built walls around her and decorated them with shells until the tide reached the first one. Claire had laughed when the water broke through. Brooke had tried to hold the wall together with both hands.

Underneath, in darker ink added later, Brooke had written:

I think safety was believing the water would stop because I asked it to.

Anna read the sentence twice.

On the facing page Brooke had listed things that made a place safe: a door she could close, Cooper nearby, batteries charged, someone who waited for an answer. Two items had been crossed out in later ink.

Anna read those too.

Cooper lifted his head.

His eyes fixed on the journal, then on Anna.

Cooper gave a low, uncertain whine.

Anna looked at him in the mirror.

She did not threaten him. She did not reach back or tell him to be quiet.

She waited.

The car continued along the empty road. Cooper watched her until the tension in his shoulders eased enough for him to lower his head. His eyes remained open.

Anna returned to the page.

Brooke shifted against the window but did not wake.

Anna rested two fingers beneath the sentence about safety, following the handwriting without touching the ink. Then she turned back to the page where Brooke had written that a camera could know her without asking for trust. A folded corner marked it.

The fold was softened from being opened more than once.

Cooper saw it. His nose moved toward the familiar paper, then toward Brooke asleep beyond the front seat. He gave another quiet whine.

Anna waited again.

Outside, the road bent away from Ashcroft.

Anna turned the page and continued learning how to love her.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Jesse Lemery

Jesse Lemery writes stories about family, memory, love, and what hides beneath ordinary life. *The Shape Love Takes* is Book One of an intentionally continuing psychological-horror story.